PRICE $10.99

THE NEW YORKER

APRIL 6, 2026

The New Yorker Magazine

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Goings On

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Goings On

Marie Antoinette-Era Fashion Plates

Also: Daniel Radcliffe stars in "Every Brilliant Thing," Robert Plant sings roots folk in a cathedral, a soulful retrospective of Beuford Smith, and more.

***By** Rachel Syme, Brian Seibert, Zoë Hopkins, Sheldon Pearce, Dan Stahl, Vince Aletti, Richard Brody, **and** Taran Dugal*

March 27, 2026

You're reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we're watching, listening to, and doing this week. ***Sign up to receive it in your inbox.***

It is a fashionable time to visit the Frick. The museum, which is housed inside an ornate Upper East Side mansion that once belonged to the Gilded Age industrialist Henry Clay Frick, reopened last April after a two-hundred-and-twenty-million-dollar renovation effort, a four-year project that greatly expands access to the space and lets in fresh air and shafts of light. This spring, the focus is less on the building itself and more on what one can see inside of it; the museum's current exhibition, "Gainsborough: The Fashion of Portraiture," runs through May 25 and features the work of the eighteenth-century British painter Thomas Gainsborough, a true maverick when it came to rendering clothing on canvas.

A hand-colored engraving designed by Pierre-Thomas Le Clerc and engraved by Nicholas Dupin, from Galerie des Modes et Costumes Français, circa 1779.Art work courtesy the Frick Art Research Library

On April 1, the Frick débuts another new show, **“Ruffles & Ribbons: Fashion Plates from the Time of Marie Antoinette,”** a collection of twenty-four fashion plates, hand-engraved, from the late seventeen-hundreds, pulled from the museum’s Art Research Library. Such engravings, which depict the wackily maximalist style à la mode, including oodles of feathers and furbelows, were, in essence, early precursors to modern fashion magazines. Many of the original French fashion plates, considered passing fancies in their day, have been lost to time, so to see the real specimens up close is a true treat indeed. A perfect Sunday? Take a stroll through the show, sit for a while in the Frick’s serene courtyard, then pop around the corner to Ladurée for a rose macaron.—*Rachel Syme*

About Town

Dance

Nearly fifty now, **Hubbard Street Dance Chicago** has long been, for good or ill, a best-in-class purveyor of trends in contemporary dance. Its latest moves, though, hark back to its roots in the commercial style known as jazz dance. For its two-week run at the Joyce, the company brings a pair of pieces by Bob Fosse: a suite of wryly insouciant TV routines he made for and with his then wife, Gwen Verdon, in the sixties, and "Percussion IV," a 1978 solo of dramatically framed, slam-bang virtuosity that Hubbard Street staged in the nineties. More recent works by Nacho Duato and by Aszure Barton fill out the programs.—*Brian Seibert (Joyce Theatre; through April 5.)*

Art

In the titular film of **Ralph Lemon's** show "From Out of Space," we spend about twenty seconds looking at a funerary hearse covered in fallen branches. Death covers death. We might call this the credo of the exhibition, which includes photographs and videos from Lemon's travels through the American South in the late nineties and early two-thousands and focusses on dilapidated sites marked with histories of anti-Black violence. There is Medgar Evers's home; the decaying storefront of Bryant's Grocery and Meat Market, where Emmett Till allegedly whistled at Carolyn Bryant; the piled-up remnants of a church where Mose Wright (Till's great-uncle) was a pastor. One senses in these images both the passage of time and the piercing stillness of a catastrophe that remains with us.—*Zoë Hopkins (Paula Cooper; through April 11.)*

Roots Folk

Robert Plant and Suzi Dian, of Saving Grace.Photograph by Rick Kern / Getty

Robert Plant will be remembered by most as the enduring voice of the iconic rock band Led Zeppelin, but in the twenty-first century his output has been shaped by smaller collaborations. Backing bands have been key to his solo work during this span, and his twilight career has been defined by a daring, sublime turn toward Americana with Alison Krauss, with whom he won the Grammy for Album of the Year, in 2009. Since 2019, Plant has played with **Saving Grace**, and last year they released their first self-titled album together. It sounds like the singer-songwriter recommitting himself to roots music and its participatory nature, and he invokes the power of both at an uptown Gothic cathedral.—*Sheldon Pearce (Cathedral Church of St. John the Divine; April 7.)*

Broadway

"Every Brilliant Thing" is putatively a solo show performed by Daniel Radcliffe, but its incorporation of the audience—some of whom get recruited as characters—makes it feel bigger. Written by Duncan Macmillan with Jonny Donahoe, the original star, it premièred in the U.K. in 2013 and transferred Off Broadway the following year; now Macmillan co-directs a Broadway revival, with Jeremy Herrin. They send Radcliffe bounding around the stage and into the audience, a savvy deployment of the actor's prodigious energy. The upbeat handling of a serious subject—a boy trying to cheer his suicidal mother and, later in life, himself with a list of things to live for—approaches glibness ("Kazoos!" "Skinny-dipping!"), but the story is redeemed by a poignant refusal to downplay depression's insidious power.—*Dan Stahl (Hudson; through May 24.)*

Art

“Boy on Bus, Harlem” (1965).Photograph by Beuford Smith / Courtesy Keith de Lellis Gallery

Beuford Smith (1936-2025) was a member of the now legendary Black photographers’ collective the Kamoinge Workshop and a founding editor of “The Black Photographers Annual,” a four-volume anthology (1973-1980) essential for anyone interested in the medium’s history. That Smith’s work remains little-known is all the more baffling considering the strength and depth of a retrospective now up at Keith de Lellis. Like Roy DeCarava, Smith worked most effectively in the dark, with silhouetted figures and shadowy spaces. The tonal depth in his prints is rich, dense, and moody—not a void but a presence. A group of small images made in the turmoil and anguish of the day after Martin Luther King, Jr.,’s assassination is the emotional core of the show. In one, a Black man in tears emerges from the darkness, his bared teeth glinting like gold.—*Vince Aletti (Keith de Lellis; through April 16.)*

Movies

The Georgian director Alexandre Koberidze used his old-school cellphone, a Sony Ericsson, to make the three-hour mini-epic **“Dry Leaf,”** which is both an intimate travelogue through his homeland and a metaphysical adventure. In Tbilisi, a teacher named Irakli (David Koberidze, the filmmaker’s father) learns that his twenty-eight-year-old daughter, a sports photographer, has run away while on the road for an assignment—taking pictures of rustic soccer fields—and he sets out in the hope of finding her. His companion, a young man named Levan, is never seen (he’s represented by a voice, and not the only one Irakli talks with). The lo-fi video renders the grand, rugged landscapes in fiercely expressive images that play like cinematic Fauvism, as Irakli’s encounters with country people thrum with memory and mystery.—*Richard Brody (In limited release.)*

Bar Tab

Taran Dugal mingles at a West Village art-salon-cocktail-lounge.

Illustration by Patricia Bolaños

“I like large parties. They’re so intimate,” Jordan Baker says in “The Great Gatsby.” “At small parties there isn’t any privacy.” Baker would probably love **People’s,** a new referral-only cocktail lounge in the West Village. On a recent Saturday, two invitees with a friend on staff walked through the velvet-lined entryway into the parlor, a dimly lit space with a sputtering fireplace. Their first round consisted of the Dove, a delicious spin on a whiskey sour, made with plum, five spice, and Armagnac, and the Kuniyoshi, a sharp mix of mezcal, shochu, vermouth, and pineapple. A cast of ostentatious characters filled the room. Here was a bespectacled man with a stentorian mid-century voice, urging the initiates to try the Calabrian tuna toast (scrumptious), the cheeseburger (heavenly), and the shrimp cocktail (not so much). “I never go out,” he said, with a breathy chortle, “but when I do it’s here.” Next came a real-estate heiress, who, between sips of the Edith (a heady blend of vermouth, sherry, and rum), beckoned one of the guests to the club’s back room. Under a skylight installed by Abby Rockefeller, who helped bankroll the place a century ago, when it was an art gallery, dozens of danced-out revellers rested against a backdrop of white silk curtains and striking art works; the lounge, which bills itself as an “art salon,” encourages patrons to place offers. The guest didn’t hear anyone do that, but he did eventually find his friend, sitting among two painters, a venture capitalist, and an Instagram influencer. By now, the space was packed, and conversation progressed at shouting volumes. The

influencer was headed to a party in Chelsea. Did the guests want to join? They did—and so the three marched into the crowd, elbows against the current, borne forth ceaselessly into the evening.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- *How old is your English?*
- *Ottessa Moshfegh on loneliness*
- *Always more treasures to be found*

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Dan Stahl is a member of The New Yorker's editorial staff.
Vince Aletti is a photography critic and the author of "Issues: A History of Photography in Fashion Magazines."
Richard Brody, a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of "Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard."
Taran Dugal is a member of The New Yorker's editorial staff.

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Photo Booth

China’s Shifting Relationship to the Countryside

Catherine Hyland’s images show what happened after the giant migration to the cities.

By Peter Hessler

March 21, 2026

A bride looks through pictures on her phone at Yunshanping, or Spruce Meadow, in Yunnan Province.Photographs by Catherine Hyland

Most of the way up the Jade Dragon Snow Mountain, which rises to a height of more than eighteen thousand feet, in southwestern China’s Yunnan Province, there is a large alpine field called Yunshanping, or Spruce Meadow, where tourists gather to take photographs. Many of the visitors are couples about to get married. They wear traditional Western wedding clothing, the bride in white and the groom in black, and they are often accompanied by a team of several people. There are photographers and lighting assistants and makeup artists, with each set of professionals clustered around the couple. In October, 2024, when the British photographer Catherine Hyland first travelled to Spruce Meadow, she spent a day documenting the scene. “I found myself surrounded by hundreds and

hundreds of brides and grooms," she told me. "It was the first time I'd seen that many brides in one place."

Hyland shoots with film cameras, in both medium and large formats, and her images of the meadow, often shot from a distance, are different from what Americans or Europeans would expect from mountain tourism. The subjects are clearly not dressed for rugged terrain. Each bride's dress has been billowed out and arranged around her in a circle, and these white figures are scattered at irregular intervals throughout the green field. They could be flowers springing up after a rainstorm, or bits of cloud coming to earth. No trails or roads are visible inside the frame, adding to the mystery of how all these people in formal attire arrived at an elevation of ten thousand six hundred feet. Invariably, they have their backs to the stunning scenery. In one image, a veiled bride sits in front of a shopping bag, staring at her cellphone, oblivious to the majestic curtain of deep-green spruce arrayed behind her.

"They are very much not engaging with the landscape itself," Hyland said. "The focus is on them, the whole time." She continued, "The pictures look quite quirky and fun, but for them it was a quite serious, organized moment. I think they feel quite a bit of pressure to get the picture. They looked like they were doing a very serious activity."

For years, Hyland has been interested in rural landscapes and their relationship to urbanization and climate change. "I've found that farming is very hard to shoot," she said. "Quite often it can make a very boring picture. I've shot around the U.K. for years, and I think I have five pictures I like. Whereas, in Asia, there is this balance between nature and tourism. I've been to places in Thailand where there is farmland and they've built a giant Buddha, like a theme park. So they are making their money from the theme park, but they are still doing the farming. Those quirks, those contradictions, work quite well for me. You do see the conundrum. People will turn their noses up at tourism, but in fact it's one of the solutions for a lot of these villages."

In Yunnan, Hyland spent much of her time around Dali, a once-small mountain town that has cycled through various incarnations through the years. When I first travelled there, in the mid-nineteen-nineties, Dali was a

sleepy refuge for young foreign backpackers, part of the banana-pancake network of friendly towns across East and Southeast Asia. Then, in the two-thousands, as urban Chinese households became more prosperous, Dali began to attract more domestic tourists. By the late twenty-tens, the town had become a major destination. Many of Hyland's images portray the things that Chinese like seeing in the hinterlands of their own country: a well-groomed yak, a miniature tourist train, women in the full ethnic dress of the Bai minority.

In the past decade or so, Dali has acquired yet another identity, as a home for young people trying to escape the pressures of modern Chinese life. The term "*tang ping*"—"lying flat"—refers to youth who renounce the standard urban work pattern known as "996": sitting at a desk from 9 *A.M.* to 9 *P.M.*, six days a week. In practice, few young Chinese feel secure enough to drop out of their hyper-competitive society, but some have found new homes in Dali. When Hyland visited, she was interested in the contrast between these young urban transplants and older locals. "You have this kind of alienation between the two generations," she said. "The younger ones are trying to get closer to nature, but in a way we might roll our eyes at. They'll be in the Starbucks sitting right on the edge of the land, with the older generation still farming."

When I lived in China twenty years ago, foreign journalists often documented the lives of individuals who were part of the country's massive migration from farm to factory. A generation later, in a China that is much more prosperous but also less open, the future trajectory is hard to predict. Hyland feels sympathy for young people who experience a degree of confusion and disorientation. "I'm trying to take my pictures of the opposite of what you've written about, people moving to the cities," she told me. "This is people leaving the cities, but they haven't quite found their place. They're quite lost. I don't know if they will find their place, or if it's a transition phase. Perhaps they will keep moving."

Hyland's images convey this sense of loneliness. In the photographs, people are rarely interacting with one another, and an empty playground and amusement park seem even emptier because of their bright colors. An old building with impressive wood columns and traditional painted eaves is

fading under the Yunnan sun. These quiet scenes contrast with the curated world of well-attended brides and solipsistic selfies.

During Hyland's last visit to Yunnan, in May, 2025, she travelled with her then three-year-old daughter, Sofia. Like any blond child in China, Sofia attracted more than her share of attention, and Hyland found that it changed her photographic interactions. "I would ask if I could take a picture of them, and then they would ask if they could take a picture of Sofia," she said. "When you have children, it does make you think more empathetically. I don't want to feel like I'm forcing people into uncomfortable positions." She always allowed her subjects to choose their own poses.

Travelling once more to the highlands of Spruce Meadow, and seeing all the brides scattered like wandering clouds, Hyland and Sofia had different thoughts about marriage. "I have not actually got married yet," Hyland said. "I have been with my partner since I was twenty. And I am engaged. I think I'm one of the women who is least interested in getting married, actually. The person who is most interested in me getting married is my daughter. She was outraged after she had seen everybody at the mountain getting married." Hyland continued, "She thought it was the most beautiful sight she had ever seen. She is still going on, a year later, about how beautiful the brides were, and when am I going to get married, and get a white dress, and go up there to get photographed."

Peter Hessler joined The New Yorker as a staff writer in 2000. His books include "Other Rivers: A Chinese Education."

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The Talk of the Town

- **What Was Behind the T.S.A. Meltdown?**
  By Benjamin Wallace-Wells | The present mess has roots in two entangled, defining White House projects: DOGE and the mind-bending expansion of ICE.
- **Trump's War Hits the Chaiwalas**
  By Nathan Heller | Restrictions and attacks in the Strait of Hormuz have made fuel prices rocket. Just ask the roadside tea venders in New Delhi.
- **Stephanie Hsu Does the Time Warp**
  By Rachel Syme | The "Everything Everywhere All at Once" actress returns to Broadway, playing the Susan Sarandon role in "Rocky Horror," at Studio 54.
- **Signed, Sealed, Delivered—and Afloat**
  By Henry Alford | The city's Blue Highways distribution program aims to decrease truck emissions and road congestion while delivering your Sephora package. Its solution? Boats.
- **Reality-TV Deconstructor**
  By Emma Allen | The author of the book "Dream Facades," about the architecture in reality-TV shows, gives a tour of notable New York locations—including Bethenny Frankel's old apartment.

Comment

What Was Behind the T.S.A. Meltdown?

The present mess has roots in two entangled, defining White House projects: DOGE and the mind-bending expansion of ICE.

By Benjamin Wallace-Wells

March 29, 2026

Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

The pleasing part of an airport is its frictionlessness. The experienced traveller might make it from taxi to gate in a tight twenty-five, passed from station to station as seamlessly as an electron in a circuit. The place is in the hands of the security state, but the touch is generally light and the thanking is relentless—for your patronage, for having your I.D. ready, for your participation at the silver level in the airline-rewards program that, financially, keeps everything afloat. An airport offers, if not exactly an equitable experience (there are Clear lines, lounge archipelagos), then at least a perceptible simulacrum of equality, in that everyone rides the same

people movers past the same Cinnabons. Certain European airports still project a mid-century grandeur. The domestic versions don't ever really manage that, but on good days they can convey a spirit of efficiency, graced with free pretzels and Wi-Fi.

This whole apparatus came shuddering to a stop last week in a pretty spectacular and ominous way, as thousands of T.S.A. agents, who were unpaid because of a budget impasse over how to fund the Department of Homeland Security, had stopped showing up to work. Americans were experiencing, the T.S.A.'s acting administrator told the House Homeland Security Committee on Wednesday, "the highest wait times in T.S.A. history." By Thursday morning, people were arriving for their flights six or seven hours early, so that LaGuardia was packed at 3 *a.m.*, and by 9 *a.m.* at J.F.K. the security lines stretched out to the curb. ("There was no water, no food. It was horrible. That's not human," a traveller in Houston told the *Times*.) That evening, President Donald Trump, perhaps eager to declare a victory somewhere, announced on Truth Social that he would issue "an Order" to pay the agents. The Senate then passed (by voice vote, at 2 *a.m.*) a bill that restored D.H.S. funding—but not for *ICE* or Customs and Border Protection—and left town for recess. On Friday, the House Speaker, Mike Johnson, tersely rejected the bill, calling it a joke. Trump's order, a Presidential memorandum, soon appeared, instructing D.H.S. to use existing funds to pay T.S.A. workers—a decision he could have made at any point.

The road to the very long lines began in February, when Congress, in resolving a broader government shutdown (the second in four months, impressively), could not agree on how to keep funding Homeland Security. As of Friday, T.S.A. agents—who turn out to be the essential element in the frictionless airport experience—had not been paid for about six weeks. They make in the neighborhood of fifty thousand dollars a year, and bills do not stop just because paychecks do. There were some gothic stories (a union leader reported that some members were selling their blood plasma for cash), and nearly five hundred agents quit, but many more simply called in sick: more than a third of the workforce in Houston, Atlanta, and New Orleans was absent on a single day. Spring break loomed, then the summer

travel season, this year punctuated by the World Cup. Testily, the Senate Majority Leader, John Thune, said, “This is a pox on everybody’s house.”

When someone in Washington tells you that everyone is suffering from the political pressure equally, that’s often a sign that he, specifically, is feeling it the most. The present mess has roots in two entangled, defining White House projects. The first was *DOGE*, which congressional Republicans hoped would, among other goals, ease the nation’s deficit, but which succeeded only in dismantling vital programs and antagonizing federal workers (who do things like making sure that no one is carrying liquid explosives onto planes). The second was the mind-bending expansion of *ICE*—last year, Congress separately approved seventy-five billion dollars for the agency, effectively almost tripling its budget—which has colonized virtually every sector of Trump’s domestic agenda.

Congress’s February efforts to resolve the shutdown were complicated by the lawless *ICE* campaign in Minneapolis, where federal agents killed two American citizens during a brutal crackdown on protests. As a condition of agreeing to fund D.H.S., congressional Democrats demanded certain reforms: no masked *ICE* agents, no roving sweeps, no arrests in churches or schools. But the White House and its allies refused, even though *ICE*’s methods of immigration enforcement are increasingly unpopular and few new migrants are coming into the country. By the end of last week, the Democrats had not won any reforms to *ICE*, though the episode provided a very public demonstration of how much dysfunction Trump and the G.O.P. are creating in the agency’s name.

The deeper trouble for Trump is that he has not offered the public much else in his second term. His Administration took office convinced that it had a mandate for big changes, but with few substantive ideas about what those changes should be. The tariff program has petered out and *DOGE* is done. The President is distrusted on the economy and has, per Fox News, a disapproval rating of an astonishing fifty-nine per cent. Since the campaign, Trump has remained relentlessly focussed on immigration enforcement.

So it was predictable that his response to the delays at the airports was to send *ICE* agents. They didn’t help much with wait times; it takes four to six months to properly train a T.S.A. agent in screening protocol. In

Philadelphia, a union official told the *Inquirer* that the *ICE* agents (who were being paid, while T.S.A. employees were not) stood by the windows and did “nothing.” In a concession, they did not wear masks. Just before the deployment, there was an ugly scene at San Francisco International Airport after agents carried away a passenger, originally from Guatemala, who was waiting to board a domestic flight with her daughter. *ICE* agents are involved with so many different federal activities that it can be hard to understand the evolving scope of their role. Are the violent, militarized, Minneapolis-style sweeps that so enthused the President a few months ago now a thing of the past, as some Administration officials have suggested, and as Trump himself seemed to be signalling when he fired the D.H.S. Secretary, Kristi Noem, and replaced her with Senator Markwayne Mullin? If so, what is such a large and extravagantly funded force meant to do?

Some of the degradations of the government that Trump has overseen are hard to illustrate in real time, but any local-news cameraman can shoot a long line of bored and frustrated people. The addition of *ICE* agents into the frame made for an elegant encapsulation of the political situation. The President has, in *ICE*, a quasi-authoritarian force at his disposal. But the trains are very much not running on time. ♦

Benjamin Wallace-Wells began contributing to The New Yorker in 2006 and joined the magazine as a staff writer in 2015. He writes about American politics and society.

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New Delhi Postcard

Trump’s War Hits the *Chaiwalas*

Restrictions and attacks in the Strait of Hormuz have made fuel prices rocket. Just ask the roadside tea venders in New Delhi.

By Nathan Heller

March 30, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

In the leafy, refined New Delhi neighborhood of Nizamuddin the other day, a tea vender named Mohammad Meraj lamented the costs of faraway war as he swept his strainer back and forth across a simmering pot.

“Normally, these cylinders come from the Strait of Hormuz,” he told a customer, gesturing at a battered, rusting red cylinder sitting on the pavement to the right of his stand, which, besides tea, advertised iced coffee, “bread omlet,” “boiled egg,” and “cigratte.” Seven stacks of tiny paper cups were arranged to the left, next to packets of Nescafé, pouches of two-minute noodles, and a double gas burner connected to the cylinder—the main tool of his trade. Like low-cost stoves across India, Meraj’s burners run on liquefied petroleum gas, or L.P.G., a compressed fuel mixture. “The cylinders usually cost nine hundred rupees, but replacing this one would cost three thousand rupees on the black market,” he explained.

India, a relative bystander in the Middle East war, is home to eighteen per cent of the world’s population and receives more than eighty per cent of its gas imports through the Strait of Hormuz—or it did until March, when Iran restricted traffic and started attacking ships. Cylinders of fluid gas, which power everything from taxicabs to cooking appliances, vanished from many distributors. In the poor quarters of New Delhi, households struggling to pay for gas fired up chulhas, old-school wood-burning stoves, and hoped their tinder supplies held. The *Times of India* found workers in Chirag Dilli, the city’s dumpling-making capital, so stretched for fuel that some had given up on steaming and had turned operations over to chow mein.

For many Delhiite commuters, though, the plainest sign of mounting trouble was the price of roadside tea. *Chaiwalas*, or street tea venders, have long been taken as emblems of the small-scale entrepreneurialism by which uneducated Indians can gain subsistence, and, in theory, something more. (The country’s Prime Minister, Narendra Modi, has made much of his own ostensible *chaiwala* interlude, selling tea as a boy, in Gujarat.) The stands serve as sites of passing assembly—roadside water coolers—and repositories of gossip and news. In the past month, they have also become centers of controversy and unease, as price increases have created what some have taken to calling the “chai crisis”: an alarming, possibly dangerous circumstance in which the world’s most populous country is straitened of caffeine.

To meet his growing costs, Meraj had increased the price of a cup of tea from ten rupees to fifteen, a fifty-per-cent rise (in New York terms, like a

cup of drip coffee going from just shy of four dollars to nearly six overnight). In his view, though, the book-balancing was a Pyrrhic success. “There are fewer customers now,” he said. “People are a little scared to spend.”

Meraj began a new brew, tipping more milk into his pan, then adding tea, spices, and sugar. He wore an ironed, mint-colored shirt with the cuffs rolled up. He had cropped black hair and a gentle scruff of beard around wide, affably set teeth, like Freddie Mercury’s, and he worked with easy confidence, placing a cover on the pot for a low five-minute boil. The fuel cost of tea, for *chaiwalas*, is the price of simmering; unlike many roadside offerings, their product never leaves the flame. Meraj, who started selling in this spot, a residential neighborhood near the tourist expanse of Humayun’s Tomb, two years ago, when he was twenty-three, had considered an investment in induction burners, but they required an upfront cost of five thousand rupees—hundreds of cups.

As Meraj worked, a young man dressed in legal garb (black suit, white shirt) approached and ordered tea. He was a regular, Rishik Singh Rajput, a law student studying nearby.

“Restaurants have been closed in many cities, like Bangalore,” Rajput reported. Some popular destinations, like the beach province of Goa, had been at pains to support tourism amid the L.P.G. shortages; restaurants pared menus to be able to cook for vacationers and the population alike. “Ultimately, there will be locals who also want food,” Rajput said dryly.

After the tea had finished its boil, Meraj poured it out, straining the steaming, fragrant liquid into small cups. A fugue of car horns rang out from the street—a reminder of the squeeze on a country with acute fuel dependencies and little involvement in the war, but also of the avidity with which daily life was going on.

“The locals are facing surging prices,” Rajput said. “But the rest is normal.” ♦

Nathan Heller began contributing to The New Yorker in 2011 and joined the magazine as a staff writer in 2013.

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The Boards

Stephanie Hsu Does the Time Warp

The “Everything Everywhere All at Once” actress returns to Broadway, playing the Susan Sarandon role in “Rocky Horror,” at Studio 54.

By Rachel Syme

March 30, 2026

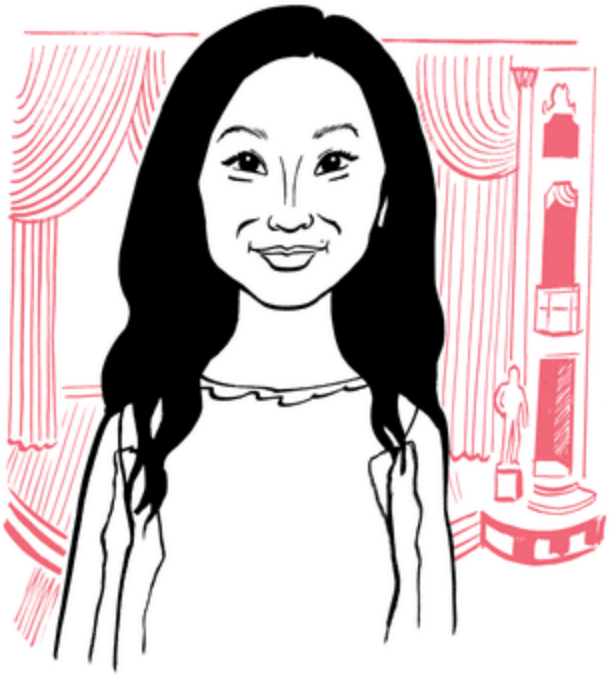

Illustration by João Fazenda

The actress Stephanie Hsu likes to call herself a “soft witch,” meaning that although she has some supernatural powers of perception, her intuition can be off by a few clicks. Case in point: last year, Hsu had a sudden vision that she would be cast in the Broadway hit “Oh, Mary!” as Abraham Lincoln. (The sight gag appealed to her: Hsu is five feet tall.) The next day, she heard from Sam Pinkleton, the show’s director, who wanted to discuss an opportunity. “I was, like, Sam, this is soooo spooky, but I already know

you’re going to ask me to be Lincoln,” she said. “And he was, like, What the hell are you talking about?”

Pinkleton was calling to offer Hsu the role of Janet in the new Broadway revival of “The Rocky Horror Show,” the high-camp glam-rock musical that débuted in the West End in 1973 and whose 1975 cult-film adaptation, “The Rocky Horror Picture Show,” is the longest-running theatrical release in history. Hsu, who is thirty-five, had never seen the movie, but she watched it the night Pinkleton called, and signed on. The story follows an uptight young couple named Brad and Janet (played in the film by a baby-faced Susan Sarandon), who wander into a castle occupied by a flamboyant, cross-dressing mad scientist named Dr. Frank-N-Furter (Tim Curry) and a gang of colorful oddballs. Janet, who begins the night as an innocent ingénue, undergoes a sexual awakening within the castle walls. “I was shocked, when I started playing her, with what was coming out of my body,” Hsu said. “She has this fudge-brownie earnestness, but her desires are very real.”

On a recent Thursday, Hsu was in the mirrored lobby of Studio 54, on her dinner break during “Rocky Horror” tech rehearsals (the show opens on April 23rd). She had changed into baggy Levi’s, but from the neck up she was still in her post-awakening makeup for Act II—red lips, doll-pink cheeks, false eyelashes, glitter-splashed cheekbones. She’d tied a blue scarf over a wig cap. “This is a *classique* Broadway look,” she said. “Everyone goes out to get their little juice in midtown wearing a baseball hat and a full beat.”

“Rocky Horror” marks Hsu’s return to Broadway. She was born and reared in the Los Angeles area and attended N.Y.U.’s Tisch School of the Arts, after which she got immersed in what she described as “the experimental downtown theatre scene.” She landed her first Broadway role in 2017, as a sentient supercomputer in the “SpongeBob SquarePants” musical, and did a bit of TV work before being cast in “Everything Everywhere All at Once,” a kooky, world-bending independent film, from 2022, directed by Daniel Kwan and Daniel Scheinert. Hsu plays Joy, a morose daughter of two Chinese immigrants. She relocated to the West Coast and earned an Oscar nomination, but she found herself missing Manhattan. On the morning after

Trump was elected a second time, she decided to move back. “I was, like, If we’re going down, I gotta go down with the freaks,” she said.

At Studio 54, Hsu pointed out the worn leopard-print carpeting, which was decades old. “We like to say it’s embedded with cocaine,” she said. During rehearsals, members of the cast, which also includes Luke Evans, Juliette Lewis, and Rachel Dratch, had held a séance in the mezzanine, trying to contact some of those who had twirled under the room’s giant disco ball in times past—Prince, the drag queen Divine. “We talked to all the ghosts,” she said.

Hsu had befriended the theatre’s in-house carpenter, Dan Hoffman, who has worked there for twenty-three years. In a tiny windowless office off the lobby, Hoffman sat at a desk, poring over archival photographs. He showed Hsu a picture of the space in the nineteen-thirties, when it was a night club called Casino de Paree and a naked woman would pose in the lobby in a giant Martini glass. “The thing about this place is, when you do standard theatre productions here, they are not successful,” he said. “But when you do something like ‘Cabaret,’ or like this show, the history comes alive. It’s, like, *boom!* ”

Hsu asked Hoffman if he’d been a “Rocky Horror” fan. “I was a fan of Susan Sarandon in lingerie, I’ll tell you that,” he said.

Hsu laughed. “I’m glad you said that,” she said. “Because, when I watched it and saw her, I was, like, in heat.”

She walked up to the stage, whose curtain was made of shredded vinyl, and explained that the set designers had hidden several Easter eggs for diehard “Rocky Horror” fans to discover. She wouldn’t give them away, but she did offer hints: “Look for the iron rods,” she said, and “Look for wet leather.” She also whispered about an “upside-down butt plug” hidden in the molding. Hsu said that Richard O’Brien, who wrote the show’s original book, liked to say that “Rocky Horror” should always feel like a “trashy little musical.” She added, “We say that phrase with absolute delight and glory.” ♦

An earlier version of this article misidentified a character in “The Rocky Horror Show.”

Rachel Syme is a staff writer at The New Yorker. She has covered Hollywood, style, literature, music, and other cultural subjects since 2012.

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/04/06/stephanie-hsu-does-the-time-warp

Here To There Dept.

Signed, Sealed, Delivered—and Afloat

The city's Blue Highways distribution program aims to decrease truck emissions and road congestion while delivering your Sephora package. Its solution? Boats.

By Henry Alford

March 30, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

It is the nadir of party conversation to detail the tangle of avenues and streets and buses and taxis that got you there. But, if you are a parcel, your

recent travels might be more diverting, particularly if a new pilot program called Blue Highways takes off. In an effort to reduce vehicular congestion and emissions—nearly ninety per cent of the two and a half million packages that New Yorkers receive daily are delivered by truck—the Department of Transportation recently launched the project, by which up to eight hundred parcels a day will travel from Brooklyn to Manhattan not by truck but by boat and then cargo bike.

The other day, an observer decided to follow one of these parcels, chosen at random—a featherweight, toaster-size box from Sephora, addressed to 235 West Forty-eighth Street—and chart its journey. At 2 *A.M.*, the package was on a truck from Sephora's distribution center in Aberdeen, Maryland. At about 3 *A.M.*, it arrived on the Red Hook waterfront at a vast terminal owned by a company called Dutch X, a next-day-delivery service committed to lowering carbon-dioxide emissions. By 10 *A.M.*, the package, along with some two hundred others, had been placed in one of nine Kevlar totes and nestled onto four steel-cage dollies. A Dutch X employee wheeled these onto a small blue-and-white passenger ferry at the Red Hook Ferry Terminal. During a twenty-three-minute ride to Pier 79, on Manhattan's West Side, one rider looked out at the landmass going by and asked his seatmate, "What if all of Staten Island were turned into an Amazon fulfillment center?"

At 10:44 *A.M.*, after docking near West Thirty-ninth Street, a thousand and fifty-six feet above trucks stuck in traffic in the Lincoln Tunnel, the package was assigned to a Dutch X biker named C Jay Jaime, a Brooklyn-born, thirty-four-year-old father of three, who would be riding around town on a special pedal-assist e-bike that came equipped with a windshield, a roof, and an attached trailer. Jaime, who had on a yellow reflective vest and a helmet, held up his phone near his supervisor's and, courtesy of the FarEye app, instantly received the coördinates for the packages—*a total of forty-five*—he'd be delivering. "This should take about six hours," he said. The Sephora box would be his nineteenth of the day. He removed the parcel from its Kevlar tote and placed it on a shelf in the trailer. The D.O.T. estimates that two cargo bikes can do the work of a van or a box truck. Moreover, the trim little contraption cut a wholesome figure reminiscent of a Richard Scarry book—as if a courtesy tram birthed a tiny Zamboni.

During the next ninety minutes, Jaime zigzagged around the theatre district dropping off packages. He passed scores of food-delivery bikes, some of the forty-four thousand trucks that traverse the city each day, a mail carrier on foot, and a toddler dragging her Labubu along a sidewalk by its ears. When he saw three trucks idling on Sixth Avenue at Thirty-ninth Street, he said, “This is what we’re trying to eliminate.”

Some of the drop-off locations were strikingly similar—luxury apartment buildings whose vast lobbies were tributes to beige and camel, each housing a blocky reception desk manned by a burly fellow with a fastidious beard. At one of the two non-elevator buildings on Jaime’s itinerary, he had to walk up four flights of stairs, whereupon he left a package on a “Hello, Sunshine” doormat. (“This is nothing,” he said, explaining that delivering a package to Rockefeller Center can take fifteen minutes.) He dropped off another Sephora box at a DoubleTree hotel on Fortieth Street. “Probably a lady from another country who forgot her eyelashes,” he said.

At 1:24 *P.M.*, Jaime parked his bike on Eighth Avenue at Forty-ninth Street. Clutching package No. 19, destined for a block away, he said, “Sometimes it takes longer to drive around the corner than to walk there.” He added that occasionally, when he’s delivering a package from Sephora, he will walk right past a Sephora store. “On Riverside Drive, there’s a building with a whole room of packages,” he said. “The doorman told me, ‘People order stuff and then they forget. They don’t even pick it up.’ ”

On arriving at 235 West Forty-eighth Street, a tall building called the Ritz Plaza, Jaime’s eyes widened; the reception desk was already covered with boxes from Amazon, stacked three high.

“This is every day, every day,” a middle-aged man behind the desk said, in a tone midway between exasperation and resignation. Jaime cleared a space and deposited No. 19. The eagle—a lipstick? a loofah?—had landed. ♦

Henry Alford, a humorist and a journalist, has contributed to The New Yorker since 1998. He is the author of the Joni Mitchell biography “I Dream of Joni.”

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House-Hunters

Reality-TV Deconstructor

The author of the book “Dream Facades,” about the architecture in reality-TV shows, gives a tour of notable New York locations—including Bethenny Frankel’s old apartment.

By Emma Allen

March 30, 2026

Illustration by João Fazenda

Maybe someday, from a certain angle, if the light hits just right, Donald Trump’s ninety-thousand-square-foot ballroom will resemble the “much-needed and exquisite addition” promised by whitehouse.gov. Or perhaps it’ll just be the ultimate reality-television-show set for our reality-television-star President. For now, it’s a pile of rubble.

Jack Balderrama Morley, the exuberant thirty-eight-year-old managing editor of *Dwell* magazine, who just published the book “Dream Facades: The Cruel Architecture of Reality TV,” can’t get worked up about the ballroom. “So much of the White House has always been a kind of symbolic construction,” he said the other day, while leading a private tour of some notable reality-TV locations around Manhattan. “All the tackiness—I find it endearing. The bald artifice, the kind of striver-ness of it—it’s like rooting for early Bethenny.”

The tour began outside the “Real Housewives of New York” cast member Bethenny Frankel’s old apartment complex, at 403 East Sixty-second Street, where she lived when she first appeared on “*RHONY*,” in 2008. (The multicity “Real Housewives” franchise turned twenty in March.) “This is the *end* of the Upper East Side,” Morley commented. With its proximity to the Queensboro Bridge and a Home Depot, Le Domaine, as the building is grandly named, feels a long way from France. A shirtless man drinking a beer at 10:45 *A.M.* waved from his balcony.

As Morley led the way to 162 East Sixty-third Street, the “*RHONY*” alum Sonja Morgan’s albatross of a town house (it took her a decade to sell it, in 2024, for half what she’d paid, in 1998), he talked about filming in New York apartments: “The spaces are so small, you can’t pull back, so you’re always up in their faces, and it feels really compressed, zany, and jittery.” Nevertheless, as Morley notes in his book, reality TV was “one of the first forms of media to create home-to-home visual connections.” Before TikTok, how else were you supposed to see how other people lived?

“It’s a little Miss Havisham-y—faded splendor,” Morley remarked, of the exterior of Morgan’s former home, wrapped in scaffolding. He walked, heel to toe, along the façade, counting. “This is, what, about fifteen feet wide? That’s super narrow. So it’s got to be handheld cameras following Sonja around as she’s picking a BlackBerry out of the toilet.” Ivana Trump also had a town house, on East Sixty-fourth Street, that sold for a fraction of its asking price, but at least it was a full twenty feet wide.

In a cab headed to SoHo, Morley defined “cruel architecture”: “That came from Lauren Berlant, the cultural theorist who wrote the book ‘Cruel Optimism,’ which describes things that people have faith will improve their

lives but are actually counter to their own flourishing. So you could think of homeownership, or getting married.”

“I wouldn’t have come this way.”
Cartoon by Frank Cotham

Meanwhile, he went on, “we’re all sitting in our little boxes that are falling apart and are getting kicked out by private-equity overlords that are buying our buildings and raising the rent!” The taxi inched down Park Avenue, near where another “*RHONY*” cast member, Kelly Bensimon, was once filmed jogging in front of a cab, with voice-over: “Like, the ultimate experience of being in New York is, like, running in traffic. It’s, like, you’re in the traffic trenches.” She is now a real-estate broker.

Morley recalled that, on the other coast, at the beginning of the Obama era, the Kardashians lived in a “Cape Cod-style house with an American flag out on the porch.” But, when Trump took over, “it became less about that sort of wholesomeness and more about the slickness, the empty, vast expanses of frictionless surfaces.” In short, a villain’s lair. He added, “It’s not helping anybody that the villains of the world are winning.”

At 22 Mercer, Morley gazed up at “Bethenny’s post-divorce apartment”—a major upgrade. The building featured some of the cast-iron filigree that SoHo is known for, and which, back in the nineteenth century, you could buy from a catalogue. “SoHo got romanticized as a place of hard work and true craft, but then you learn that a lot of the beautiful façades were mail order,” he said.

Down the block, near the Real Housewife Jenna Lyons's loft, Morley whispered, "Oh, gosh, look at what's happening." A woman wearing stilettos and carrying a Gucci shopping bag was holding up traffic while unsteadily posing for photos, on cobblestones. "When the artists came to SoHo, they were just as much posers as influencers taking selfies in the street," Morley theorized. "They were getting some of that secondhand glamour of hard work and sweat."

Final stop: 565 Broadway, where MTV's "Real World" was initially filmed, making it perhaps the original New York reality-TV home. When 565 opened, in 1860, a newspaper reported, "In proportion, in chasteness of design, in rich and elegant finish, and in perfect keeping, we know no building in the whole length of Broadway that can equal it." "Supposedly the glass windows on the ground floor were the largest window panes in the country," Morley said—the better to spy on its occupants. Now it's a Madewell. ♦

Emma Allen is The New Yorker's cartoon editor and edits humor pieces on newyorker.com.

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Personal History

How I Became a Filmmaker

After college, I joined an odd little utopia of movie nerds working out of an office on lower Broadway. Then the sustainability of the setup started to seem questionable.

By Lena Dunham

March 30, 2026

Illustration by Tomi Um

I made my first short film during a summer break from college at Oberlin, right after I turned twenty. I called it a satire, although I'm not sure I even knew what that meant. It was about a high-powered teen-age art dealer who bossed around people several times her age, a scenario that seemed like a fairy tale but was, in retrospect, a rather prescient vision of my life to come. I cast my family members and used our home, a loft in Tribeca, as both a

production office and a set. I haven't watched the film in two decades—I'm sure I would be both charmed and alarmed by its amateurishness—but at the time it felt like one small step for me, one giant leap for womankind. It's that kind of hubris that defines being a young artist, and it should never be beaten out of anyone.

I submitted the film to the Sundance Film Festival's even more indie counterpart, Slamdance, and when it was accepted I felt as though my life was beginning. I booked tickets to Park City, Utah, and dragged along my best friends at the time, Audrey and Sara—two stunningly petite brunettes who made me feel both more and less worthwhile when they flanked me. There was a Facebook group for accepted filmmakers, where cheap house shares were posted, and we secured a single king-size bed in a rundown ski lodge, which we split with film bros in their thirties and their wanly supportive girlfriends. All we knew was that the festival promised celebrity sightings (I kept track on the back of an envelope: Jared Leto! Gary Coleman! Teri Hatcher! Scott fucking Speedman!) and, if we played our cards right, the chance to get very drunk using our fake I.D.s.

On our first night in Park City, we trooped in snow boots to a crowded Western-themed establishment, where men shoved business cards at us—"John Johnson, independent producer." We took advantage of an open bar, slamming cocktails that, we were told, were lower in alcohol because this was Mormon country. Audrey, with her winged black eyeliner and side-swept bangs, even attracted the attention of the celebrity d.j. Steve Aoki, who invited us to join him at a "Motorola x Heineken activation." After all the excitement, how would we ever return to Oberlin, eat in the sad light of the cafeteria, and take a class called Practicum in Contemporary Agrarianism?

The next day, my short screened for a sleepy crowd of a dozen people, and my glory was over faster than the sex we'd been having with undergraduate men back in Ohio. The disappointment had barely set in—all those desperate all-nighters in the media lab had amounted to *this*?—when I became enraptured by the short that played after mine. It was distinctly more impressive and assured—well shot, replete with pro actors and puppet choreography. Called "The Back of Her Head," it told the story of a shy boy

with a crush on a Manic Pixie Dream Girl who lived in the apartment across the way. I was certain that it had been made by an adult with years of experience—this was the "(500) Days of Summer" of romantic puppet shorts!—but when it was time for the filmmaker to take his bow a pair of college kids stood up. They were baby-faced and dressed in the knowingly grandpa-ish garb that signified indie culture at the time. They were Josh and Benny Safdie, two Boston University students about my age, and my friends and I spent the rest of the festival running around with them, bound by a desire to make ebullient mayhem.

Benny and Josh had already surrounded themselves with a remarkable group of technicians—cinematographers, production designers, actors—and after school they set up shop in a building on lower Broadway, not far from my parents' place. That and a companion building across the street became a kind of dormitory for wildly talented indie-film nerds, a crew of boys—always boys—who attended Tisch or Columbia, schools whose film departments, unlike Oberlin's, consisted of more than a passed-around Super 8 camera, a broken projector, and an aging professor who enjoyed talking about Swedish modernism and hugging students tightly while sighing. I used every trip home to New York as a chance to ingratiate myself with them, offering to hold the boom, to P.A., to wheat-paste flyers for screenings, or just to pay for dinner at a Chinatown noodle shop, because I was the only one who still got an allowance.

All I had wanted was to be around people who were making movies—not just talking about movies, or writing about movies on their Blogspots, like the one on which I reviewed Cassavetes films for no one, but actually *making* them. And now here they were. Ariel Schulman and Henry Joost (the creators of "Catfish"), the production designer Sam Lisenco, and the early YouTube titans the Neistat brothers had all taken offices in the same buildings. Ronald Bronstein and his wife, Mary, were hanging around, fresh off the festival runs of their films "Frownland" and "Yeast." This is to say nothing of the blond fuckboys with the streetwear brand or the guy who called himself a "sound sculptor." (Obviously, that's the only one I got the chance to kiss.) Never in my life had I felt like I knew *what* was happening, much less *where*. But our commune on Broadway reminded me of the way my mother spoke about SoHo in the early nineteen-seventies, when

someone fascinating was always doing something fascinating, and all you had to do to find it was get out of bed. Sometimes the excitement even came to my bed, as we'd all pile in to watch some misunderstood classic like "Ishtar" on a flat-screen TV that I'd inherited from my uncle Bart, entangling our limbs in that way you stop doing with your guy friends once you've entered your first real monogamous relationship.

In the summer between my junior and senior year, some of the guys—who were known en masse as the Red Bucket collective—helped me shoot my first "feature" film, a misguided but ambitious hybrid of vérité digital and Godard-inspired Super 16 entitled "Creative Nonfiction." The shoot took us to my great-aunt's house, in Connecticut, and to a commune my mother had lived on when she was my age, in the woods of upstate New York. Along the way, a light we had rented fell from the back of our white van on a country road at 3 *A.M.*, and a fight ensued: "*We're fucked. We could be on the hook for, like . . .*" None of us actually knew the amount—it could have been a thousand dollars or a million—but each guy was certain that someone else should have been responsible for properly latching the van's back doors. We returned the battered light, straight-faced, and never met a consequence. The shoot finished with us dumping three enormous bags of sand on the floor of my mother's studio to create a faux desert, then forgetting to clean it up.

When I graduated from Oberlin, a year later, I decided that the best use of my limited income from babysitting would be to rent a hundred-and-fifty-square-foot "studio" a story below the Safdies. Sara—my gamine friend who had accompanied me to Slamdance, a budding film editrix—took the desk next to mine. Now I wasn't just an interloper; I was a part of the fabric of the place. Another friend of the group's also joined our floor, an actress and writer named Greta Gerwig, who was already famous to me because she'd starred in some of the premier mumblecore films of the mid- to late aughts, which had beckoned from the shelves of Campus Video and convinced me that a career in movies was within my reach.

Sara and I were diligently shooting and editing episodes of a web series, "Delusional Downtown Divas," that was meant to skewer the art world. "D.D.D.," as we called it, averaged about three hundred views an episode,

but it was a way to create work at a breakneck pace. We'd often shoot at actual art openings, live music events, and other settings that made our lack of a production budget look less glaring. The series starred three of my closest friends, Isabel, Joana, and Audrey, whom I'd met when I was one, three, and thirteen, respectively. At night, we partied prodigiously, in echoey lofts rented by boys who dressed like James Dean and had somehow been paid well for indie albums that didn't chart; at the Jane Hotel, where the Olsen twins could be spotted on a Tuesday night; or in our childhood homes when our parents were away for the weekend. During the week, I sped from a job selling couture-influenced baby attire to my little office, where I edited on a desktop computer that I'd put on my first credit card and was paying off ten dollars at a time. Greta, meanwhile, used our space to film audition tapes, and occasionally I would act as her reader, running lines from scripts with code names like "Flight of the Pterodactyls" (which turned out to be one of the many "Jurassic Park" reboots). We were all in awe when Greta booked her first studio film, Noah Baumbach's "Greenberg," and headed off to California. When she came home, three months later, we threw her a huge party in Chinatown. I asked her how Hollywood was, and she shrugged. "Everyone hikes," she said.

Looking back, it was a very innocent time. Yes, there was drama. A boy who knew a boy built us a storage loft and a ladder, into which he wood-burned the Springsteen lyrics "I love you for your pink Cadillac," and so naturally I slept with him, then road-tripped with him to a wedding in Kentucky. By the end of the weekend we weren't speaking, except when he demanded that I drive on the highway in Baltimore so that he could get some shut-eye, even though I had no license. Sara and I got into a fight when I found out that she and an older paramour had been sleeping on the floor of the office at night, which seemed to me like an abuse of privileges (although it's impossible, now, to imagine caring about that). One time, a jilted boyfriend of Audrey's stomped into my office with a thrifted lamp that she had forgotten at his place, smashed it, and screamed, "*Make sure to tell her about this!*"

We weren't making money. If anything, we were losing it, and we were living with our parents in order to be able to afford our odd little utopia. Ariel (or Rel, as we called him) once spent hours constructing a phone

system between our floors out of tin cans and twine, just so that we could tell dirty jokes followed by “over and out.” To this day, I feel a pang every time I watch a documentary about artists and they describe the moment when they first became part of a creative community, when nobody was doing it for the cash yet, nobody had betrayed a trusted collaborator or called someone else a sellout. At the time, it all seemed tentative and terrifying, impossible and inevitable. In total, this period lasted only a year or so, but it felt much longer, or maybe wider, because it was when I *really* fell in love with movies. It was also the first time that I felt like someone worth knowing.

I had been out of school for a year when the dread set in. However merry the mayhem of the movie dorm on Broadway, the sustainability of it all was starting to seem questionable. I could afford the rent on the office because I didn’t need to pay for a place to live, but my parents seemed less and less delighted that I was home and more and more maddened by the reality of living with someone who was old enough to drink but too young to honor a single instruction about how to behave in their home. I couldn’t seem to stay at any job for longer than five months—that was about the point at which whoever was employing me would realize that I had no applicable skills. I was involved with a fellow Oberlin graduate who was living in San Francisco, and every few months I’d open a new credit card to buy a ticket to visit him. We would snort Adderall off his “Selena” poster and fuck half-heartedly on his desk chair as the sun rose over the Castro—but it was becoming clear that this placeholder boyfriend was not, in fact, the great love of my life. Neither was the graphic designer who did Tae Kwon Do, or the lonesome ornithologist who called me every few weeks from a salmon-fishing boat he was working on.

During a brief stint as a restaurant hostess—during which I spent all my tips on cabs to work, because I was always sleeping past my alarm—I met a thirtysomething co-worker, whom I’ll call the Co-worker, and I immediately became fixated, finding him sensual, damaged, and more than slightly dangerous. I left the job but kept his number, and we began having sex in the alleyway behind his job after he closed up at 1 *A.M.*—ostensibly for the thrill of it, but actually because he had a live-in girlfriend, whom he referred to as “my roommate.” When I finally did see his home, a

dilapidated row house that he shared with a few friends and his brother—who looked like the Co-worker would have looked had he not loved cocaine—I was shocked by the level of filth, and I had to quickly decide whether to flee or to deem it exotic. I chose the latter. I could feel the disdain from my parents and sibling every time they cast their eyes over my own pigsty of a bedroom, which was strewn with expired makeup and polyester lacy underthings from the new Forever 21 up Broadway and mix CDs that I'd stepped on in platform heels while creeping toward my bed in the dark. The rush of being newly out of college had been maxed out.

A comment from my mother—couched as concern, as such comments always are—made me aware that I had gained the freshman fifty and held on to it. So I started dieting, counting out almonds and eating cottage cheese with Splenda for all three meals. I began shrinking. I'd go into my father's closet each morning to weigh myself after my "first morning urination," just as the pro-anorexia websites I frequented suggested. I would look in his full-length mirror and think—with the rage of a boxing coach talking to a wayward prodigy—*You better make something of yourself, kid*.

It was from this place—fearing that life might just go on this way until I was too old for it to be cute, until I was no longer becoming someone new but just *was*—that I wrote my film "Tiny Furniture." Impatient and hungry, heartbroken over no one in particular, I typed out the script over a few nights in my father's office. I had been in a period of conflict with my mother that felt, to me, like a Biblical battle between good and evil but was really just about the fact that I never, ever cleaned up after myself. Looking for wine in a cabinet one night, I found a box of her journals from when she was my age. I squirrelled them away under my bed and read them, night after night. The person they revealed was shockingly like me.

My mother, as I had experienced her, possessed a temperament as even as the veneers on her teeth. She was always dressed impeccably, but with the louche ease of someone who knows she's cool. She couldn't be rattled, to the extent that my teen-age fights with her often ended with me beating the couch pillows or biting my own arm—anything to get her to register an emotion beyond hostile bemusement. This was, after all, the woman who had advised me not to hold her hand on the way to fifth grade because

doing so would only increase my social isolation. Yet in her diaries she was lonely, weight-obsessed, angry, violated. Among the items on a “NEW LIST OF THINGS I WANT” were “a lover and please let it work to make me happy”; “to start getting my art together”; “to be more discreet—tell less of my secrets, fears etc, esp. Sex and unkind words about people.” She added, “Today I feel bad and mad. What the fuck is gonna happen to me.”

The pages—hundreds of them—became a kind of call-and-response, a conversation I was having with the version of her who once pulsated with the need not only to create work but to create a life worth living, just as I was trying to do now. It had felt urgent for my mother to avoid the adult life that seemed inevitable—her parents’ world of desperately trying to keep up, to conform at “the club,” to have daughters who reflected their solid American values. As I walked back and forth to a day job at the midtown office of a handsy accountant, heels blistering in pleather Zara pumps, I felt the same way.

One thing I could say about my mother, no matter how much she enraged me with her staunch refusal to engage with the volatility of my inner life, was that she had never demanded that I be respectable—only happy. My past projects hadn’t seemed to impress her much; she wasn’t ever condescending about my work, just hyper-involved in her own. But on the morning of her sixtieth birthday I printed a draft of “Tiny Furniture” and dropped it in front of her at the kitchen table. The script told the story of Aura, a frustrated daughter of an artist mother, and it used snippets of my mom’s journals, read aloud to the camera by the protagonist (because artist mothers always told us to write what we knew!). “Sorry, but I read your journals,” I told my mom. “You once said you wanted to act. This is for us to do together. Happy birthday.” In a move that was deeply uncharacteristic—she was the kind of mother who pinned nothing of ours to the fridge and walked out of high-school plays at intermission—she sat and read it in one sitting. “O.K.,” she said. “Let’s go.”

Within days, my mother went from my archnemesis to my No. 1 champion. She persuaded my father to leave the city for the month of November so that we could have the loft to ourselves as a set, a staging area, a catering hub, and more. She asked friends of hers to donate funds for the shoot,

amounts that weren't life-changing for them but were dream-making for me. I overheard her speaking to one on the phone: "It's good—it's really good. You're going to make back every penny." This dogged belief, this clearing of the path, made every subsequent aspect of my creative life possible.

Drawing on my film-festival contacts and a network of inexperienced but willing bodies from high school, college, and even MySpace, I assembled a crew. My producers, Alicia Van Couvering and Kyle Martin, were both N.Y.U. graduates with a level of professionalism that made everything I'd done before look like what it was: child's play. With the hastily written script in hand, we set up at the dining-room table and began preproduction. All we were missing was a cast. I didn't really know any actors, and judging from my brief time as a theatre student I wasn't sure I wanted to. Jemima Kirke was the one friend in high school who had seen me as more than a comic sidekick. She had recently resurfaced after rehab in Florida and come back into my life like a summer rainstorm, sudden and pleasingly violent. She had never acted (although she later confessed to having taken a few Stella Adler classes out of boredom), but she was even more luminous now than she had been when she was the most luminous girl in high school. A realization slapped me across the face: she was my muse. She had always been the person I aspired to behave like—part Lolita, part Keith Richards, with a healthy dose of indie sleaze and a haughty sense of manners about very specific things, like being on time. I asked her to take on the role of Aura's best friend, Charlotte, a lonely rich girl in a high-ceilinged apartment. At a party one night I met the actor David Call, who agreed to play Aura's sexually aggressive older co-worker. (He would soon land a part on "Gossip Girl," which at that time in New York was as impressive as saying you had a supporting role in an Orson Welles movie.) Alex Karpovsky was already a darling to the same set who worshipped Greta; I had run into him at 9 *A.M.* at a film festival as he was crossing the street, still drunk from the night before, and I'd demanded his number—my first agenda had been to kiss him, but, when that failed, collaboration seemed fine. He became Aura's grumpy and romantically ambiguous friend Jed.

I'd intentionally written the film to be shot in and around my family's loft. It would also star my brother (who at the time presented as a tidy

seventeen-year-old girl), my mother, and even some of our neighbors. Before making my own films, I'd never acted beyond some high-school productions, but I had always harbored a quiet sense that I could do something in front of a camera that I wasn't able to do in real life. Unsure that anyone else could capture the specificity of, well, me, I gave myself the leading role.

I was used to operating as a crew of one—holding the camera and the microphone at the same time, occasionally assisted by one of the guys from the Safdies' office, who would just stand there and roll his eyes at how much I didn't know. My previous shoots had involved haphazardly dragging equipment across town, stopping every few feet to pant. Now we tried to run "Tiny Furniture" like a real set, and I could see the difference it made. Shot with some measure of foresight, the footage seemed to come alive, imbued with a meaning deeper than anything I had actually written. Much of this was thanks to my cinematographer, Jody Lee Lipes, who had been a star at N.Y.U.'s undergrad film school. His eye had been refined by watching European minimalists like Michael Haneke and Bruno Dumont, and he had already filmed "Afterschool," a movie that premièred at Cannes. Before Jody, nobody had ever pushed me to consider the frame, the light, or even the words on the page. I knew only about first drafts, not about the push to perfect what had tumbled out of me. Now I could feel myself growing quickly, the way a baby triples its weight in its first year. At night, when the crew would clear out of the apartment—leaving behind empty bags of chips and bits of gaffer tape for me to clean up—I would sit and watch every take, rapt, glowing with the sense that I was becoming someone new.

We wrapped an eighteen-day shoot just after Thanksgiving. I celebrated by going to Brooklyn and letting the Co-worker come on my back, but for the first time his dismissive attitude didn't sear me. I felt as if, without his knowing, I had transformed from a silly little plaything into someone to reckon with. (It didn't hurt that I'd stolen about seventeen filthy sex lines directly from his mouth and used them for comic effect in a movie he had absolutely no idea I was making.) We rushed to edit the film before the submission deadline for South by Southwest, a festival that was fast becoming the hub of a D.I.Y. film movement, showcasing works by people

like Andrew Bujalski, Joe Swanberg, Lynn Shelton, Barry Jenkins, and the Duplass brothers. The chief programmer at the time, Janet Pierson, had taken an interest in my earlier work, accepting “Creative Nonfiction” after everyone else, everywhere else, rejected it (including the festival’s previous programmer). It had screened in a Wednesday-afternoon slot, nowhere near prime time but close enough to the action that I’d felt encouraged to go on. When we finished editing “Tiny Furniture”—hours before the submission window closed—I sent it to Pierson along with a note that was as florid as any written in the history of letters. “This film is an expression of what it feels like for me to be alive!” I wrote. And I meant it.

In the days that followed, I returned to babysitting, trying not to think about who might be watching the film, and what they might think of it—or of me onscreen, naked, crouched in the shower, weeping after a humiliating sexual liaison in a sewage pipe. It helped that when I’d shown my parents the finished product they’d nodded with the kind of respect they usually showed only to dead artists. I still remember where I was when I got the call—on the toilet, mid-stream, during work at the penthouse of a family who had five kids and a separate fridge for babysitters. Pierson had watched the film, and she wanted us to première in competition at South by Southwest the following month.

When younger artists tell me about things that might seem like small triumphs—getting accepted to a festival, getting a note of encouragement from an artist they love—I always try to remind them to celebrate those early wins. Your first experiences of creative acceptance are unparalleled, because you don’t know enough to worry about what might actually happen if you succeed. ♦

This is drawn from “Famesick.”

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American Chronicles

The Camps Promising to Turn You—or Your Son—Into an Alpha Male

At the Men of War Crucible, you bear crawl through rivers. At Warrior Week, you dig your own grave. At the Squire Program, your teen-ager can take part, too.

***By** Charles Bethea*

March 30, 2026

*RISE offers men an opportunity to crawl through mud, carry heavy objects, and, as its website puts it, "CHANGE YOUR STORY & UNF**K YOUR LIFE."Photographs by Jason Andrew for The New Yorker*

Among the written works credited to Donald Trump is the foreword to a book from 2024 called "Alpha Kings." The book's author, Nick Adams, is a bearded and broad-faced former deputy mayor of a suburb of Sydney, where he tried and failed to get rid of the local pigeon population. In the foreword, Trump calls Adams, who is now an American citizen and an internet personality, "one of my favorite authors," and praises his commitment to "fighting for the qualities that make alpha males so special." Adams loves the restaurant chain Hooters, "ice cold domestic beers," and belittling women. "Let me explain something to you, sweetheart," one

dialogue between Adams and a probably apocryphal woman, which he posted on X, begins. “I am an alpha male . . . I lead, you follow. You are the supporting cast, I am the main character.” In the book, Adams calls Trump a “study in peak alpha masculinity for the ages,” but “Alpha Kings” also has a larger agenda: “organizing thousands of alpha males in a way that hasn’t been done since Dwight Eisenhower assembled the troops to storm the beaches of Normandy in 1944.” His target readers are men between the ages of fifteen and thirty-five who, Adams writes, “love America, love sports, have traditionally male interests and activities, and are sick of being told that their masculinity is toxic and that their generation will and should be led by women.” He offers them “Nick Adams’ Commandments for Alpha Males,” a list of forty-five (Trump, numerically) short dicta, including “Success is a low-maintenance woman, not just a hot one” and “Never apologize.” Adams does most of his lecturing on X, where he has more than six hundred thousand followers, but he also likes lecterns. In Washington, D.C., he warned one audience of Young Republicans, “It starts with the Fortnite controller and boneless chicken wings, and ends in gender pronouns and Communism.” Last year, Trump nominated Adams to become the U.S. Ambassador to Malaysia.

Trump was no doubt trolling the libs with this nomination. But the elevation of so-called alpha masculinity has not been incidental during his second term, which was midwifed in part by Joe Rogan, Jordan Peterson, and lesser gods of the manosphere. Alpha-ness has become the official demeanor of American power. A few months before Charlie Kirk was killed, he visited Greenland with Trump, and subsequently said, of the President’s imperialist vision for the island, “It makes America dream again—that we’re not just this sad, low-testosterone beta male slouching in our chair.” Mark Zuckerberg recently reinvented himself as a leather-clad cage fighter, insisting that there isn’t enough “masculine energy” in corporate America. Zuck evidently can’t grow a beard, but Ezra Klein and Senator Chris Murphy have. There’s also the rise in facial plastic surgery for men—Elon Musk and John Mulaney are rumored to be among the recipients—seeking stronger chins. Penis implants have, well, risen. Trump’s Cabinet displays its alpha plumage, too: Pete Hegseth’s Crusade tattoos and “warrior ethos”; Robert F. Kennedy, Jr.,’s bench-pressing videos; Sean Duffy’s lumberjacking résumé; the mixed-martial-arts background of Markwayne

Mullin, Trump's new Secretary of Homeland Security. Even some of Trump's female Cabinet members are cast this way. Tulsi Gabbard enjoys "Green Beret Tactical Challenges." Linda McMahon, a former C.E.O. of World Wrestling Entertainment, is "very comfortable in a guy environment." Recently, Kash Patel, the F.B.I. director, put agents through U.F.C. training, and Trump gave an endorsement of sorts to the influencer and boxer Jake Paul for political office, despite the fact that he's not—yet—running for anything.

In the past several years, the phrase "alpha male" has seeped into the language around us, like the contamination of an underground aquifer. By the time former Representative Marjorie Taylor Greene called Will Smith's attack on Chris Rock during the 2022 Oscars an "alpha male response," I was using the term ironically. But there are plenty of American men these days who regard alpha masculinity—or "warrior mode," or "modern knighthood," or other such appellations—not ironically but aspirationally. There are now programs offering to help such men achieve these aspirations, or something close.

On a hot morning last August, I tailed a van speeding through the countryside of central Virginia. The vehicle contained nine blindfolded men wearing black, as they had been instructed to do. Each had paid three thousand dollars to take part in a three-day program called *RISE*, which stands for Ruthless Integrity and Simple Execution. It offers men an opportunity to crawl through mud, carry heavy objects, and, as its website puts it, "*CHANGE YOUR STORY & UNF**K YOUR LIFE*." The van's speakers played a high-volume mashup of construction sounds, Jordan Peterson lectures, Marine Corps drills, and mumbling voices. "All designed to keep them in the present moment and separate them from the life they were coming from," Brendan King, *RISE*'s founder, told me.

The van's first stop was a gravel lot off the Blue Ridge Parkway. After allowing a porta-potty "leak-out," King ordered the blindfolded men to march down a trail, holding one another's shoulders, for nearly a mile. Occasionally, King's assistants, a pair of bulky guys with law-enforcement backgrounds, offered the stumbling line a corrective shove. Weekend hikers gave the group a wide berth. Among the sightless were Justin, a martial-arts

instructor from the Seattle area; Adam, who owns a lawn-mowing business in Indiana and had lost a baby; Kevin, a people-pleasing I.T. salesman from Dallas; and James, an unemployed Army veteran living in Phoenix with his second wife. James broke down crying when King asked him why he was there. “A lot of reasons,” James stammered. “Blocks and barriers.” The men, ranging in age from twenty-nine to sixty-four, carried rucksacks containing the few items that they were allowed to bring. Sleeping bags were permitted, but not pillows or pads.

Eventually, King ordered them to stop and remove their blindfolds. The air was now cool and moist. They saw that they were standing at the midpoint of a tunnel carved into a mountain. “You see that light at the end of the tunnel?” King shouted, his voice echoing. The men squinted. “That’s where you’re headed. But you’ve got to go backwards first.” They put their blindfolds back on, turned around, and wobbled out of the tunnel.

In 1982, Frans de Waal’s book “Chimpanzee Politics” helped popularize the term “alpha male.” The book is an account of power struggles within a colony of male chimps at a zoo in the Netherlands. De Waal, a Dutch primatologist who taught at Emory University and was a director at the Yerkes National Primate Research Center, challenged a number of assumptions about nonhuman primates. He noticed that the leaders of the chimps he studied were not necessarily the strongest or most intimidating but, rather, the ones who excelled at coalition-building. They kept the peace impartially, often by protecting underdogs when conflicts arose. De Waal called his alphas the “consolers-in-chief.”

It’s not clear how closely people read the book. In the nineties, Newt Gingrich handed out copies to freshman congressmen. “After that, the term ‘alpha male’ became very popular,” de Waal explained in a *TED* talk, a few years before his death. He continued, “On the internet, you will find all these business books that tell you how to be an alpha male. And what they mean is how to beat up others and beat them over the head and let them know that you are boss and ‘Don’t mess with me’ and so on. And, basically, an alpha male for them is a bully. And I really don’t like that.”

“Well, it’s official—you never use algebra in real life.”
Cartoon by Sophie Lucido Johnson and Sammi Skolmoski

This was hardly America’s first brush with hypermasculinity. “The alpha male keeps returning as a heroic trope,” Michael Kimmel, a former professor of sociology at Stony Brook University and the author of “Manhood in America: A Cultural History,” told me. At the beginning of the twentieth century, men were increasingly working in offices, rather than in factories or on farms. Women joined them. “This was an ‘assault’ on masculinity,” Kimmel said. “People were freaked out that men were being feminized.” Scientists suggested gendered cures. In the eighteen-seventies, the physician Silas Weir Mitchell had begun advocating a “rest cure” for nervous women, sending them to bed and encouraging them to “live as domestic a life as possible.” Men, meanwhile, were told to act like cowboys, in what came to be known as the “West cure.” Theodore Roosevelt was prescribed this treatment, and later co-founded the Boone and Crockett Club and championed “rough-and-tumble” sports. The Boy Scouts and 4-H Clubs arrived in the early twentieth century, during what was later dubbed the golden age of fraternalism. More than a quarter of American men joined orders like the Knights of Pythias, and gyms grew in popularity. All of this, Kimmel explained, “was meant to help boys get away from female teachers, and, of course, Mom.”

After a great depression and two world wars, this culture began to shift. By the nineteen-fifties, efforts were under way to nurture traumatized young men who had served overseas. More public schools were built, and veterans took advantage of the G.I. Bill. “We encouraged these men to move with their families to the suburbs, where they could have a little lawn and a barbecue,” Kimmel said. Another reorientation arrived in the seventies and eighties, in response to gay liberation, feminism, and greater workplace equality. In 1990, the poet Robert Bly published “Iron John: A Book About Men,” which spent more than a year on the *Times* best-seller list. “The grief in men has been increasing steadily since the start of the Industrial Revolution and the grief has reached a depth now that cannot be ignored,” Bly wrote. The book spawned the “mythopoetic men’s movement,” which sought a return to a “deep masculinity” through all-male wilderness retreats and the use of Native American rituals. “Mythopoetic man,” though, wasn’t quite as catchy as “alpha male.” Kimmel thinks that George W. Bush’s victory over Al Gore, in 2000, stemmed partly from this new dichotomy. “I remember Gore was called a beta,” Kimmel told me. “And Bush was alpha-male-ish.” The latter term, Kimmel came to believe, “means completely embodying the traditional notions of masculinity—the most important of which is being without apology.”

In 2022, the social scientist Richard Reeves published “Of Boys and Men,” which describes how men are falling behind in contemporary society. In the past forty years, men’s wages have decreased as a percentage of over-all family income, while broader wealth inequalities and job insecurity have grown. Girls now perform better than boys in high school and are more likely to enroll in college, setting them up for better careers. Men today are five times likelier than they were in the nineties to say that they don’t have any close friends. They are also much less likely to receive mental-health treatment than women, and four times more likely to die by suicide. “There are very good reasons for large numbers of young men to feel anxious, to worry about their future, including their relationships with women,” Raewyn Connell, a retired sociologist at the University of Sydney who is credited with co-founding the field of masculinity studies, told me. “That is perhaps what drives the circulation of the ‘alpha male’ idea.”

The alpha-beta framing now feels ubiquitous. A man in Maine recently filed a lawsuit alleging that his First Amendment rights were violated when he was told to stop calling attendees at school-board meetings “soft beta males.” Kimmel told me, “The tech bros and J. D. Vance fanboys and others seem to feel so put upon by wokeness, by political correctness, that they’re constantly being policed. The idea of being able to assert all of that and not have to apologize for being a man—boy, is that attractive to them.” Also attractive, Connell noted, is the business opportunity for “extracting money” and attention “from anxious young men.”

In 2008, Aaron Marino launched a YouTube channel called Alpha M. He was in his early thirties, broke, and the owner of a new camcorder, which he used to offer something that he hadn’t received in life: male guidance. “I didn’t care if you were gay or straight or what religious or political leanings you had,” he told me recently. “I just wanted to help you feel better about yourself.” Marino, who lives near Atlanta, built a following of millions of mostly young men who wanted to know “how to be a gentleman” and “what to do with butt hair.” He discussed sex, too. A recent Alpha M video reveals the “7 Everyday Habits KILLING your ‘Manhood’!”—Marino calls his penis Big Al—and cautions against erectile enemies like seed oils and screen time. All along, he told me, he has been trying to help create the “right kind of alpha male,” which he defines, generously, as “the best version of yourself you can be.”

During the pandemic, many of Marino’s subscribers left. “At my height, I had twenty-five million views a month,” Marino told me. “And that dropped off a cliff to, like, three million. I saw what was getting popular and what you had to say—and I just wasn’t willing to sacrifice my integrity.” Accounts run by male influencers like Andrew Tate, Andy Elliott, and Wes Watson were supplanting him. Watson, who spent nine years in prison for robbery, burglary, assault, and battery, offers the “unbreakable mind-set” to his followers on YouTube. He posts videos of his Bugatti, a romantic interest, and his buddies, most of whom, like him, have head tattoos and huge arms. “Show people that you’ve made a lot of money, have a hot girlfriend, drive a nice car, and there’s your following,” Marino told me. Also: post pejorative-laced challenges for your audience. “MEN are SOFT AF for ONE REASON!!” Watson wrote on Instagram recently.

“THEY DON’T F*CKING Push Themselves Past Their COMFORT ZONE ANYMORE!!” (Last year, Watson was arrested again, for allegedly beating a man at a Miami gym where they were working out. He did not respond to a request for comment, but, in court filings, he describes the beating as “consensual.”)

Alpha-themed training programs have taken off. “It was easy when it was just hunting and living in caves,” one program’s website explains. “Now you have to compete with CEO, celebrities, plastic surgery, and some very expensive toys like Bugatti Veyron. However, in the midst of all that, some men stand out. . . . These are the alpha males.” Fourteen hours and fifteen hundred dollars later, that’s you. A four-day in-person program, in Austin, called Activate Your Alpha promised to “not only take you through the riggers [sic] of pseudo special operations training but also dive deep into the crevices of our own psyches as men.” Elsewhere, the alpha sales pitch is Biblically coded. Rise Up Kings offers a three-day “Awakening” event, in Texas and Florida, that “will transform you into the leader and the man of God you were created to be.” As with ads for many other such courses, the R.U.K. sizzle reel shows men rolling in mud, taking ice baths, and raising heavy objects in the air, like G.I. Jesus, as dramatic music plays. One R.U.K. grad says, “The old man that arrived here three days ago is now dead. And there’s a new man, there’s a king, that has risen.” Other programs sell teens on “Christ-like manhood,” which includes learning “basic auto repair” (two thousand bucks). The blog for the Art of Manliness has a primer on “How to Poop Like a Samurai”—“Legs free is good. Legs free and armed is better.” The Men of War Crucible offers to “forge modern-day warriors and restore the masculine warrior spirit,” as typified by the Knights Templar. (One industry observer told me, “They just beat the shit out of you for days on end. It’s alpha as fuck.”) Warrior Week advertises an acceptance rate similar to that of an Ivy League school. “You must FIND a way in,” the program’s site warns. I D.M.’d Warrior Week’s head coach—who calls himself “the Reverend of Truth” and has said, “Transformation is not theory, it’s war”—asking to visit a session. He called me “brother” in his response, which ended in a rejection. An automated message from another program, which also denied me, read “Thank You, Warrior.”

I had better luck with *RISE*. The program's home page shows a man's mud-flecked face, cast downward, above four short imperatives: "Build COURAGE. Earn CERTAINTY. Find BROTHERS. Become ELITE." James, the Army veteran from Phoenix, had stumbled across it one night last June, while his wife slept. He was a chubby, mixed-race fifty-five-year-old with an earring. He wanted to be the man his wife deserved, he told me, but he was lonely and uncertain; though he'd shown bravery in combat, he didn't feel brave anymore. Certainly not ELITE. He wanted to shed his skin. "I knew I couldn't do it alone," he told me. "So I'm sitting there going through the websites and looking and looking, but all I kept finding were these religious retreats. Then I saw the *RISE* website." Two days later, he spoke with Brendan King, the program's founder.

King, who is in his early fifties, is a former marine, a motivational speaker, and a mental-health and substance-abuse professional. Before launching *RISE*, in 2024, he coached at Warrior Week. He and I first communicated—King in ALL-CAPS text messages—last summer. He invited me to see the culmination of his program's "full-spectrum transformation," held at a wooded property that he owns in Virginia. In the two-month lead-up to the event, King explained, each participant answers daily prompts: "What are the biggest promises you have broken and what has that cost you?" "Write a ruthlessly honest letter to your father." The men share their responses with one another, and with King, through voice memos. "It's designed to truly open a man up," he told me, "so when you get to Virginia we have all the pieces." King keeps notes on each participant during the event, which begins with what he calls the "beatdown."

The beatdown started with a low crawl up King's steep gravel driveway. Relieved of their blindfolds, the men now wore heavy rucksacks filled with colored rocks representing their anger (red), guilt and shame (black), and sadness (blue). "Listen up," King said, as they panted at the halfway point. "What are you learning?"

"Not to quit," someone said.

"Teamwork," another offered.

"What about you?" King asked James, who had been grumbling.

“It’s very easy to just quit—give up, say ‘Fuck it,’ ” James replied after a moment.

“What else in your life have you been close to quitting on?” King asked.

“Myself.”

“O.K., that’s pretty generic. Give me a thing. A specific thing.”

“I’m drawing a blank,” James said.

King looked around. “Who’s not fucking his wife? Is that you?”

“That’s me,” James finally said. “I’ve made excuses. I’ve allowed myself to __”

“Don’t get overly complicated again. What’s the reason? Is she ugly?”

“No.”

“Does she stink?”

“No. It’s me.”

“Is your dick not big enough?”

James paused. “Honestly, it doesn’t work,” he said. “I suffer from E.D.”

“O.K.,” King said, softening his tone. “Here we go.”

James started sobbing. “There’s nothing worse.”

“There was a time when I was younger when I couldn’t get it up,” King offered. “And it fucking embarrassed the fuck out of me.”

“I’ve been there,” another man said. Others nodded.

“I gotta take a fucking needle to my dick,” James went on. “There is no intimacy, no romance.” He stammered. “I can’t give her the things that she

needs. And it’s demoralizing. I don’t feel like a man. So why would I be capable at anything else I do in life?”

“That’s why we’re here, brother,” King said. He addressed the group: “The gift that he’s getting right now is just knowing that other men are sitting here listening to him and saying, ‘Hey, we love you, bro. We get it.’ ” He said, “See your brother in his pain.”

Later, James told King that he had experienced horror in Iraq; he could still smell the burning flesh. He hadn’t told anyone about it. “My mom’s never been the type that really knew how to be emotional,” James said. “Growing up, if I was sad or upset, she always bought me stuff. And that’s what I always equated to happiness. So as an adult, when I was alone and depressed, I would just go buy me something.” He continued, “There was times where I was so alone and I felt like I didn’t have any human interaction. At nine, ten o’clock at night, I’d go to a Walmart, and I would just aimlessly walk, just to have other bodies around.”

Others spoke up, too. Justin, the martial artist, who has suffered from drug addiction, told King, “You’re trying to trigger us.” He was wallowing in a mud pit that the men, wallowing with him, had dug together. King was spraying them with a hose, and Justin blurted out, “My childhood was fucked.” King told him to explain. “My parents used to whup the shit out of me,” Justin said. “I watched my mom stab my dad. I watched my mom run over my dad with the car. I stabbed my mom with a needle when I caught her shooting up. I’ve been through so much pain.”

“What do you take away from it?” King asked. “What’s the gift in this for you?”

“There’s always gonna be suffering,” Justin said. “It’s where you put your fucking mind. And right now my mind is not here.”

“That’s why you got high, bro!” King said. “You’ve disappeared from pain your whole life. I want you to be present. I want you to feel the cold, feel the water, smell the mud, see the mud. So that the day comes and you go, ‘I don’t ever want to fucking go back through that again!’ ”

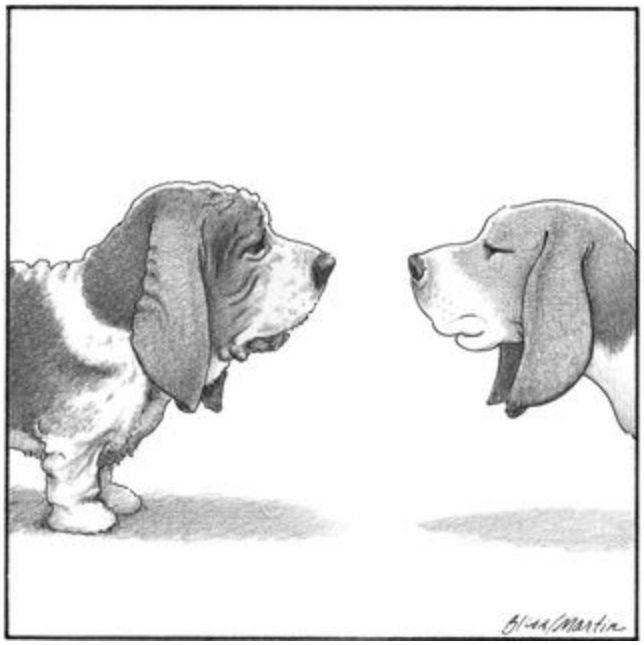
The physical trials of *RISE* brought to mind the Modern Day Knight Project, a controversial forerunner that took a more intense degradation-as-realization approach. The program, launched in 2019, cost eighteen thousand dollars and attracted men who had “totally stifled” their “alpha male and . . . haven’t had an example of an alpha male,” as Bedros Keuilian, its founder, has said. Keuilian, a stout, bearded fifty-one-year-old, founded Fit Body Boot Camp, a global personal-training franchise, in 2010, and now lives in Chino Hills, California. When he was six, his family moved from Armenia to the States, where, he says, he was a “fat kid” and a petty thief. He now describes himself as a “serial entrepreneur” and has linked his work to the will of the divine; he has a million Instagram followers and a book, “Man Up: How to Cut the Bullshit and Kick Ass in Business (and in Life).” On one of his websites, Keuilian claims, “Every day over 2 million people use a product, service, or coaching program I’ve created, which gives me an incredible amount of happiness and significance.” He describes the Modern Day Knight Project in the parlance of sweary self-help hustlers: it helped men do “hard shit” and accept their “calling to greatness.” The Project’s marketing materials note, “Male chimps don’t accept disrespect, it’s not uncommon for one to kill another to defend his honor in the pack.”

The Project’s participants were instructed to fight one another and endure simulated drowning, among other humiliations and discomforts, while remaining awake for most of three days. In a 2023 blog post, a finance guy named Michael Ashcraft described it as a “75-hour men’s military Hell Week.” He hadn’t got beyond the bear crawls when he quit. “With muscles screaming, out of the bear crawl posture, I stood up,” Ashcraft wrote. “Looking at me with eyes of fury, my coach was livid: ‘Mike, get down and crawl!’ Nonplussed, I beckoned for the bell.” Ashcraft tapped out before being ordered to dig a grave, get inside a body bag, and consider his eulogy as instructors piled dirt on top of him.

The Project ended in September of 2024. Keuilian told me at one point that this was a result of Trump’s return and a diminished “attack on masculinity.” Another time, he said that it had become “too cost-prohibitive.” Also, a thirty-year-old Project participant named Richard Spoon had died after a trail run during the program. An obituary for Spoon,

an electrical lineman in Westfield, New York, noted his devotion to his wife, his dog, and exercise. Spoon had seen an Instagram ad for the Project. Kaitlin, his widow, told me that the program had offered him a sense of purpose. Watching videos posted online during the event, though, she grew concerned by his obvious exhaustion: his legs looked strangely pale. “My husband took the whole ‘you can’t quit’ thing so seriously,” she said. “He wanted to be a better person so badly.” She filed a wrongful-death complaint against Keuilian, alleging negligence—there was no emergency medic present. She ultimately settled; Keuilian did not have to admit any fault. For his part, Keuilian blamed Spoon’s death on an enlarged heart—not his program—but noted that it was “heartbreaking.” He said, “A lot of people got hurt.” But nine men, he added, had told him that the Project had saved their lives. “We were touched by God for those five years,” he told me, proudly.

Keuilian more recently founded the Squire Program, which now trains teen-aged boys in six states. It is marketed as “a rite of passage for your son as he becomes a man”—or a “savage servant,” as Keuilian calls righteous men capable of ass-kicking. “Knights had squires that helped them prepare their armor, horse, and weapons for war,” Keuilian told me. “And the squires had the knights as examples of healthy masculinity.” Squire’s website portrays its work as essential to saving America: “The opposition is on a mission to weaken masculine societies and turn them into soft, confused, unsure, passive-aggressive, feminized betas.” It goes on, “Imagine how much easier it is to have greater control over a society when you have a country full of young men who are docile.” I found a YouTube review of Squire by an online observer named Charles White, Jr., titled “Father Son Alpha Male Bootcamp is Cringe.” White calls the program’s creators “scammers” who “prey upon desperate losers” and notes the site’s grammatical errors: “They just view proofreading as beta shit.” Keuilian subsequently copped to the bad grammar. But he did not apologize for “being mean, being loud, and being aggressive,” or for the program’s curriculum, which he calls “a metaphor for life.”



“Who did your work?”
Cartoon by Harry Bliss and Steve Martin

Early one morning, I visited a Squire session at a private gym across the street from a state prison in Chino Hills. It was still dark when we gathered. Keuilian wore a black Squire hoodie. He was joined by a couple of coaches, including Steve Eckert, a bald and bushy-browed former marine who functions as Keuilian’s “hammer.” I noticed a tattoo on his forearm that read “No Excuses”; a nearby wall was scrawled with the words “*LIONS NOT SHEEP*.” Before coming, I’d watched a 2021 video about the Modern Day Knight Project in which Eckert told Keuilian, “You’re almost *racist* if you’re a man these days.” Keuilian told me that Eckert, who “lost his shit on purpose” with adult participants as the Modern Day Knight Project’s “facilitator of suffering,” is more “tranquillized” for the Squire Program’s twelve- to seventeen-year-olds. Eckert had come with his homeschooled fourteen-year-old son, Tyson, who shook my hand while making penetrating eye contact. Tyson, who is training to be a U.F.C. fighter, was there to model manhood and sonhood for the aspiring squires. There were ten teen-agers who’d travelled from around the country with their dads. The parents had each paid nine hundred dollars; most had found Squire online. They all wore black-and-white Squire unis. Some sons looked stoked, others like hostages.

The day began with introductions in a garage attached to the gym. “Man, we’re just here to literally be intentional about getting him his manhood,” Chad, a dad from Dallas, told the room, gesturing to his gangly fifteen-year-old son, Will. Later, Will told me, “I’m mostly just here for my dad.”

Many of the fathers expressed a sincere desire to do better for their sons than their dads had done for them. Keuilian applauded this impulse. His father, a communist, had taught him Ping-Pong, he said, but “was very broke-minded.” At one point, a guest speaker named Keith Yackey, who describes himself online as an “Ex Pastor turned Sex Coach,” stood and asked, “How many of you guys want to grow up to be rich?” Some hands shot up. Others hesitated. “In our culture, they’re shaming you for wanting to be rich,” Yackey continued. “They shame you for wanting to be jacked and juicy. They shame you for wanting to have lots of sex and intimacy with your wife.” He went on, “When the culture is putting people like Harry Styles in a dress and on a magazine and young kids go, ‘I wonder if I’m a girl or not,’ we’re here to say, ‘Fuck that.’ ” Keuilian outlined for the group the “characteristics of a man,” at least according to the 2012 book “The Way of Men,” by Jack Donovan, who I later learned is a far-right “masculinist” and white supremacist who has argued that women should not have the right to vote. The core characteristics of a man, Donovan says, are strength, honor, courage, and mastery.

We assembled outside around a contraption that Keuilian described as a “bear trap from Alaska,” which was set to snap. “Life is full of bear traps,” he explained, noting, among other snares, “a little toot of coke” or a “red-haired girl named Kyla.” He triggered the trap with a stick, which broke in half. The dads and sons hustled to a nearby dirt patch. This was where the Modern Day Knight Project’s participants had once dug their own graves; you could still see the body-size depressions. Eckert instructed the dads and sons to run a few hundred yards with kettlebells, sledgehammers, and sandbags, then to smash open the sandbags. When they were done, Eckert declared, “Taking the heavy shit, still winning—that’s how you get the money, get the girl, get the fucking mansion and the car.”

Back inside: pullups and frog jumps. Eckert referenced “fruitcakes” and “pussies”—things to avoid being. A father lifted his son to help him

complete a pullup. Another dad took a different tack, saying, “Let’s go, fat boy!” As the group hopped and grunted, Keuilian strode through the room with a video crew, shooting a Squire promo (two takes). “A father and son working together is a cheat code for life,” Keuilian told the camera.

Tyson Eckert, the fourteen-year-old, lectured about character, competence, confidence, capability, credibility, competitiveness, and courage. “You need to lift,” he told the class, displaying a shirtless photo of himself and a quote attributed to Socrates that extolled “the beauty and strength” of the male physique. Then it was off to a nearby public park for “jousting.” The boys donned headgear and faced off, one on one, with padded sticks. The coaches encouraged “kill shots” to the head. Each winner received a token, another metaphor. “Tokens mean putting food on the table for your family,” one coach said. I watched a small son get pummelled. “That was fun,” he said flatly when it was over. Heading back to the gym, one notably silent son told me that his father had made him come.

One participant quit and demanded a refund. “It was so degrading to, like, lay in the mud and spread mud all over yourself and then clean yourself off with baby wipes and get sprayed with the hose all over your face,” he said. “I wanted to fight, honestly. I was pissed.”

After a burrito lunch, and a peek at Yackey’s Porsche, Keuilian unrolled a jujitsu mat. “I didn’t think I’d be choking out my dad today,” Will, from Dallas, told me. Then there was an ice bath and an obstacle course scattered with barbed wire and nails. Keuilian had been talking up the bath all day. Each father and son shared a cattle trough, facing each other. As the timer passed seven minutes, Steve Eckert exhorted a whimpering young man to dunk his head underwater. In obvious pain, he complied.

Diplomas were distributed. Then a coach filmed testimonials. “Zac looked at me, and he was, like, ‘I don’t know if I can do it,’ ” a dad from Oregon said, referring to the ice bath. “We locked eyes and we exchanged a look that was, like, ‘You got this, bro,’ and we went back down under and we emerged again victorious, and that moment will be seared in my brain forever.” His son nodded. The dad declared, with boosterish enthusiasm, “Bring your sons. Turn them into men.” I asked a son—not his—if he would tell friends back home about Squire. Probably not, he said: “They might think it was weird.”

On the final night of *RISE*, after the participants peered into one another’s eyes around a campfire and shared what “power” they beheld, the men walked one at a time through the murmuring dark to a small clearing in the woods. A cracked mirror leaned against a tree. Before it, a pile began to form: the stones each man had carried for two days. One by one, they dropped their metaphorical anger, guilt, shame, and sadness and gazed into the glass. “He’s got some things to say to you,” King, standing nearby, told each man. “You’ve got some things to say to him.” Most of the men cried. “I hated what I was looking at,” James, the veteran, told me later. “I hated who I was. I hated all—just all the shit I’ve done. And that was me, I guess, in a way, getting out that last little bit of anger.” He went on, “I just told myself, like, ‘You *are* different. You’re not this bad person you always are trying to make yourself be—and you’ve got a lot to look forward to.’ ”

King had sold these men on something like a Very Tough Mudder, but it turned out to be more touchy-feely than that. Regardless, he assured me, the program “works for the guys who show up.” Other male-development programs make similar promises. Some likely do real harm. But I glimpsed a heartening shift in some of the men at *RISE*. King didn’t mention the anthropologist Claude Lévi-Strauss’s essay “The Effectiveness of Symbols,” from 1949, which argues that people need a familiar language with which to work through their problems on their own terms. But it seems clear that some men, turned off by New Agey lingo or the sterile setting of traditional therapy, may need the bro talk and the mud to begin the work of confronting deeply uncomfortable feelings.

The next morning, the men hiked up to a grassy mountaintop to watch the sun rise. King had saved this view, and their first decent cup of coffee, for the end of the course. The men were each journaling when I approached. “At first, it was, like, ‘I’m weak. I’m the worst out of the group,’ ” James told me. “And then I realized I needed that to show me that I can trust in other people.”

Adam, the youngest participant, sat close by. “When my daughter passed away, she was two months old, and I never got to spend more than a few hours with her,” he told me, staring at the horizon. “I’ve carried that guilt for a very long time, and I can’t do it anymore. My kids deserve a better father than that.” His eyes were wet.

One man was missing from the mountaintop. The night before, Justin, the martial artist, had thrown off his pack during the final ruck. He’d demanded, and received, a ride to his car. I ran into him at the airport the next day. “It was so degrading to, like, lay in the mud and spread mud all over yourself and then clean yourself off with baby wipes and get sprayed with the hose all over your face. I wanted to fight, honestly. I was *pissed*,” he said. “I could have stayed at home and had my wife spray me down with a hose and tell me what I was doing wrong.” He shook his head. “It’s, like, ‘Carry this log all day, and then when you get rid of the log tell me how you feel.’ Of course you’re gonna feel like a weight is lifted off you.” He later got a refund.

Trump’s nomination of Nick Adams as Ambassador caused protests in Malaysia, and ultimately lapsed in the Senate. Adams claimed that, in fact, he’d been “promoted.” Earlier this month, the State Department announced that he is now the “Special Presidential Envoy for American Tourism, Exceptionalism, and Values.” He continues his alpha shtick. When the U.S. men’s team defeated Canada for an Olympic gold medal in hockey, Adams declared on X, “Canadian beta males will be celebrating their silver medal with a Taylor Swift singalong, but only after the land acknowledgement.” He received eight thousand likes for this. I wanted to ask Adams if it was lonely in his man cave while he came up with this stuff, but he didn’t respond to my e-mail.

King sees *rise* as the next step in the evolution of the alpha-male ideal. “I attempted suicide at seventeen, walking into traffic,” he told me. “I was a mess—drugs and alcohol, the whole nine. I thought that becoming alpha—that tough, badass guy—was going to be the thing. And I ruined my first marriage because of it. In my second marriage, I realized the man that my wife wants to see, it’s *not* that man. She wants the man that can sit there and *hold space*.” He’d recently landed on a term for this man: “sovereign male,” someone who “takes the best parts of the alpha and the best parts of the beta.” King acknowledged that getting there need not involve crawling through mud. “You can do therapy, yoga, microdosing, ayahuasca—I’m sober, so that’s not for me,” he said. “But real men need to learn to connect and console.”

Six months after the *RISE* event in Virginia, most of the participants were still in touch, texting frequently in a group chat. “Man, I’ve got fifty unread messages today,” James told me recently. He felt a degree of change. His wife had told him that he was more present. “She says I’m getting softer, too,” he said. “I think that’s a good thing.” ♦

Charles Bethea, a staff writer focussing on the American South, has contributed to The New Yorker since 2008.

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A Reporter at Large

He Helped Stop Iran from Getting the Bomb

A former C.I.A. officer says that he recruited scientists as part of the United States' effort to disrupt Iran's nuclear program.

***By** David D. Kirkpatrick*

March 30, 2026

Kevin Chalker on his ranch in North Carolina. At the C.I.A., he says, he specialized in the "cold pitch"—approaching potential Iranian defectors.Photographs by Thomas Prior for The New Yorker

Not long after the terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001, Kevin Chalker set out to become a spy. He was a thirty-year-old graduate student at the Johns Hopkins School of Advanced International Studies, in Washington, D.C., and he and his wife, Young, had a newborn son. She thought that this idea was terrible. Having grown up in a left-leaning Jewish family in Chicago, she pictured killings and coups. She also worried that Chalker would turn out like his father—a gruff and taciturn man who had once worked for the Central Intelligence Agency. He had ended up as a construction worker in Fort Worth, Texas, where he kept trying to interest his daughter-in-law in Jesus and guns. The last time the family got together, he'd offered to teach her how to use a knife to kill someone.

Chalker reminded her that his father had been an enlisted marine who joined a C.I.A. paramilitary force operating in Southeast Asia during the early years of the Vietnam War, a time when “the agency was doing wacky stuff all over the world.” Chalker promised her that he would do only “traditional espionage—no big deal,” adding, “Everything’s going to be cool.”

He queued up a few days later at the C.I.A. table at his school’s national-security job fair. Chalker had a more martial bearing than most graduate students. He had been a nationally ranked judo fighter and a Golden Gloves boxer in high school and college, and he had spent two years at the United States Air Force Academy, in Colorado Springs. (He dropped out because of an eye injury sustained in a bar fight, and eventually graduated from Texas Christian University.) He also had an aptitude for languages. He could read and speak basic Mandarin and fluent Japanese—he had lived and worked in Japan for several years after college. He had even picked up a little Farsi from an Iranian American girlfriend in college. A C.I.A. analyst at the job fair put Chalker on the phone with a native Japanese speaker at headquarters, to test his proficiency, and soon he was on the way to a Marriott in northern Virginia for the first of half a dozen interviews. In the fall of 2003, he entered the first class of C.I.A. trainees who had applied after 9/11. The training culminated in months at the Farm, the legendary C.I.A. base at Camp Peary, in Virginia. The agency assigned each new trainee a randomly generated alias for internal use. Chalker became Fred E. Snappleton.

I first heard of Chalker in 2018. After a six-year career at the agency, he had set up a security-consulting company, and one of its few publicly known clients was the emirate of Qatar. That spring, the investor Elliott Broidy—a mega-donor to President Donald Trump—filed a lawsuit calling Chalker a former C.I.A. “cyber-operative” and claiming that Qatar had paid him to orchestrate cyberattacks against Broidy and several others. The hacking and leaking of a vast trove of Broidy’s private e-mails revealed that he had tried to turn the Trump White House against Qatar as part of his successful effort to win hundreds of millions of dollars in business with the United Arab Emirates, Qatar’s chief regional rival, for a private intelligence company he owned. I wrote articles for the *Times* about the contents of Broidy’s leaked

e-mails, and I also covered his evolving legal claim against Chalker. I had no reason to doubt that Chalker had played a role in the hack.

So I was surprised when, in early 2024, Chalker sent me an e-mail introducing himself. He had read an article I wrote for this magazine about an innocent American caught up in spy-vs.-spy battles among Persian Gulf monarchies, and he wanted to talk. We arranged to meet at his office, high in the World Trade Center. Now fifty-four, Chalker is nearly six feet tall and barrel-chested, with short brown hair and a thick, graying red beard. His suite in the World Trade Center is cavernous, with a view that sweeps from the Brooklyn Bridge to the Statue of Liberty. A collection of historic encryption machines is displayed in vitrines in the main room, and in his corner office he keeps half-empty bottles of obscure liquors from around the world. The whole place could have accommodated dozens of people. But, aside from a receptionist, he appeared to be alone.

Chalker told me that his consulting firm, Global Risk Advisors, had once employed nearly two hundred people, almost all of them former military and intelligence officers. Before Broidy's lawsuit, the company had earned about a hundred million dollars a year. By 2018, he had also founded a second company, Qrypt, which develops cutting-edge quantum encryption, and had hired dozens of computer programmers. But Broidy's suit received tremendous publicity, driving away all of Global Risk's clients, even the Qataris, and Chalker was forced to lay off its entire staff. Qrypt had been negotiating its first large contract, with the Pentagon, until a counterintelligence official called about Broidy's allegations. Chalker virtually shut down that company, too, although he kept its name on the empty suite in the World Trade Center. Since then, Chalker said, he had "not earned a single penny." He lost a lectureship at Yale after the *Yale Daily News* wrote about Broidy's lawsuit. Banks refused to do business with him. His insurance company had even cancelled his homeowner's policy, because he was deemed too great a risk.

News reports, citing anonymous sources and Broidy's suit, alleged that Chalker had hacked various other eminent figures, including the Emirati Ambassador to Washington; that he had spied on Switzerland's top prosecutor and two Republican senators; and that he had deployed such spy

tricks as covert surveillance and honey traps—sexual lures—in order to help Qatar secure the rights to host the soccer World Cup in 2022. Chalker, who denied all of these allegations, told me that the stress of Broidy's lawsuit made him vomit so frequently that he eventually required esophagus surgery.

"Frankenstein's Monster? From now on, it's just Frankenstein. Welcome to America."
Cartoon by Benjamin Schwartz

Recently, however, he and Broidy had settled the suit. Chalker told me that the terms were confidential but that he wanted to repair his reputation. He had always been an American patriot, he insisted, and to prove it he was willing to talk publicly, for the first time, about his years of clandestine work for the C.I.A.—which, he said, had "prevented Iran from getting a nuke."

Chalker told me that, just as he had promised his wife, he had never personally engaged in combat or killing. Yet, during many conversations in the past two years, he also told me that he had risked his life for the agency, and that he indirectly carried responsibility for some killings. He acknowledged that luck—"right place, right time"—had played a big role in the success of his various covert operations. But he also insisted that he had helped obtain pivotal information that laid the groundwork for more than a decade of American efforts to disrupt the Iranian nuclear-weapons program, from the Stuxnet cyberattacks, which occurred around 2010, to the Obama Administration's nuclear deal, in 2015, to the U.S. air strikes on Iranian atomic-energy facilities in the summer of 2025.

Chalker’s strategy for clearing his reputation—which had been the foundation of his lucrative business—was unexpected, to say the least. It is nearly unheard of for ex-spies to divulge their past activities. But Chalker spoke in detail, aware that I would vet his narrative. As we talked, I sensed a certain resentment. The C.I.A., despite all the crucial and dangerous work he claimed to have done, had offered him no help as the lawsuit ruined his life. I wondered how much of his story I could trust.

Chalker told me that his application to the C.I.A. included an hours-long multiple-choice test. Instead of posing questions about geography or world affairs, the test asked him to tackle hypothetical situations, from the frustrating to the dangerous. Chalker concluded that the test was primarily assessing his psychology. “They don’t want Boy Scouts,” he told me. “They want people just crazy enough to do all the crazy things the agency asks.”

He began as a clandestine-services trainee on the East Africa desk at C.I.A. headquarters, in Langley, Virginia. Part of the desk’s work at the time entailed paying favored Somali warlords to capture or kill suspected Al Qaeda terrorists. Chalker told me, “We would say, ‘Fifty thousand dollars alive or twenty-five thousand dead’—because we preferred to have them alive so we could debrief them.” He told me that one of his assignments was shipping dry ice to Mogadishu; the C.I.A. used it to transport human-tissue samples for DNA testing, to confirm the identity of a corpse before paying a bounty.

A keypad-secured door leading to a safe room in Chalker's house. The decal features a common saying in intelligence circles.

It isn't clear how many high-level targets, if any, were killed while Chalker worked on the East Africa desk. But the broader pattern of C.I.A. payments to certain warlords was later exposed by a diplomat critical of the practice; the payments, intended to bolster warlords and clans who could counter Islamist extremism, helped set off a backlash in Somalia that culminated in an Islamist takeover in 2006. (The U.S. responded by backing an Ethiopian invasion.) Matt Bryden, an expert on the Horn of Africa, interviewed Mogadishu warlords who were on the C.I.A. payroll at the time, and he told me that the payments had triggered "a whole chain of counterproductive consequences, as far as the U.S. was concerned."

Transportation in and out of Mogadishu was another problem for the agency. Armed groups had menaced C.I.A. teams driving to and from neighboring Djibouti. Planes arriving in Mogadishu risked getting hit by gunfire as they descended. The desk chief asked Chalker for ideas. Chalker told me that, by reading cable traffic and studying airplane tail numbers, he discovered that inbound charter flights delivering khat—a legal narcotic

leaf that many Somalis chew for a buzz—always landed without trouble. When Chalker told me this story, he imitated the desk chief's throaty response: "Are you telling me that we are going to use U.S.-taxpayer dollars to hire a bunch of fucking drug dealers to fly in and out of fucking Mog?" Then: "That is the best fucking idea I ever heard." (The desk chief didn't respond to phone messages, but a former senior official told me that the C.I.A.'s inspector general questioned, but ultimately consented to, the reliance on khat-shipment flights. I am withholding certain names out of consideration for the agency's policies around protecting the identities of its officers; elsewhere in this article, I have withheld details in order to protect individuals whose coöperation with the agency may put them in danger.)

After Chalker completed his assignment, he spent months learning defensive driving, the use of weapons, surveillance detection, nighttime land navigation, techniques to assess the credibility of a potential asset, and other tradecraft. Roleplay exercises at the Farm simulated traps or manipulations that officers might face. About a quarter of the class failed to complete the course, and Chalker told me that many others quit the agency within their first year of "being a spook in the real world." His class of more than a hundred and twenty trainees eventually slimmed down to fewer than fifty. At thirty-three, Chalker was older than most of his classmates, with more experience professionally and abroad, and he was tapped to spend a day with James Pavitt, then the agency's director of operations. (Other former officials confirmed that Pavitt, who died in 2022, sometimes invited trainees to join him for a day, though they stepped out during sensitive meetings.)

At the Farm graduation ceremony, envelopes labelled with the first name and last initial of each new officer were placed on a large table. Chalker told me that it was like "finding your seat at a wedding." Inside were the officers' first assignments. Many were bound for Iraq, which the U.S. had recently invaded. Chalker assumed that, based on his language skills, he would work in East Asia. Instead, the slip inside the envelope for "Kevin C." said "*CP/IRANNUC*"—counterproliferation, working against Iran's nuclear-weapons program.

Chalker was shocked. A classmate with a doctorate in physics had been assigned to enter a two-year Japanese-language program, whereas Chalker, fluent in Japanese, had received a D in physics at the Air Force Academy and had never set foot in the Middle East. After a bus dropped the graduates off at Langley, he started to complain. The officer handling Chalker's assignment told him to "go sit in that fucking cubicle and don't speak until spoken to." Chalker told me that the officer happened to be Valerie Plame, whose cover had recently been blown by the George W. Bush Administration, in a retaliatory leak that came after her husband publicly questioned the rationale behind the Iraq War. (When I called Plame, she told me that she did not remember Chalker or use such profanities, but she said that she had been parked in a personnel job at headquarters at the time and would indeed have rejected complaints about a trainee's assignment.)

Before 9/11, Iran's nuclear ambitions had been a relatively low priority for American spies. The C.I.A. knew that, in the late eighties, Iran had bought instructions for making an atomic bomb from the Pakistani scientist A. Q. Khan at a meeting in Dubai. But Khan had sold outdated blueprints, and the agency believed that this had handicapped the Iranians, who had never engineered the necessary centrifuges. Then the invasion of Iraq—although it turned up no evidence of a live threat from weapons of mass destruction—raised new concerns about how close Saddam Hussein had come in the nineties to obtaining a nuclear weapon. President Bush, alarmed, directed the National Security Council to prevent Iran from acquiring one.

A debate over tactics unfolded within the Bush Administration. Chalker told me that, as he understood it, the Pentagon had suggested running commando operations to kill key Iranian scientists, as Israel subsequently did. But the C.I.A. proposed recruiting those scientists to defect, as U.S. spies had once courted Soviet physicists. Chalker paraphrased the agency's pitch: "We can debrief them and learn so much more—and, if they say no, *then* you can kill them." (A more senior agency official confirmed the broad strokes of his account.) The White House liked the agency's idea, and Bush authorized the C.I.A. to conduct clandestine operations to stop Iran from building a bomb.

The C.I.A. program that Chalker described to me became publicly known in 2007, when the Los Angeles *Times* reported on the existence of an agency project called Brain Drain. But the details of the “invitations” to Iranian scientists have not previously been reported. (The C.I.A., which jealously guards its sources and methods, declined to comment on Chalker’s account.)

“My liege, I pledge my sword, my life, and my car for airport pickups and drop-offs, even if it’s, like, super early.”
Cartoon by Lars Kenseth

When Chalker joined the Iran desk, roughly two hundred C.I.A. officers there were working on counterproliferation. But nearly all of them were analysts. Aside from the group’s chief and his deputy, only three others—including Chalker—were trained for field operations. (I reviewed internal documents that independently confirmed these numbers.) Chalker told me that there was an additional challenge: both of the more experienced operators were undergoing treatment for alcoholism, a common problem in their profession. Just weeks after he graduated from the Farm, Chalker became both the desk’s newest case officer and the most senior one available. Chalker recalled that the group’s chief had told him, dryly, “Snappleton, looks like you have a chance to excel.” Chalker suspected that his premature promotion was “a really, really bad idea.”

Chalker learned that the C.I.A. didn’t have a ready roster of Iranian scientists who might be persuaded to defect. In fact, the agency had few

relevant assets inside Iran. About a decade earlier, however, a U.S. spy working in the region had obtained transformational insights from an Iranian nuclear physicist. This scientist, who was given the code name Bernadine, had even passed on detailed knowledge of the meeting in Dubai where the Iranians had bought nuclear secrets from A. Q. Khan. But Bernadine had since become erratic. After refusing any payments for nearly a decade, he had suddenly demanded hundreds of thousands of dollars. And the information he provided increasingly confused C.I.A. physicists; some of it didn't even make scientific sense. Bernadine appeared to be useless—or, worse, a potential double agent. Chalker was asked to come up with a plan to recruit other scientists, and began by reading old cable traffic about how the agency had handled Soviet defectors in the John le Carré days.

Then, just a few months after Chalker set to work, Bernadine called. Like other covert assets, he had been given a phone number at C.I.A. headquarters to call if he wanted to talk or needed to be pulled out of Iran, along with a secret code and a passphrase to authenticate himself. Bernadine was now viewed with such suspicion that Chalker's bosses suspected a setup. The unit's chief told Chalker to arrange a meeting with Bernadine outside Iran but to consider the situation potentially hostile: if the Iranians had compromised Bernadine, their commandos might barge in to capture or kill Chalker. The night before Chalker left to meet Bernadine, in a European city, he thought that these might be his final hours with his family. His wife was pregnant with their second child. After dinner, their two-year-old offered him some of his ice cream, because "sharing is caring."

The global war on terror was near its peak. "Everything was fast back then," Chalker recalls. The agency sent him to the meeting alone and unarmed. According to Chalker, this was standard: if a case officer needed a weapon, "pretty much everything has already gone wrong." When he reached the European city, he identified Bernadine on a prearranged street corner—he was the older man standing alone with quavering hands. They exchanged code words. (Chalker: "It's always something like 'I am looking for an Italian restaurant that serves *lasagna*.' 'I don't eat Italian food but I love *apple pie*.' ") An operative would normally plan to walk alone to a hotel room to avoid being seen with an asset. But in this case the danger

was that Bernadine might be conspiring to kidnap or murder Chalker, so he wanted bystanders to see them together. He escorted Bernadine through a nearby hotel lobby to a room he had reserved.

As soon as the door closed, Chalker began hammering Bernadine with hostile questions. He recited details from the recent reports filed by Bernadine's C.I.A. handler, and demanded that Bernadine explain his suspicious behavior. Bernadine looked baffled—nobody from the C.I.A. had ever treated him so disrespectfully. He said that he had never demanded any payments or taken any C.I.A. money. He insisted that he began working with the agency to protect his children from a dangerous nuclear-arms race, not to get rich. He also denied relaying the technical information that had so confused C.I.A. physicists, calling it obvious nonsense.

Chalker, unsure what to make of these denials, placed a notebook in front of Bernadine, who spent hours filling it with pages of new details and diagrams related to Iran's nuclear program. While Bernadine returned to Iran, Chalker took the next flight out of the country.

A team of C.I.A. officers detained Chalker at Dulles Airport. The agency was worried that he, too, might have flipped, and made him take a polygraph test. But physicists at the Oak Ridge National Laboratory, in Tennessee, said that the new scientific details from Bernadine checked out. Chalker also judged him to be honest. This raised an obvious question: If Bernadine hadn't provided the bogus information or requested the payments, had his previous handler at the agency engaged in deception? Chalker later wrote a report accusing the handler of fabricating intelligence and embezzling from the C.I.A. Chalker said he had been told that the agency eventually recovered some two million dollars in stolen funds, and that the handler served time in prison.

In the months after the meeting in Europe, Chalker arranged to sneak Bernadine's wife and several close family members out of Iran. He then set out to meet again with Bernadine, this time in a Middle Eastern city, with the plan of escorting him to the United States. Using encrypted communications, Chalker directed a C.I.A. case officer in the city to set up a safe house for a rendezvous with Bernadine.

When Chalker explained the plan to me, he taught me a lot of agency jargon. To pick up a key to the safe house, he set up a “brush-pass” in the city’s souk, in a busy alley where he and the local case officer might make contact unobserved. This followed a protocol known as Screening, Cover, and Flow. To spot the case officer, he asked her to describe her appearance, and he assigned her to carry both a “far recognition signal” (her “far” was a copy of the *Financial Times*, which is printed on distinctive pink paper) and a “near recognition signal” (her “near” was a scarf tied around the forward strap of a purse slung over her left shoulder). If she suspected surveillance, she was to remove the scarf to abort the handoff. He also gave the case officer a specific S.D.R., or “surveillance-detection route,” so that he could watch her arriving from an elevated spot and feel confident that nobody was tailing her.

She showed up on time. Yet she carried a different newspaper, and her scarf was tied to the wrong part of her purse strap, in the back. Was this a signal or just sloppiness? Chalker panicked. He took the key, but he sent a message to Bernadine to stay in Iran, then hurried to the airport.

Three security officers met him at Dulles. This time, a team of gray-haired C.I.A. veterans grilled him about each step of his plan. Chalker wondered what he’d done wrong. Had the Iranians grabbed Bernadine? He interrupted his interrogation: “I get it. I am fired. Just tell me why, and let me go home!”

In fact, the questioning of Chalker was part of a postmortem examination of a misstep by the case officer who had handed him the key. She was married to a U.S. official working in the country, and she had rented the safe house using an alias, along with a fake passport. The country’s intelligence officers had already been monitoring her and, upon reviewing the rental agreement, concluded that she was a spy. (Not a very good one—she’d botched the newspaper and scarf signals.) According to Chalker, the country’s intelligence agency had shared the location of the safe house with the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps—who likely would have abducted Chalker had he shown up. It’s not clear how the C.I.A. learned of the tipoff to the I.R.G.C., but it was presumably through intercepted communications.

Working with a different undercover officer, this time in a European city, Chalker successfully extracted Bernadine to America. A C.I.A. cable with the subject heading “Exceptional Performance Award for Fred E. Snappleton” commended Chalker for “exemplary ops sense in guiding the asset and his family during this sensitive time,” and awarded him a twenty-five-hundred-dollar bonus.

To find other potential defectors, Chalker asked Bernadine to name everyone he knew involved in the Iranian nuclear program. After eight months, according to one internal count that I reviewed, Chalker’s debriefings of Bernadine had produced hundreds of intelligence reports, as well as leads for several other operations, which in turn generated more successful defections.

One pivotal source emerged under sordid circumstances. In 2006, Chalker was based in the C.I.A.’s New York station. He sometimes coördinated with the Department of Homeland Security to look out for targets passing through J.F.K., and he developed contacts inside the department’s agencies. One day, Chalker’s counterparts in D.H.S. called with a tip: the local police in a town in the Hudson Valley had received a complaint about an Iranian-born scientist allegedly soliciting prostitutes. F.B.I. special agents told Chalker that he could join them as they questioned the man, and they all headed upstate.

“I didn’t realize it was a chain.”
Cartoon by Ellis Rosen

The scientist, Masud Naraghi, was about seventy years old. He had studied nuclear physics at the University of Michigan in the early sixties, finished a doctorate at Case Western Reserve University, then returned to Iran and worked for its atomic-energy agency. A short-lived marriage to an American woman had given him a green card, and he had quietly returned on his own to the United States in the early nineties, bringing with him a considerable amount of cash. He'd used the money to found an engineering firm, Torr International, just outside Newburgh, New York.

Before Chalker and the F.B.I. agents sat down with Naraghi at his Torr office, Chalker checked with C.I.A. headquarters. He learned that other case officers had debriefed Naraghi years earlier and concluded that he did not know anything useful to the C.I.A. about Iran's nuclear program. But, as Chalker listened to Naraghi answering the F.B.I.'s questions, he felt that the Iranian seemed "too smart to be playing so dumb." Impulsively, Chalker threw out Bernadine's real name and asked if Naraghi knew him. The scientist "turned sheet white," Chalker said. He recalled thinking, with delight, *Oh, you motherfucker*.

Naraghi, whom the C.I.A. code-named Shelve, turned out to have been the founding father of the country's covert nuclear program—the J. Robert Oppenheimer of Iran. But he was no loyalist. Chalker concluded that Naraghi had embezzled from the Iranian government to build up the nest egg he used to found Torr. It took Chalker two years of empathetic listening and confident reassurance to convince Naraghi to coöperate fully. But in time Naraghi shared new insights about how Iran had overcome the weaknesses in A. Q. Khan's blueprints and about the scale and scope of the country's nuclear ambitions. An internal C.I.A. document recommending Chalker for another award said that Naraghi had provided a "new intelligence-reporting stream on the foundations of Iran's desire to become a nuclear power."

As they talked, Naraghi decided that he wanted to write a memoir about his career and defection. The agency envisaged the book as a public invitation for other Iranian nuclear scientists to defect as well, and Chalker worked government contacts at Rupert Murdoch's News Corporation to line up a publisher at its HarperCollins division. But News Corporation executives

somehow directed Chalker to Daniel Halpern, the bushy-haired and left-leaning editor of the company's literary imprint Ecco Press. When I called Halpern, he readily admitted that he was "quite suspicious of the C.I.A.," and said that he vividly remembered Chalker's visit to his office. Chalker and another officer had been "right out of central casting—everybody on the floor could tell they weren't your usual authors," and the whole project felt very "cloak and dagger." Halpern told me he ultimately decided that Naraghi was unwilling to reveal enough for a commercially viable book. Still, a member of the Naraghi family told me that Masud, who died in 2020, left behind a completed manuscript. The family declined to share it with me and is now seeking to sell it to a new publisher.

To recruit an asset, most undercover C.I.A. case officers follow a method referred to during training as *SADRH*, for Spot, Assess, Develop, Recruit, and Handle. The painstaking process might take years. Chalker's job had a different rhythm. He specialized in the "cold pitch"—recruiting a stranger in minutes. Perhaps a relative living in the West agrees to lure a scientist outside Iran, or an eminent physicist invites an Iranian to speak at a conference abroad. (The C.I.A. often set up conferences for that purpose.) Chalker, posing as a curious junior researcher, might arrange to bump into the scientist in a hallway and ask a question about his long-ago dissertation. Could they get coffee?

Chalker said that, at least for him, the curious-scientist ruse never worked. He told me that every actual scientist he approached immediately guessed that he was a spy, from either the U.S. or Israel. "Every time I walk up and say, '*Salaam habibi*, how are you?,' they just think, *Oh, this is it*, and they assume I am there to kill them." Most of the time, he said, the terrified scientist was "compliant" enough to at least sit down in a café. Chalker typically had about ten minutes to explain, as gently as possible, that he was from the C.I.A., that he had the power to secure the scientist and his family a comfortable new life in the U.S.—and that, if the offer was rejected, the scientist, regrettably, would be assassinated. (Chalker tried to emphasize the happier potential outcome.)

Killing a civilian scientist would violate international law. The American government has denied ever doing it, and I found no evidence that the U.S.

has carried out any such murders. A former senior agency official familiar with the Brain Drain project told me all that mattered was that Iranian scientists had *believed* they would be killed, regardless of whether the U.S. actually made good on the threat. And Israel had been conducting a campaign to assassinate Iranian scientists, which made the prospect of lethal reprisal highly plausible. Other former officials with knowledge of the project told me that the C.I.A. sometimes shared intelligence with Mossad which enabled its operatives to locate and kill a scientist. Such information exchanges were kept vague enough to preserve deniability if a more legalistic U.S. Administration later took office.

According to Ronen Bergman's "Rise and Kill First" (2018), a history of Israel's targeted killings, Michael Hayden, Bush's last C.I.A. director, told then President-elect Barack Obama that the Israeli assassination program "has no American relationship whatsoever," and that the agency would, of course, never recommend such a thing. But, Hayden continued, his "broad intelligence judgement" was that the Israeli killings were very useful, because "the death of those human beings had a great impact" on deterring Iran from developing a bomb.

The Iranian news media has blamed the deaths of at least eighteen scientists in the past two decades on Israeli and American spies; Israeli officials have done little to hide Mossad's role in the assassinations, many of which were carried out with the assistance of internal Iranian opposition groups. In 2007, Ardeshir Hosseinpour, a physicist in his mid-forties, was killed in Isfahan, either by radiation or by poisonous gas. In 2010, a bomb planted on a parked motorcycle in Tehran killed Massoud Ali Mohammadi, who was fifty. Later that year, a bomb affixed to the car of Majid Shahriari, another scientist in his mid-forties, killed him and injured his wife. In 2011, gunmen on motorcycles shot and killed Darioush Rezaeinejad, aged thirty-five, as he and his wife were picking up their daughter from school; his wife was also wounded. In 2012, yet another bomb affixed to a car killed the thirty-two-year-old Mostafa Ahmadi Roshan, along with his driver. And so on.

Chalker told me that he didn't know the exact fates of the scientists who refused his offers. This wasn't surprising, given that intelligence agencies compartmentalize information about sensitive operations. Citing stories

from friends in the U.S. Special Forces, Chalker said he believed that, on at least a few occasions, U.S. commandos—such as Delta Force operatives, Navy *SEAL*s, or members of the C.I.A.'s paramilitary Ground Branch—have carried out targeted killings of Iranian military officers. (Chalker said that the operators even had a term of art for such killings: X-boxing.) He could not name any Iranian scientists assassinated by Americans. But he is confident that those who rebuffed him were, in fact, killed—one way or another.

Israel's assassination campaign sometimes complicated Chalker's attempts to recruit defectors. He told me that an Iranian scientist who had agreed to coöperate with him—code-named Hustle—once casually mentioned that he was considering an invitation from a colleague outside Iran to attend a conference abroad. Surmising that Mossad must be trying to draw Hustle out of Iran in order to kill him, Chalker wrote out an urgent cable for the C.I.A. to send to the Israelis, taking the exceptional step of disclosing himself and his operation. He summarized the cable to me: "You do *not* have dibs. . . . And do *not*, I repeat, do *not* kill the white guy, about five-eleven, with brown hair and a red beard, who may be with him." Hustle eventually defected to the U.S., via a city in Asia. According to an internal C.I.A. report, Hustle participated in "an intense, week-long debrief session" with specialists from the C.I.A. and the Department of Energy, and provided "detailed re-engineering" schematics of "Iran's most advanced and sensitive nuclear technology," along with "the locations of clandestine facilities within the missile development node of Iran's weaponization program." Chalker and a C.I.A. lawyer persuaded a university administrator to ask a member of its physics faculty to assess Hustle's qualifications to enroll in graduate school; Hustle went on to complete a degree in the U.S. and started a successful new career. (I independently confirmed those aspects of his résumé.)

Chalker told me that two of the scientists he'd approached outside Iran—"complete dicks" who were "very confrontational"—had brusquely rebuffed him; he was certain that they had immediately reported him to Iranian intelligence, and in both instances he raced to an airport. He was also sure that both men were eventually killed, though he felt little remorse about it. Each scientist had made a choice to side firmly with Iran in a

covert war with the U.S., at a time when Iranian-backed militias were actively killing American soldiers in Iraq. (The Pentagon has said that more than six hundred Americans died at the hands of such Iranian proxies.)

Another scientist was tantalized enough by Chalker's offer to help him defect that he talked for more than two hours. But the scientist worried that the C.I.A. could not fulfill its promise to protect his wife and his children from the Iranian authorities. Chalker told me that he had insisted, "No, I can do this! I've done this so many times before—you don't understand! And, you know, you are gonna *die* if you don't let me do this." The scientist still refused, telling Chalker, "If I say yes, they might die, and, if I say no, only I will."

Chalker told me that he "felt really bad about that one." The scientist in question felt no loyalty to the Iranian government and, indeed, would have been happy to help defeat its nuclear program. He was sacrificing himself to protect his family. "My only job was to make them feel secure and safe, to get them to agree to let me take them out," Chalker told me. "I just couldn't convince him."

Another Iranian scientist, whose code name was Ejection, had started out even more skeptical. At their initial meeting, Ejection clung to the conviction that Chalker was a Mossad operative trying to lure him to his death. To establish his C.I.A. bona fides, Chalker told me, he began "peeling the onion." First, he named other Iranian scientists—including close former colleagues of Ejection's—whom he had helped to defect with their families. Then Chalker pulled from a hidden compartment in his jacket a photograph of himself, in the U.S., standing next to one of those colleagues. When that didn't work, Chalker produced a note from another such colleague, handwritten in Farsi, urging Ejection to trust Chalker's offer. Finally, Chalker repeated a detail of Ejection's medical history that only his good friends would have known.

“It’s so hard to find a pet that likes living in the city.”
Cartoon by Christopher Weyant

But Iranian authorities had told Ejection that the Israelis had killed all of the former colleagues Chalker claimed to have recruited. He remained convinced that everything Chalker said was part of a Mossad plot: the Israelis could have staged the photograph using a mask or a wax dummy; they could have tortured a colleague into writing something in Farsi, then digitally manipulated the letters to form a fake message; they could have hacked Ejection’s medical records. Giving up, Chalker left Ejection a phone number to call if he changed his mind before he was killed.

Not long afterward, in Iran, Ejection unexpectedly ran into the daughter-in-law of one of those former colleagues. Defying Chalker’s warnings, she had flown into the country to visit her extended family. (Another member of that family confirmed to me that they had returned to Iran for such visits.) In Chalker’s telling, Ejection offered the woman condolences about her father-in-law’s assassination by Mossad. She said not to worry—he was alive and living in the U.S., under the protection of a burly C.I.A. officer with short brown hair and a red beard. Ejection, convinced at last, called the number Chalker had left him.

More than two years after their abortive encounter, Chalker sat down again with Ejection, in another hotel room in a European city, and congratulated him on the new life awaiting him in the U.S. Chalker was joined by a C.I.A. translator and by a physicist from the Oak Ridge National Laboratory, who debriefed Ejection for three days. Ejection turned out to have access to Natanz, in central Iran, where a secret facility had been equipped with

underground buildings capable of housing thousands of centrifuges for enriching uranium. He knew much more than expected. By the second day, a cable from headquarters informed Chalker that the plan had changed. Instead of flying Ejection to America to start that new life, Chalker was told to persuade him to return to Iran to find out even more.

Improvising, Chalker seized on a professional insecurity that he knew haunted Ejection. Chalker told me that his pitch went like this: Ejection was a star scientist with a prodigious intellect, but he had never been promoted to the level he felt his work merited. Surely the Iranian system had been unfair to him. Chalker recalls telling Ejection, “People have never treated you with the respect you deserve, but this is your chance. You can prove to everyone that you are smarter and better than they are.”

For Ejection, returning to Iran meant risking his life. He said that he would go back only if the C.I.A. paid him hundreds of thousands of dollars. Chalker, as it happened, had brought along a duffelbag containing three million dollars. But he knew the byways of Iranian culture, and worried that Ejection would stop trusting him if he coughed up the money without haggling. Chalker talked him down to about ten thousand dollars, in part by explaining that carrying more cash would make him too conspicuous at the airport. Sometimes, Chalker told me, a case officer’s job is “to convince someone that something is a really good idea—even though it is actually the worst idea *ever*.”

Ejection agreed to return to Iran for a short period. Chalker, who handed him off to another case officer, never learned where he ended up, or whether he survived. Another cable to Fred E. Snappleton commended Chalker for giving the agency invaluable “eyes and ears on the ground” inside Natanz.

According to Chalker, another scientist, code-named Sealion, provided new intelligence about a Syrian weapons program. An asset code-named Omitted added more details during a meeting in a Middle Eastern city, and then returned to Syria; not long afterward, Israel bombed a facility where Omitted was believed to be working, and Chalker told me that he was unsure if Omitted was killed. Former C.I.A. officials told me that

intelligence reports from Chalker's assets were presented to the highest levels of the U.S. government, including to Presidents Bush and Obama.

Espionage is never a solo performance. The resources of a state are what make spying effective: collaboration with friendly foreign services; the collection of intercepted communications; interpretation and assessment by legions of trained analysts; the unknowing collaborations of many case officers, each siloed off from the others. The revelations from Chalker's defectors were one strand of a long cord, and he also had the advantage of fortuitous timing. The American invasion of Iraq had elevated Iranian scientists' fears about the potential consequences of pursuing a weapon of mass destruction. In 2005, the election of the Iranian President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, a bellicose hard-liner, spooked some of the country's scientists, making them willing to undermine the nuclear project.

Nevertheless, Chalker's former colleagues told me that he had demonstrated an indisputable knack for the cold pitch. In my many hours of interviews with him, he appeared relentlessly attentive, and he somehow managed to come off as guilelessly earnest even as he recounted a career of ruthless deception. Then, there is his fighter's frame. It may have been a dead giveaway at a conference of physicists, but one American colleague told me that looking so much like a spy from central casting had helped Chalker persuade potential defectors that he could actually deliver on a promise of protection.

The most salient reason for his success, though, was surely his existential offer: defect or die. One of Chalker's colleagues told me that, against the backdrop of so many Israeli assassinations, Chalker's interactions with Iranian scientists could almost be considered humanitarian—he had been "throwing them a lifeline." Of the many scientists he approached, three-quarters ultimately agreed to coöperate.

To corroborate his recollections, I obtained partially redacted excerpts of employee reviews by Chalker's C.I.A. supervisors. As at many workplaces, agency assessments can be hyperbolic, reflecting the effusiveness of a supportive boss trying to promote the accomplishments of his team and win his employee a raise. But even a skeptical reading confirmed that Chalker had done his job. Some reviewers praised his understanding of the

“acquisition cycle” for recruiting an asset, and the “balance between empathy and prescriptive direction” that he brought to his work. One veteran supervisor noted that Chalker’s work “produced Intel of tremendously high impact” that was “regularly briefed to senior policy makers and directly influenced U.S. Policy.” Another supervisor said that the “only criticism” of Chalker within the agency was that he could sometimes fall behind on administrative tasks. Yet another credited Chalker with either debriefing or recruiting Iranian scientists across successive generations of the nuclear program’s history; the reviewer called this a “unique Counterproliferation milestone.”

Cumulatively, Chalker’s defectors contributed to what several former senior officials told me had been a dramatic leap forward in the U.S. government’s understanding of Iran’s nuclear ambitions in those years. The consequences were manifold. Around 2010, U.S. and Israeli spies used that intelligence to help carry out the Stuxnet cyberattack, which reportedly destroyed a thousand centrifuges used to enrich uranium. In 2015, the Obama Administration also relied on the intelligence as it negotiated a diplomatic agreement to constrain Iran’s nuclear-weapons program. Gary Samore, a former senior official in the Obama Administration who worked on the deal, told me that negotiators had felt confident the agreement would restrict all of Iran’s uranium enrichment because, in the previous decade, the C.I.A. had achieved such a comprehensive understanding of the program, with “tremendous penetration” into its facilities, sometimes including details “down to the blueprints.” Although Samore personally never knew which information had come from any “specific defector,” he told me that the “picture was very complete.”

Drawing at least in part on information from Chalker’s defectors, the Pentagon constructed life-size underground facsimiles of Iranian nuclear facilities where the scientists had worked, attempting to duplicate even the thickness of the walls. The Air Force relied on the facsimiles to plan the bombing raids carried out in the past two years against nuclear facilities in Natanz, Fordow, and Isfahan, and U.S. Special Forces have used a facsimile for training. In the current war, President Trump is reportedly considering ordering a commando operation against one of the Iranian facilities to capture enriched uranium.

Chalker's wife, though, never forgot his promise that spy work would be "no big deal." In 2009, the agency reassigned him from New York to Rome. He and his family were to move into an apartment building that was home to a Syrian diplomat who was believed to have knowledge of his country's chemical- and biological-weapons programs. The agency hoped that Chalker and his wife would befriend the diplomat's entire family. But, just before the move, Young learned that her father had cancer, and she insisted on a change of plans. She told Chalker that he was always away, that he never saw his sons, and that he did not make enough money. Chalker said that she'd given him an ultimatum: "You can leave if you want, but I am staying here, and I am keeping the kids." In November, 2010, Chalker, who was approaching forty, formally resigned from the agency. He began coaching Little League and had more time to practice martial arts with his boys. Looking back, Young told me that she thought Chalker had tried to be a decent husband and father—"if you catch me on a good day."

On December 27, 2017, Robin Rosenzweig, the wife of Elliott Broidy and a legal adviser to his investment firm, received what appeared to be a security alert from Google, asking for her Gmail password. It was a phishing attempt, and when she fell for it hackers took over her account and gained access to Broidy's. Within months, they had leaked tranches of his private messages to multiple journalists, including me. In addition to revealing his efforts to profit by turning the White House against Qatar, the disclosures forced him to plead guilty to conspiring to act as an unregistered foreign agent for the Chinese government and a Malaysian financier, for which he agreed to forfeit $6.6 million to the U.S. He might have faced a further penalty, or even jail time, but before he was sentenced—or made to forfeit the money—he received a pardon from President Trump. (Years earlier, in 2009, Broidy had also pleaded guilty to bribing New York State pension-fund managers, and agreed to pay the state eighteen million dollars.)

Broidy's criminal convictions notwithstanding, his allegations against Chalker appeared plausible. Global Risk Advisors had been a shadowy operation. A list of specialties on its website had included "intelligence-based advisory services" that might employ techniques "developed from years of expertise within the US government." For a time, Global Risk had advertised "penetration testing"—hacking clients in order to assess their

cyber defenses. Moreover, Qatar was virtually its only publicly known client. Global Risk registered an office in Doha in the fall of 2017, shortly before the Broidy hack, during an escalating feud between the U.A.E. and Qatar (which had involved credible allegations of hacking by both sides). And Global Risk looked highly profitable, despite the absence of other known clients. Chalker and Young lived with their sons in a large apartment in Manhattan, and they also owned sprawling ranches in Texas and North Carolina. Many former U.S. national-security and intelligence officials have cashed in by selling consulting services to Persian Gulf monarchies whose agendas often differ from U.S. policy goals.

By 2022, lawyers for Broidy had revised his lawsuit against Chalker to charge that Qatar had paid Chalker “tens of millions of dollars” for “denigration campaigns” against the country’s critics. The complaint cited new information from five unnamed former Global Risk employees. Broidy’s lawyers also alleged that Chalker had orchestrated the hacking of the Emirati Ambassador to Washington and had used spy tactics against critics who opposed Qatar’s role as host of the World Cup in 2022. One detail in the suit was verifiable and seemed to bolster its assertions: Global Risk had set up various shell companies in Gibraltar, and in 2017 and 2018 at least forty million dollars had passed in and out of these accounts. The revised lawsuit, citing the five former employees, claimed that these were payments from Qatar. In 2022, an article in the Associated Press, which quoted anonymous former employees who sounded similar to those cited in the lawsuit, reported that the F.B.I. was investigating Chalker for potential violations of laws against providing foreign governments with information about the covert tactics of American spies. The F.B.I. declined to comment to the A.P.; a lawyer for Chalker denied all of the allegations, and said that he knew of no federal investigation. (Through a spokesman, Broidy declined to comment on any of this.)

Vetting Chalker’s account of his C.I.A. career had led me to conclude that he had been a reliable narrator. When it came to his business career, however, I found a few inconsistencies. For example, he insisted to me that his company’s work for Qatar had begun *after* the country won the right to host a World Cup, in December of 2010. He said that his work had consisted only of making security preparations for the event, including

helping to set up a state-of-the-art cyber-operations center and training Qatar's internal security and intelligence services. Chalker also told me that he'd taken a leave before formally resigning from the C.I.A., and that he had used the time to figure out how to make money. When pressed, he admitted that, during this period, he and a former C.I.A. officer had set up a short-lived business partnership and pitched the Qataris on hiring them as security consultants; he said that he may have provided unpaid services or advice in that context. After further reporting, I concluded that this was likely a cropping of the full picture. Two advisers to Qatar told me that Global Risk had also conducted background checks and written reports on people linked to campaigns criticizing Qatar; corporate-intelligence firms often provide such open-source research. (Chalker later acknowledged that research to me.) I also reviewed credible documents that appeared to show that, in 2010, while Qatar was still competing to host the World Cup, Chalker's business partnership had at least sought payment from Qatar, and had hired the private intelligence firm Diligence to snoop around, either for Qatar or at the behest of individual Qatari clients. (In 2020, a London-based consultant close to the Emiratis accused Diligence of bugging him, breaking into his mailbox, and trailing him; Diligence acknowledged conducting surveillance it said was legal and "justified.")

In the course of my reporting, I met several enemies Chalker had made over the years, sometimes in disputes over money. When I pressed him about the anonymous former employees, he admitted that he had been a hot-tempered and secretive boss, and that Global Risk's work culture—dominated by former spies and commandos—had been characterized by what he called "toxic masculinity." Turnover was high, and he readily named a few employees who had left on bad terms and might have seen a chance to profit by coöperating with Broidy. After all, Broidy's private intelligence company, Circinus, hires the same kinds of former spies and commandos that Chalker's once did. In that sense, Broidy and Chalker—one working for the U.A.E., the other for Qatar—were two of a kind.

As Broidy's lawsuit dragged on, the allegations it kicked up grew increasingly far-fetched. The A.P. reported obtaining business proposals that Chalker had supposedly submitted to Qatar; Fox News, the *Free Press*, and two Swiss news outlets eventually posted some of this material online. One

putative proposal, titled “Project Endgame,” evidently used “Endgame” as a code name for the Emirati Ambassador to Washington, Yousef Al Otaiba. Printed on Global Risk letterhead, dated March of 2017, and signed only with the initial “K,” it appeared to outline a plan for hacking Otaiba’s e-mails, which leaked later that spring. But the proposal was full of cartoonishly goofy faux spy talk. (“Imminent Threat: Qatar’s enemies are already plotting against you. The time to act is now!”) And it looked less like an authentic pitch to officials in Doha than like a document calculated to embarrass Qatar in the West. (“An attack on Hamas is an attack on Qatar. An attack on the Muslim Brotherhood is an attack on Qatar.”) Echoing right-wing conspiracy theories, the proposal also offhandedly listed the *Times* as among “Qatar’s media assets.” John Sipher, a prominent former C.I.A. officer who reviewed some of the supposed proposals as a potential expert witness for Chalker, told me that the documents were “loopy” and “horseshit,” and that they could not have been written by anyone with actual U.S.-government experience. (The *Times*, the Washington *Post*, the *Wall Street Journal*, and the BBC never reported on the documents or their allegations.)

Chalker himself had never been a cyberoperative; in any case, it would hardly require the expertise of a former C.I.A. officer to carry out the run-of-the-mill phishing attacks that snared both the Ambassador and Broidy. Nor, I learned, did Chalker stop working for the agency after resigning. Several former officials told me that Chalker had become a contractor for the agency and for the Pentagon. Global Risk had provided the C.I.A. with covert financial and logistical services for operations around the world. People familiar with Global Risk’s operations told me that the Gibraltar shell companies had been used to move C.I.A. money, and that much of Chalker’s revenue had come from covert work for the U.S. government. Chalker had stayed in contact with the deputy chief of the C.I.A.’s station in Doha while working for Qatar, and had obtained State Department licenses to provide the training and services that Global Risk sold to the country. Pawel Chudzicki, whose law firm handled the licenses for Global Risk, told me that the State Department had conducted an inquiry in response to the Associated Press article and identified no violations of the law. Indeed, given how much money Chalker was making off the C.I.A. and the military, I found it hard to imagine that he would jeopardize his cash flow by

hacking Broidy, a prominent Republican fund-raiser close to Trump—much less by spying on senior American lawmakers.

Former U.S. officials told me that, in early 2023, Chalker's lawyers—citing, among other things, the potential exposure of the Gibraltar shell companies—formally asked the C.I.A. to invoke national-security concerns and quash Broidy's lawsuit. But the agency's lawyers, following standard policy, responded that they would intercede only when the possibility of Chalker's testifying was truly imminent. Feeling that the agency had abandoned him, Chalker groused to friends that, as recently as September 11, 2021, the C.I.A.'s New York station had borrowed his World Trade Center office to hold a memorial event with two hundred guests. Three months later, he complained, the station had disinvited him from its annual holiday party because of the stigma surrounding the lawsuit.

The unnamed former Global Risk employees remained the linchpin of Broidy's lawsuit. By 2024, Broidy's lawyers were requesting an extraordinary protective order that would have blocked them from publicly revealing their names, appearing in open court, or facing questions from Chalker's lawyers, as though they were testifying against a Mafia don. An anonymous declaration from one of the former employees referred vaguely to Chalker's unspecified "capabilities" and claimed that the employee feared for the safety of "myself and/or my family" if Chalker ever learned who he was. (None of the unnamed former employees cited in the lawsuit agreed to speak with me on the record.) Meanwhile, an article in the Jerusalem *Post* speculated, without evidence, that Qatar might have paid Chalker to train Hamas fighters. Chalker told me, incredulously, "I was an Iran guy for the agency, my wife is Jewish, and *I* am training Hamas?"

Finally, on April 2, 2024, a magistrate judge gave Broidy's lawyers a one-month deadline to justify the supposed safety concerns of the former Global Risk employees—veterans of the Special Forces or the C.I.A. who presumably knew how to look out for themselves. Six days later, Broidy settled. Four people familiar with the terms told me that no money changed hands. Chalker faced no criminal charges. Senior national-security officials do not appear to have taken the allegations seriously, either: while the lawsuit was unfolding, Qrypt, Chalker's other company, signed technology-

licensing agreements with both the Oak Ridge National Laboratory and the Los Alamos National Laboratory.

Regardless of the merits of Broidy's lawsuit against Chalker, it effectively doubled as an attack on Qatar, by portraying the country as involved in seedy digital espionage. The resulting negative publicity increased the perceived risks for U.S. consultants, lobbyists, and former officials who might have considered working for Qatar, scaring them off or causing them to raise their prices. All of this surely pleased Qatar's rivals, the U.A.E. and Saudi Arabia. (The e-mail leaks revealed that Broidy had sought lucrative contracts with both countries.)

Still, Chalker is no innocent. Marko Milanovic, a professor at the University of Reading, in Britain, and an expert on international law, told me that the killing of Iranian nuclear scientists in peacetime, whether by Israel or by the United States, was "just murder—just killing someone you don't like." Imagine, he said, if Russian or Iranian spies killed American computer scientists merely because they were working on artificial intelligence that had a military application. Of course, a former spy complicit in such killings was not a legitimate target, either. But Milanovic said, of Chalker's recent difficulties, "Am I going to cry you a river? No."

I asked Chalker about this perspective, and, to my surprise, he said that he could see parallels between his activities as a spy and Broidy's lawsuit against him. "It was a highly successful nation-state denial-and-disruption campaign," he said. "Just look at what it cost me—physical and mental health, lost friendships, lost business." He concluded, "I have to admit, they did a bang-up job." ♦

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Annals of Religion

At Synagogues, Tensions Are Boiling Over

Disagreements about Gaza and Zionism have divided congregations.

By Eyal Press

March 30, 2026

In South Orange, New Jersey, a "We Stand with Israel" sign outside the Congregation Beth El synagogue became a flash point.Illustration by Ben Wiseman

Early one morning last fall, Nathaniel Felder left his home, in Maplewood, New Jersey, dressed in a navy sweatshirt and a gray yarmulke. After putting on a backpack, he walked to Irvington Avenue, the location of Congregation Beth El, a Conservative synagogue in neighboring South Orange. Outside the shul's entrance, a sign greeted visitors: "We Stand with Israel and We Pray for Peace." Felder reached into his backpack and unfurled a sign of his own. It proclaimed, "Starvation Is Against Jewish Values: Our Support of Israel Cannot Be Unconditional."

Felder angled his sign so that it would be visible to people driving past and also to parents who would soon be dropping their kids off at a Hebrew school that the synagogue runs. Before any congregants showed up, however, a police car pulled into Beth El's parking lot, and a pair of officers from the South Orange Police Department stepped out. One of them told Felder that the precinct had received a complaint about a trespasser at the synagogue. Felder explained that he was a member of the congregation and that his kids attended the Hebrew school. After going inside the synagogue to verify this, the officers warned Felder that posting a sign without prior approval was prohibited—if he did not leave the property, he would be arrested, and potentially banished from Beth El. Felder agreed to stand on the sidewalk, which is public property, but he refused to leave or fold up his sign.

When Felder joined Beth El, in 2020, the "We Stand with Israel" sign hadn't yet been mounted. It was hung roughly a year after Hamas's October 7, 2023, attack on Israel, to express solidarity with the twelve hundred people who were murdered—in the largest massacre of Jews since the Holocaust—and with the two hundred and fifty-one people Hamas had abducted. ("Bring Them Home Now!" was inscribed on the other side of the sign.) Felder understood the impulse behind the shul's decision. The yarmulke he was wearing had originally belonged to his maternal grandfather, an observant Jew who had profoundly shaped Felder's understanding of Judaism and his sense of right and wrong. His grandfather had been an ardent Zionist who, in 1975, sold his house, on Long Island, and moved to Beersheba, a city in southern Israel. Felder grew up in Montclair, where he joined Habonim Dror, a progressive Zionist youth movement. In 2001, after graduating from high school, he deferred college to spend a year in Israel with some Habonim friends, living for a while on a kibbutz and then in Karmiel, a city in the north. That year, marked by the suicide bombings of the second intifada, was tense and bloody. Felder returned to America with a heightened appreciation of the trauma and insecurity that pervaded Israel—a sentiment that resurfaced when he learned about the October 7th attack. He was especially upset to learn of the carnage at places such as Nir Oz, a kibbutz that reminded him of the one he'd lived on.

But Felder also feared that the attack would provoke unprecedented violence against Palestinians, and believed that being Jewish required adhering to certain moral precepts. Last spring, when he read reports that famine was intensifying in Gaza because Israel was blocking food and other humanitarian aid from entering the territory, the “We Stand with Israel” sign began to trouble him. Among other things, he was worried that neighbors would assume that he and his fellow-worshippers condoned Israel’s blockade, which Felder saw as a desecration of what his grandfather had taught him was the most sacred Jewish tenet: protecting human life. As the crisis in Gaza intensified, he sent an e-mail to Jesse Olitzky, Beth El’s senior rabbi, and Rachel Marder, the associate rabbi, in which he shared his distress and asked the rabbis to reconsider the sign. He was told that it would remain. Two months later, Felder wrote to the rabbis again. By this point, experts were warning that half a million people in Gaza were at risk of starvation, and organizations such as the Rabbinical Assembly, an association of Conservative rabbis, were urging immediate action to alleviate civilian suffering. Felder suggested that the Beth El rabbis send out a congregation-wide e-mail offering guidance on how to respond to the humanitarian crisis—say, by directing members to relief groups or by encouraging members to contact their representatives in Congress to exert pressure on Israel.

No such e-mail was sent. By late August, Felder had started to think about staging a demonstration at Beth El—even though he had never attended a protest and disliked drawing attention to himself. Felder, an architect with an obsessive streak, thought extensively about the design of his banner, ultimately opting for a white sign with lettering the precise shade of blue as the Star of David on the Israeli flag. He was equally exacting about the sign’s message. Instead of criticizing Israel, he decided, it should emphasize a core value of Judaism. Felder hoped that this would bring the members of Beth El together.

As he soon learned, the sign had the opposite effect.

“Go fuck yourself—you’re trash!” one man shouted at him.

“Get a life!” another person yelled.

Not only did some members disagree that Israel bore moral responsibility for the famine in Gaza; they were furious that Felder was making this insinuation at the place where they came to worship and to educate their kids about Judaism. But other people came up to Felder and engaged him in dialogue. Before heading off to the shul that morning, he had texted a photograph of his banner to a WhatsApp group for synagogue members who were distraught about the destruction of Gaza and dismayed by the lack of attention it was receiving at Beth El. Felder notified the group that he would be standing "outside the parking lot entrance." An hour and a half later, a person in the chat uploaded another photo, which showed several members of the group standing alongside Felder and his sign.

Half a century ago, Norman Podhoretz, the editor of the magazine *Commentary*, published an essay in the *Times* in which he observed that American Jews "have all been converted to Zionism." The event that had precipitated this change was the 1973 Yom Kippur War, a surprise assault on Israel launched by Arab forces on the holiest day on the Jewish calendar. The attack had punctured an air of invulnerability created by the 1967 Six-Day War, in which Israel had swiftly captured the Golan Heights, the Sinai Peninsula, the West Bank, and Gaza from its Arab neighbors. The American Jewish community responded to the Yom Kippur War, which killed nearly three thousand Israeli soldiers, by flooding Israel with donations; doctors and students volunteered to join the war effort. Podhoretz found it striking that among the converts were many Reform Jews, who had often expressed opposition to the idea that Jews constituted a nation, as well as some Orthodox Jews who had previously seen Zionism as a heresy, believing that only God could end their people's perpetual exile. Even some left-wing socialists had come around, Podhoretz noted, among them Irving Howe, the editor of *Dissent*, who admitted that his emotional reaction to the Yom Kippur War had been "astonishingly intense."

It would not have been unreasonable to assume that, after October 7th, this dynamic would repeat and that the determination to bring home the Israeli hostages—twelve of whom were U.S. citizens—would galvanize a new generation. There was no such unity. For some American Jews, the atrocities perpetrated by Hamas, followed by the eruption of pro-Palestinian protests on college campuses, sparked a renewed sense of collective identity

and *Ahavat Yisrael*—love for the Jewish people. For others, Israel's merciless assault on Gaza, which has killed more than seventy-two thousand Palestinians, and the increased settler incursions into the West Bank alienated them from the Jewish establishment and from Zionism itself.

Cartoon by Ali Solomon

Even the word "Zionism" now stirs fierce debate. In the view of Israel's founders, few American Jews today would qualify as Zionists, since they have chosen to live in another country rather than to participate in the building of a Jewish national home in Palestine, which was classical Zionism's chief aspiration and goal. But, for many American Jews, Zionism has come to represent the belief that there should *be* such a home—both because of the Jewish people's ties to their ancestral land and because of the centuries of persecution that Jews endured, culminating with the Holocaust. This form of Zionism remains deeply rooted in the American Jewish community, particularly the Modern Orthodox branch. At many Jewish institutions, rejecting Zionism is indeed regarded as a form of sacrilege. But

more and more American Jews are having a hard time reconciling other core features of their identity, such as a belief in equality and social justice, with support for a country whose current leaders—a far-right alliance headed by Benjamin Netanyahu—pass racist laws and espouse Jewish supremacy. Some Jews have gone further, condemning Israel as an illiberal "ethno-state" that oppresses Palestinians and should be abolished in its current form.

This past October, a survey by the Washington *Post* found that forty-six per cent of American Jews supported the war in Gaza and forty-eight per cent opposed it. Thirty-nine per cent believed that Israel had committed genocide. Disagreements over the war have disrupted family dinners, upended friendships, and splintered congregations. Last fall, in a sermon delivered during Rosh Hashanah, Angela Buchdahl, the senior rabbi at Central Synagogue, in Manhattan, declared that she had never been more afraid to talk about Israel, for fear of offending some worshippers. "I want to tell you about my unconditional love for the Israeli people and our beleaguered homeland, still desperately struggling to bring its hostages home, still trying to eliminate Hamas terrorists that not only refuse to lay down their arms but intentionally trap their own people in a combat zone," Buchdahl said. "But if I tell you these things, all of which I believe, some of you will stop listening and decide that I'm no longer your rabbi."

She continued, "I also want to tell you how my heart breaks over the civilian deaths and tragic suffering in Gaza, the shattering destruction of Palestinian homes and cities. I want to denounce settler violence in the West Bank and the rhetoric from far-right government ministers who talk about annexation of the West Bank and the expulsion of Gazans. . . . But if I tell you these things, all of which I *also* believe, some of you will stop listening and decide that I'm no longer your rabbi." The conversation about Israel was "ripping our community apart," Buchdahl observed. She described her effort to navigate the fault lines as "the most painful experience of my rabbinic life."

When Buchdahl gave the sermon, Israel and Hamas had not yet reached an agreement to stop the Gaza war. But tensions within the American Jewish community have hardly dissipated since a peace deal was signed, in

October, 2025. Only weeks after the ceasefire, the mayoral campaign of Zohran Mamdani—who called the Hamas attack a “war crime” but also described the Israeli response as “genocidal”—prompted more than a thousand rabbis to sign an open letter condemning the “political normalization” of anti-Zionism, a development that they linked to Mamdani’s refusal to condemn phrases such as “globalize the intifada.” (Mamdani has discouraged use of the phrase but has also said that, for Palestinians, it can represent an appeal for equality, not a call to violence.) The sentiment voiced by the rabbis did not stop several prominent Jewish politicians in New York, including Representative Jerry Nadler, whose district spans much of Manhattan, and Brad Lander, then New York City’s comptroller, from endorsing Mamdani. It also failed to dissuade roughly a third of Jewish New Yorkers from voting for him, according to an exit poll. And in late February, just as attention began to shift away from Gaza, Israel and the United States launched a joint attack on Iran—a potentially epochal war that may end up dividing Jewish Americans no less than the Gaza war did, particularly if the conflict drags on and casualties mount.

Liba Beyer, a Beth El member who considers herself anti-Zionist, and her mother, Rena. Liba helped create a WhatsApp group that allowed participants to engage in critical dialogue about Israel.

To be sure, many Jews in America hold ambivalent views, feeling both a connection to Israel and a contempt for the Netanyahu government. (In the Washington *Post* poll, fifty-six per cent of respondents said that they felt “very” or “somewhat” emotionally attached to Israel, but fewer than a third approved of Netanyahu’s performance.) Arguments about Israel in the American Jewish community are also nothing new. In “Jew vs. Jew,” a book published in 2000, the journalist Samuel G. Freedman documented how Israel had gone from being a unifying subject among American Jews to a source of strife. The cause of the shift, he argued, was the Oslo peace process of the mid-nineties. Jews who were unaffiliated or who attended Reform synagogues largely favored the process, which created areas of limited Palestinian self-governance, whereas a majority of Orthodox Jews, who lean conservative, opposed it. But the debate that Freedman described was a clash between two strands of Zionism, pitting doves who accepted territorial compromise against hawks who believed that Israel’s security depended on the borders it had acquired during the Six-Day War. The new division runs deeper, raising fundamental questions about what it means to be a Jew. The debates have grown especially vexed at synagogues and other Jewish institutions that subscribe to liberal Zionism, which has long sought to combine devotion to progressive political values with fealty to Israel, allegiances that recent events have made difficult—some would say impossible—to maintain.

Immediately after the Hamas attack, the mood at Beth El was sombre, but there were few signs of discord. At morning minyan—the weekday service—worshippers began concluding the proceedings with a prayer for Israel. On Shabbat, the Acheinu, a prayer for liberating those held in captivity, was recited from the bimah, an elevated platform where sermons are often delivered. For several weeks, the name and the age of each hostage was read aloud.

In the weeks that followed, a detailed account of a different captive’s story was read every Shabbat, attesting to a lingering collective grief. The pain was particularly acute for worshippers who knew people who had been murdered or kidnapped by Hamas fighters. (Multiple Beth El members had loved ones among the hostages.) But some congregants’ anguish over October 7th was compounded by dread about Israel’s brutal, indiscriminate

response. One such member was Liba Beyer. On October 9th, she attended a listening circle during which congregants consoled one another and cried. Six weeks later, she and two friends invited several dozen Jewish acquaintances to a meeting at Beyer's home. The meeting was private, and no cameras were allowed, so attendees could speak freely. After bagels and coffee were served, the participants began sharing feelings that many had been afraid to articulate—including discomfort with narratives that cast Israel solely as a victim, and shame about the escalating civilian death toll in Gaza.

"I've done a lot of growing. When you broke up with me, I was a guy with clean and dirty piles of clothes. Now I'm a guy with clean and dirty baskets of laundry."
Cartoon by Adam Sacks

The gatherings continued, and the group acquired a name, Tzedek *soma*. ("Tzedek" is Hebrew for "justice," and "*soma*" is local shorthand for South Orange-Maplewood.) Only a handful of people at the initial meeting attended Beth El. But more members started showing up, and the Beth El contingent created a WhatsApp group that allowed congregants to engage in critical dialogue about Israel and to post messages about events of shared interest, such as local vigils calling for a ceasefire in Gaza. By the time I visited Beyer at her home, last fall, the group had fifty members. Beyer, who has a warm smile and bright-pink glasses, did not hide her satisfaction. "I've built so many amazing relationships, and we're having these meaningful conversations inherent to our identities," she said, after leading me through her kitchen to her back porch, where we sat beneath a sukkah decorated with portraits of Hannah Arendt and other prominent Jewish

women. (A sukkah is a hut, erected for the weeklong festival of Sukkot, that evokes the fragile structures the Israelites inhabited while wandering the desert.) Beyer also did not conceal her frustration that, within Beth El, virtually all criticism of Israel had been relegated to an unofficial text chain.

She had joined Beth El in 2013, drawn to the synagogue because of its demonstrated commitment to progressive values, an ethos reflected in the gay-pride and trans-pride flags displayed in the foyer. In the intervening years, Beyer co-led a committee to help settle Syrian, Iraqi, and Afghan refugees. She had also undergone a shift in her own Jewish identity. Originally from Dayton, Ohio, she'd grown up in a "super Zionist" household, she told me, and attended an Orthodox school. In college, she volunteered at the Hillel chapter. But, on a trip to Israel during this period, she joined a group of female peace activists who stood at checkpoints in the West Bank to document human-rights abuses. Beyer eventually became a director at Human Rights Watch, which, in 2021, published a report accusing Israel of committing the crime of apartheid in the West Bank. At the time, she still identified as a Zionist; she found the report's conclusion deeply upsetting but fair. During the Gaza war, as images of schools and hospitals in ruins filled newspapers, she felt that a genocide was occurring, and her attachment to Zionism loosened, then gave way. "I would definitely call myself an anti-Zionist," she told me.

Beyer was aware that saying this openly at her synagogue would not endear her to everyone. Her own husband, a right-wing Zionist who is the son of Moroccan Jews, disagreed passionately with her. "We're a mixed marriage on Israeli politics," she joked. She'd received her share of icy glares at Beth El, particularly when she came to services wearing a watermelon-print yarmulke—a symbol of solidarity with Palestinians, whose flag has red, green, and black elements. But there had also been times when a person she didn't know approached her to ask for one of the "Jews for Ceasefire" pins she carried in her prayer-shawl bag. "A lot of shuls have a candy man—I'm the button lady," she said with a laugh. These encounters had convinced Beyer that many congregants were wrestling with how to square their sympathy for Jewish Israelis with the humanitarian catastrophe in Gaza. "I really believe *most* people are struggling," she said.

Beyer, who has two teen-age children, also noted that, although she stood out ideologically even among the WhatsApp participants, many of whom retained some connection to Zionism, her views were increasingly common among younger Jews. A month or so after the October 7th attack, Beth El hosted an educational program for teen-agers on the history of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. Afterward, a student in the audience complained to his parents that, at the event, the deaths of Palestinian civilians had been characterized as collateral damage—a regrettable but unavoidable consequence of the battle against Hamas. Beyer said, “Who do the rabbis think are going to be their congregants in eight, nine, ten years?”

In June, 2024, during the summer holiday of Shavuot, which celebrates the giving of the Torah on Mt. Sinai, roughly fifty Beth El members gathered in a lounge behind the sanctuary to participate in a discussion about antisemitism. Six months earlier, the Anti-Defamation League, a group that monitors antisemitism, had issued a press release saying that more than three thousand such incidents had taken place in the U.S. in the three months after October 7th. The figure was alarming, exceeding the total in some previous *years*, though one reason the number had soared was a change in the A.D.L.’s methodology—a decision to define more anti-Zionist events, like antiwar protests led by such groups as Jewish Voice for Peace, as acts of hate.

For those who believe that “anti-Zionism is antisemitism,” as Jonathan Greenblatt, the A.D.L.’s national director, has argued, including these kinds of incidents is clearly warranted. The A.D.L. and its supporters have raised alarms about Jewish students who identify as Zionists being vilified on college campuses, and about protests against Israel’s occupation of Gaza that include chants like “From the river to the sea, Palestine will be free”—a slogan that many hear as a call for Israel’s destruction.

At the Beth El event, which was titled “Wading Into the Gray: Understanding and Disentangling Antisemitism and Anti-Zionism,” a different perspective was presented. After the room filled, the moderators, both of whom belonged to the WhatsApp group, passed out copies of a document called “The Jerusalem Declaration on Antisemitism.” Published in 2021 by a team of scholars in such fields as Jewish studies and Holocaust

history, it was created to help distinguish hatred of Jews from criticism of Israel. This distinction was missing both from popular discourse, the academics felt, and from an influential definition of antisemitism associated with the International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance, which lists numerous examples of antisemitism related to criticism of Israel. (Among them are “denying the Jewish people their right to self-determination, e.g., by claiming that the existence of a State of Israel is a racist endeavor” and “applying double standards” to Israel that were not expected of other states.) In recent years, many countries have adopted the I.H.R.A. definition, including the U.S. An executive order signed by President Donald Trump mandated that federal agencies consult the I.H.R.A. definition when investigating complaints about discrimination toward Jews; at many colleges, this has emboldened efforts to punish pro-Palestinian speech.

The Jerusalem Declaration attempts to be more nuanced. Applying classical anti-Jewish stereotypes to Israel—such as suggesting that its leaders control the banking system with a hidden hand—is clearly antisemitic, it says, but other criticisms, including “opposing Zionism as a form of nationalism” and holding Israel to moral standards not demanded of other countries, might not be. “Hostility to Israel could be an expression of antisemitic animus, or it could be a reaction to a human-rights violation, or it could be the emotion that a Palestinian person feels on account of their experience,” its authors observe.

At the Beth El event, the moderators asked the attendees to signal whether they considered certain expressions to be antisemitic. Among them was “From the river to the sea,” which, according to the Jerusalem Declaration, can be used to express support for a binational state where Jews *and* Palestinians are accorded equal rights. The meeting broke into discussion groups—and soon erupted in anger. An older man stood up and told the moderators that they should be ashamed for having planned such an event on a Jewish holiday. A woman had walked out, informing the moderators that she found the discussion offensive. “It was very tense,” Avi Smolen, one of the moderators, acknowledged. In his view, the awkwardness underscored the value of having such a session; several people “came out of the woodwork” to thank him afterward, he said. David Mallach, a Beth El

member who participated in the event, was more critical. Sharing the Jerusalem Declaration but not the I.H.R.A. definition “created a stilted conversation,” he told me. But Mallach did not disagree that the event had usefully exposed a rift in the community. “It made it very clear how deep the divisions within the synagogue were,” he said.

Cartoon by Carolita Johnson

Mallach has been a Beth El member for thirty-seven years. Before retiring, he worked at United Israel Appeal, a subsidiary of the Jewish Federations of North America, which forges ties among synagogues and other Jewish groups. Over coffee one day in Maplewood, he recounted a split within the congregation sixteen years ago that had been sparked by a personality clash between the senior rabbi at the time, a woman, and the cantor, an older man. After the synagogue’s board voted to dismiss the cantor, scores of families who were loyal to him left. Mallach referred to this event as “the great schism.” Since the exodus, Beth El’s membership had recovered and indeed grown, he said, but now another schism had formed.

At one point, Mallach pulled out a pen and made two drawings on a napkin. The first was a gentle bell curve; the second was a jagged line, with two sharp peaks—one on the left, the other on the right. “If we posit that there was a spectrum of opinion on Israel like this,” he said, pointing to the first line, “post-October 7th, we have a fissure like this”—he tapped his finger on the second. As congregants were pulled in opposite directions, he said, the middle ground shrank. Although the Beth El community was overwhelmingly Democratic, he added, more congregants he knew had shifted to the right than to the left. (Over all, American Jews represent a solidly liberal voting bloc, with seventy per cent identifying as Democrats.)

Among those whose commitment to Israel had intensified after October 7th, numerous sources told me, was Olitzky, Beth El's senior rabbi. A few weeks after having coffee with Mallach, I met Olitzky in his office, a small room appointed with prayer books, family photographs, and, on the top shelf of a bookcase, a shrine to the Baltimore Orioles—the star-crossed baseball team he'd rooted for since his grandfather began taking him to games. "There's nothing more Jewish than being a baseball fan and believing that this year is *the* year," he said with a smile. Nothing except getting into fierce arguments with fellow-Jews, some would say, which Olitzky—who has a round, boyish face and a conciliatory manner—portrayed as a privilege rather than a burden. "I'm blessed to be a rabbi of a community that understands the importance of wrestling, and that creates space for conversation," he said.

The notion that Beth El had split into polarized camps was false, Olitzky insisted. But he acknowledged that "heightened emotions" had been stirred. Immediately after the Hamas attack, one of the emotions that overcame him, he went on to say, was a sense of abandonment. He had long been active in an interfaith clergy association whose members worked together during times of crisis, coördinating actions after such events as the murder of George Floyd, for whom Beth El organized a symbolic shiva. After October 7th, he did not hear from any of the clergy association's members. The lack of outreach prompted him to co-write an article with two other local rabbis which struck a plaintive tone. "Clergy we have stood side-by-side with at rallies in support of LGBTQ+ rights and protections or raising our voices together to speak against racial injustice have simply disappeared," the rabbis wrote. The silence "has gutted us."

Alex Willick, a Beth El member who was told that he could not share a story at services about a school for Palestinian children that Jewish settlers had bulldozed in the West Bank.

That silence was also instructive, some prominent American Jews said. In a column in the *Times*, Bret Stephens noted that the good will many Jewish Americans had assumed would be extended to them after October 7th never materialized. Instead, some progressive allies rushed to denounce Israel's military response while either praising or refusing to condemn Hamas. Stephens called people who had been politically activated by this dynamic "October 8th Jews," a term that has since gained wide currency. Last year, in an address on the "State of World Jewry," at the 92nd Street Y, the author Dan Senor celebrated this awakening. "There was a crack, an opening, in Jewish consciousness on October 8th," he said. "People started wearing Jewish-star necklaces for the first time, they went to rallies, they donated hundreds of millions to emergency campaigns and sent supplies to I.D.F. units, and, yes, by the hundreds of thousands, they listened to podcasts about Judaism and Israel." (Senor is the host of "Call Me Back," a podcast whose popularity surged after October 7th.)

Senor and Stephens are neoconservatives who hardly needed to be convinced that the members of progressive movements were not friends of

the Jewish people. But the shift in consciousness they described was not confined to Jews on the right. It was arguably even more pronounced among Jews who thought of themselves as liberals—people such as Olitzky, who, in 2017, was among a group of rabbis arrested at the Trump International Hotel for protesting Trump's executive order barring travel from seven Muslim-majority countries. The value of diversity, and of peace, had been instilled in him from an early age, he told me. In 1995, when he was in sixth grade, his parents took him to Madison Square Garden to attend a memorial for Yitzhak Rabin, the Israeli Prime Minister who'd been assassinated by a right-wing extremist after signing the Oslo Accords. Olitzky's father, Kerry, was himself a rabbi and the founder of Big Tent Judaism, a movement that sought to open the doors of temples to people who had previously been excluded, like queer Jews and interfaith couples. (A "Big Tent Judaism" sticker can be found on Beth El's front doors.)

At our meeting, Olitzky said that he still prayed for peace every day. He emphasized that his love was for the people and the land of Israel, not for its current government, and least of all for extremists such as Itamar Ben-Gvir, the national-security minister, who has repeatedly praised violent Jewish settlers as heroes. Olitzky referred to Ben-Gvir as a *booshah*, a "disgrace." But he also made it clear that none of the controversial things Israeli leaders had done in recent years—from allowing settlers to terrorize and humiliate Palestinians in the West Bank to blocking food and water from entering Gaza—had changed the fact that Beth El was a Zionist congregation committed to supporting Israel.

This was evident in the themes of his sermons. In one delivered a year after October 7th, he described breaking down when he learned of the death of Hersh Goldberg-Polin, an Israeli American hostage whose body had been found in a tunnel in Rafah. The tears he'd shed for Goldberg-Polin symbolized "the pain of peoplehood," he told the congregation, an ethos that bound Jews together and justified prioritizing their suffering over that of others. The previous day, Olitzky had similarly endorsed focussing exclusively on the plight of the hostages in response to a letter from Liba Beyer. He rejected her request to pass out buttons inscribed with the words "*B'Tselem Elohim:* ALL Life Is Holy" during the High Holidays, for congregants whose grief about the Gaza war extended equally to Israelis

and Palestinians. Some time later, Olitzky also rejected Beyer's request that Beth El host a reading group centered on the book "Being Jewish After the Destruction of Gaza," by the journalist Peter Beinart, who has argued for Israel becoming a binational state. She told Olitzky that eighteen members had wanted to attend. In an e-mail, Olitzky wrote to Beyer, "Sponsoring a conversation that offers the conclusion that Israel shouldn't be a Jewish state isn't a program that makes sense for us as a synagogue to host."

Last fall, at the start of Yom Kippur services, Olitzky spoke about the meaning of the "We Stand with Israel" sign he'd put up outside the synagogue. This was about two weeks after Felder had mounted his demonstration and after many other Beth El members had expressed discomfort with the sign, in e-mails and in private conversations, with some suggesting alternatives such as "One People, One Heart" and "We Stand with the Israeli People." In his sermon, Olitzky began by recalling the mood on October 7th. He had walked home with his daughter after services and explained to her what had happened. In response, she asked if they could hang an Israeli flag outside their home. A flag still waved there, he told the congregation. Olitzky acknowledged that the "We Stand with Israel" sign lacked nuance. But it served as an invitation for conversation, he said, and affirmed an unwavering bond. "Saying 'I Stand with Israel' means 'I believe in Israel, what Israel is, and what Israel can be—the Israel I dream of,' " he proclaimed.

Many worshippers loved the sermon, including Keren Siegel. She and her husband had joined Beth El in 2021, after the birth of their twins, drawn by the fact that it was a Conservative shul (they both strictly observe the Sabbath) with a growing community of young families. Siegel, whose father is Israeli and who has many relatives in Israel, assumed that the worshippers there supported Zionism. In the days after the October 7th attack, which she spent frantically texting cousins to make sure that they were safe, she turned to Beth El for succor. The realization that many members did not have the same connection to Israel, and even sympathized with its critics, startled her. Last July, the son of one of her cousins died while on a military operation in Gaza, and she later memorialized the death by placing a sticker bearing the relative's name on the "We Stand with Israel" sign. When she learned the news about her relative, she wondered

whether some people at Beth El might think that his death was justified—she had heard about protests where pro-Palestinian demonstrators had shouted, “Death, death to the I.D.F.!” Olitzky’s Yom Kippur sermon was a welcome affirmation of the synagogue’s core values, Siegel felt. “We are a Zionist community and synagogue,” she told me. “And, just like we support economic justice and gender and racial rights, one of our values is that we believe in the right for Israel to exist as a Jewish state.”

“Your guess is as good as mine.”
Cartoon by Jon Adams

Felder’s reaction to the sermon was, of course, very different. Since standing outside Beth El with his banner, he had come to find that his views were more widely shared among congregants than he’d understood. On his way to the Yom Kippur service, he was optimistic that their voices were being heard. Olitzky’s sermon left him crestfallen. So much for Big Tent Judaism, Felder thought while driving home. So much, too, for applying Beth El’s progressive values to Israel—a disjuncture that had struck him a month or so earlier, when he’d learned that the rabbis at Beth El were planning to lead a service outside an *ice* detention facility. When he saw the e-mail about the *ice* service, he told me, “that was the moment I printed out my sign. Because I am horrified by what’s going on with *ice* and immigration, but there was no mention of the biggest thing that was touching the Jewish community at the time. For me, we had lost our moral authority to advocate for social justice at that *ice* facility by ignoring the mass starvation of a civilian population. It made the *ice* protest hollow.”

Nothing Olitzky could have said about the Gaza war would likely have pleased all the members of Beth El. This is why, as the conflict entered its second year, rabbis at many American synagogues strained to avoid the subject.

Some rabbis who were privately appalled by Israel's actions in Gaza stayed quiet for fear of being branded traitors. Sharon Brous, the senior rabbi at IKAR, a synagogue in Los Angeles, told me that pro-Israel advocates often resort to a discourse that she called Defend, Deflect, and Denounce. "First, defend Israel at all costs, even when Israel is blatantly wrong," she said. "Then deflect—'Why aren't you talking about Sudan?' And then denounce any person who refuses to play by the rules." Back in 2012, amid an exchange of rockets between Israel and Hamas, Brous experienced this directly, when the Jerusalem rabbi Daniel Gordis accused her of "betrayal" in a column in the *Times of Israel*, citing a message that she'd sent to her community in which she expressed compassion for Israelis and Palestinians in "absolute balance." The accusation stung, she told me, both because Gordis had been a mentor and because it prompted personal attacks on her, including rape and death threats. Not long after October 7th, on a Zoom call with more than a hundred influential figures in Hollywood, Brous emphasized her profound sympathy for Israelis; two board members at her synagogue had relatives in Israel who'd been killed or kidnapped by Hamas. But she also voiced concern for civilians being forced to leave northern Gaza. Brous recalls that the A.D.L.'s Greenblatt, who had joined the meeting and described anti-Zionism as a form of genocide, abruptly cut her off. "Please stop!" he snapped. "Don't blame the victim. . . . We can humanize them when they stop dehumanizing us." Then he hung up.

Rabbi Paul Golomb and his wife, Deborah Golomb, at their residence on the Upper West Side. Deborah said, "What's going on in Israel, Gaza, and the West Bank breaks my heart."

The Jewish establishment has long demanded uncritical support for Israel. "Israeli democracy should decide, American Jews should support" was reportedly the motto of Abraham Foxman, Greenblatt's predecessor at the A.D.L. This stance, however, has not stopped some of the establishment's members from criticizing Israel—from the right. The journalist Joshua Leifer, in his recent book "Tablets Shattered," points out that many prominent American rabbis publicly assailed Yitzhak Rabin for signing the Oslo Accords. One called Rabin's government a *Judenrat*, the Nazi term for Jewish councils appointed to oversee ghettos.

Although the Jewish establishment's effort to silence criticism has sometimes proved effective with rabbis, it has not prevented Jews who care about Palestinian rights from joining groups such as Jewish Voice for Peace. Indeed, attempts to muffle criticism have backfired, some observers believe. Nomi Colton-Max, a Beth El member and a former president of the synagogue, told me, "If we could have had open conversations about Israel, the same way that we've had open conversations about everything else, the

situation might not have reached this point." Colton-Max co-chairs New Jewish Narrative, an organization that supports justice and self-determination for Israelis and Palestinians, and is a vice-president of the American Zionist Movement. Congregations throughout North America, she feels, have long embraced a notion of "inclusion" that, when it comes to Israel, stretches from just left of center to the extreme right. "We allowed the tent to go further to the right but never to the left," she said. *Shalom Bayit*—a Hebrew phrase meaning "peace within the home"—"has always been about including only those on one side."

In December, 2024, a Beth El member named Alex Willick received an invitation to speak in the synagogue's main sanctuary on Shabbat about a recent visit to Israel. The rabbis had asked several members who'd made trips there to talk about their experiences while standing on the bimah, before the Acheinu prayer was read. Their presentations had all covered similar ground, relaying the resilience of the Israelis they'd met. Willick, who works at the New Israel Fund, a social-justice and pro-democracy nonprofit, was asked to talk about an "interaction" he'd had in Israel, "something that would inspire the community." He decided to talk about his encounter with Yinon Levi, a Jewish settler who, among other things, is known to have rammed a bulldozer into an elementary school in Zanuta, a Palestinian village in the West Bank's South Hebron Hills. (In 2024, the Biden Administration imposed financial sanctions on Levi and three other Jewish settlers for allegedly inciting violence against Palestinians, but the Trump Administration removed the sanctions last year.) During his visit, Willick had gone to the site of the attack and surveyed the ruins, which were strewn with children's drawings and broken crayons. While Willick was there, some settlers drove by in a white pickup and smiled—including Levi.

Before Willick spoke, Olitzky and Marder asked to see his remarks, so that they could offer feedback. He agreed, and found their suggestions helpful. Afterward, he texted the WhatsApp chain, encouraging people to come to his talk. But, the week before he was scheduled to speak, he received an e-mail informing him that the invitation had been rescinded, and suggesting other venues at Beth El where he could tell his story. Olitzky said that this decision was made because there needed to be "conversation and dialogue"

about such a topic, and because the bimah was a special place where the community came together to feel “a sense of hope.” Willick was not convinced by this explanation, noting that many graphic and upsetting stories had been shared from the bimah in the past two and a half years—stories about violence perpetrated by Hamas. Although the theme of Willick’s intended talk was dark, it opened with a description of his deep connection to Israel. Later in the talk, he would address those who might wonder why he was speaking about a Palestinian school in a space reserved for Jewish stories. His experience *was* a Jewish story, he explained: “Everyone involved, aside from the victims, are Jewish—the perpetrators, the enablers, and the observers.”

Willick told me all this while we walked through a New Jersey nature reserve where he likes to go running. A father of two young children, he described the day he visited the bulldozed school as “the darkest moment in my history of Zionism.” Now, he said, he was no longer sure that he considered himself a Zionist. “If I can’t dissociate *that* action from that word within my own community, I don’t even know how I feel about the word at all anymore,” he said.

As disappointed as Willick was, he had no intention of leaving Beth El. Neither did the other WhatsApp-group members I met. “I don’t want to burn it down—I’m only here to make it better,” Liba Beyer said, adding that her son would soon be having his bar mitzvah at the synagogue, which was also where her father’s memorial took place and where her daughter had celebrated her bat mitzvah, in 2024. Beyer hoped that, just as congregations had learned to welcome and accommodate L.G.B.T.Q.+ and interfaith families, so, too, they would evolve to make space for people with diverse views on Israel.

Not everyone believes that such accommodation should be made. In November, Nolan Lebovitz, the senior rabbi at Valley Beth Shalom, a synagogue in Encino, California, wrote an article for *Tablet* in which he stated that Jews who have forsaken Zionism “have removed themselves from our shared sense of peoplehood.” His argument echoed the thesis of a 2021 essay by Natan Sharansky and Gil Troy, also published in *Tablet*, that labelled defectors from Zionism as “un-Jews.” Since October 7th, Lebovitz

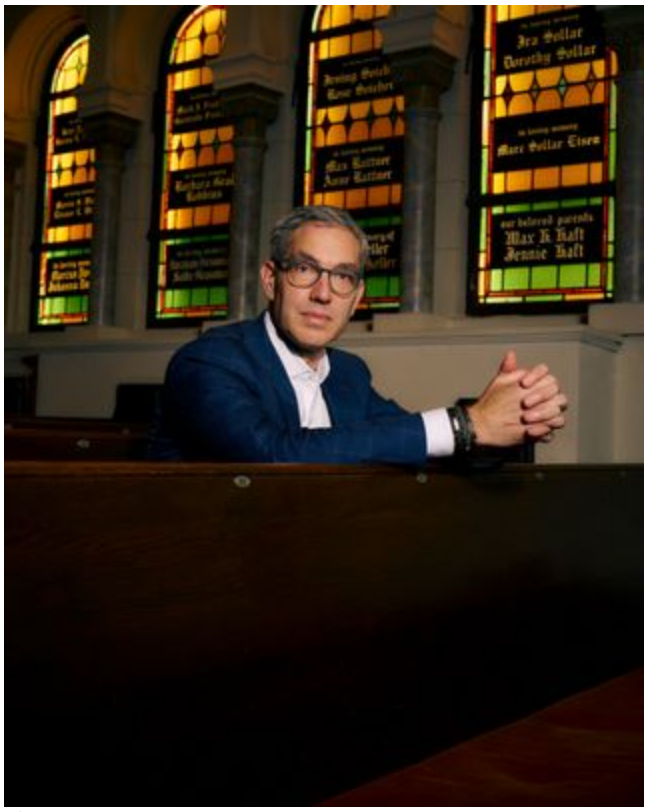
wrote, the differences between Reform, Conservative, and Orthodox denominations paled next to the only division that now mattered: “Zionist or anti-Zionist.” A number of congregants who had rejected his shul’s “strong and unequivocal commitment to Israel” had quit, and Lebovitz had welcomed their departures.

Many Jews have stopped attending temples that refused to acknowledge their concerns about Israel. In January, I had tea in New York with a woman I’ll call Rivka. (She did not want her real name used.) A musician in her thirties who works at a social-justice nonprofit, she had joined a synagogue on the Upper West Side upon moving to New York several years ago. After October 7th, the synagogue sent out an e-mail collecting donations for the I.D.F., which she viewed as an “occupation army.” Then she overheard a member of the congregation say, “There are no innocent people in Gaza.” She left the temple and started searching for a place of worship that was more aligned with her values. By the time we met, she had found one—an anti-Zionist minyan in Harlem that she’d started herself. On Friday nights, the group met in a member’s apartment for Shabbat services and a potluck dinner. In the past year, many similar minyans have formed in such places as Brooklyn and Boston. Rivka no longer felt a connection to Israel, though her spiritual journey was hardly that of an “un-Jew.” Before launching her minyan, she’d spent months studying Jewish liturgy so that she could lead services. She’d also improved her Hebrew. “My faith has definitely gotten more intense,” she said, propelled by a desire to prove that Judaism “belongs to all of us—Zionism doesn’t have a monopoly.”

After meeting Rivka, I visited B’nai Jeshurun, a nondenominational synagogue on the Upper West Side. Although it was a blustery evening in the middle of the week, the synagogue was packed with people who had come to attend a panel discussion, “The Jewish Tent at a Crossroads,” about the rupture over Israel and Zionism. Before the event began, I chatted with a man sitting behind me, a retired rabbi named Paul Golomb, who had once served as the vice-president for programming at the American Zionist Movement. He was still holding out hope for “a Zionism that is liberal and just,” he said. His wife, Deborah, who was seated next to him, appeared to be less hopeful. “What’s going on in Israel, Gaza, and the West Bank breaks my heart,” she said.

Rabbi Irwin Kula, the panel's moderator, asked the participants to describe their biggest fear or nightmare. One of the panelists was Peter Beinart, the writer whose book had been deemed unfit for study at Beth El. Beinart, who continues to attend an Orthodox synagogue, said that, in addition to worrying that God will judge his community for doing too little to stop the carnage in Gaza, he feared that he would soon be banished from this community. "Shabbat is not Shabbat if you spend it alone, and I sometimes feel like that's my future," he said. Another panelist, Elliot Cosgrove, the senior rabbi at Park Avenue Synagogue, on the Upper East Side, said his main worry was that, at a time when the Jewish people did not lack for external enemies, "we are making internal enemies." He called for summoning a "capaciousness of spirit." It was a heartfelt message but a somewhat surprising one from a rabbi who had recently inflamed tensions among Jews. A few months earlier, Cosgrove had delivered a sermon about Mamdani, insisting that the candidate posed "a danger to the security of the New York Jewish community" because of his opposition to Zionism.

Cosgrove's sermon inspired the rabbinical letter denouncing Mamdani. It urged Americans to "stand up for candidates who reject antisemitic and anti-Zionist rhetoric, and who affirm Israel's right to exist." Although the letter drew more than a thousand signatures, it was controversial. Many rabbis refused to sign it because they believed that clerical leaders have no business intervening in an election. Others feared that singling out Mamdani could stoke Islamophobia. Still others worried that the letter, which was titled "A Rabbinic Call to Action: Defending the Jewish Future," would actually sabotage the "Jewish future" by alienating young Jews who were excited about Mamdani. Rabbi Hara Person, the chief executive of the Central Conference of American Rabbis, the professional organization for Reform rabbis, said, "If we tell this entire swath of young people that their ideas and concerns are not welcome, we're going to lose them." Her fear was borne out on Election Day: although Andrew Cuomo, who attacked Mamdani repeatedly over his views on Israel, carried Hasidic neighborhoods, such as Borough Park, Mamdani won the Jewish vote in progressive strongholds such as Park Slope.



Rabbi Elliot Cosgrove, of Park Avenue Synagogue. Cosgrove delivered a sermon calling Zohran Mamdani "a danger to the security of the New York Jewish community" because of Mamdani's opposition to Zionism.

Cosgrove, in his sermon on Mamdani, asserted that Zionism and Israel were "inseparable strands" of his Jewish identity. The day after Mamdani was elected, I went to Park Avenue Synagogue to speak with Cosgrove. He has pale eyes and a contemplative bearing, and appeared to be in a reflective mood. When I asked whether he thought that the American Jewish community today shared his feelings about Zionism and Israel, he paused for nearly thirty seconds. "I'm not sure," he said, finally. Later, he handed me "For Such a Time as This," a book he wrote about the Jewish "awakening" after October 7th. Mamdani's victory seemed to have surprised and unsettled him. "As certain as I am that these last two years have prompted many Jews to draw closer to Judaism and to Israel, so, too, there are many Jews for whom these last two years have prompted the opposite," he said.

As Mamdani's election showed, the Jewish community is as divided about antisemitism and concerns over Jewish safety as it is about Zionism and Israel—issues that are now inextricably related. "It's become impossible to

have a conversation about antisemitism without Israel-Palestine arising," Dov Waxman, a political scientist and a professor of Israel studies at U.C.L.A., noted. In 2016, Waxman published "Trouble in the Tribe," which centers on the growing debate about Israel in the American Jewish community. He is now working on a study of the equally fractious debate about antisemitism. Two decades ago, Israel's conduct primarily affected the lives of Jews and Palestinians in the Middle East. Today, Waxman told me, what happens in the region profoundly shapes the security and perceptions of Jews in the diaspora. On one side were the "October 8th Jews" who were preoccupied by the growing influence of the anti-Zionist left at a time when violent attacks on Jews were becoming increasingly common: last spring, in Washington, D.C., two Israeli Embassy staffers were killed outside the Capital Jewish Museum; in Michigan, a man recently rammed a truck filled with explosives into a synagogue. On the other side were Jews who tended to be far more concerned about the resurgence of antisemitism on the right, from the likes of Tucker Carlson and Nick Fuentes, and believed that Israel's aggressive actions were partially responsible for *making* Jews unsafe. As some news outlets reported, the suspect in the Michigan attack, a Lebanese American named Ayman Mohamad Ghazali, had recently attended a memorial for four members of his family who were killed by an Israeli air strike in eastern Lebanon. (Israel has claimed that Ghazali's brother was a member of Hezbollah, a charge that Hezbollah has denied.) The argument about Mamdani was "a microcosm of the larger debate," Waxman said. "Should we be concerned about anti-Zionist speech and phrases like 'globalize the intifada,' or should we view Mamdani as an ally because what's most needed is an alliance in the face of rising Christian nationalism and a racist far right?"

Within the Beth El congregation, many members on the WhatsApp text chain were initially heartened that neither Olitzky nor Marder had signed the open letter criticizing Mamdani. But, a week before Election Day, Olitzky did sign it. Soon afterward, Marder followed suit. To the chat-group members, her signature came as a particular disappointment, because she was seen as more sympathetic to their concerns. Last fall, in a Rosh Hashanah sermon, Marder declared that her heart ached "for the innocents who are suffering in Gaza" and "for the thousands of Palestinians who have

died in this war, and the many who are starving and suffering." She also acknowledged "the trouble in our tent." Remaining *Am Echad*—one people—"depends on our ability to tolerate diverse views," she said.

The disappointment in Marder was short-lived. A few days after she endorsed the open letter, she took her name off it. When I asked Olitzky if I could talk with Marder, he demurred, telling me it was important that the synagogue leadership speak in "one voice." (Marder declined to be interviewed, but in an e-mail she explained that she "didn't feel comfortable as a spiritual leader having my name attached to a petition that endorsed or condemned a candidate.") Olitzky expressed no regrets about signing the open letter, affirming his commitment to "call out antisemitism," which he did not distinguish from anti-Zionism. After our meeting, he sent me a link to a sermon he gave in which he described the litany of hate crimes targeting Jews in places such as Staten Island, where a man wearing a yarmulke was assaulted with a metal bat. Such incidents had caused him to wonder whether he should cover his head with a baseball cap on train rides at night, or even on walks through his own neighborhood.

At Beth El in January, Marder led a discussion of anti-Zionism in politics. It was far less contentious than the one that had taken place two years earlier, during Shavuot. As the furor over the October 7th attack and the Gaza war subsides, such gatherings have become easier to organize, several Beth El members told me. "The temperature has been turned down—we're in a different moment," a board member said. "The rabbis have facilitated some sessions where people have been able to have productively uncomfortable conversations." Olitzky and Marder recently returned from a listening tour of Israel and the West Bank, organized by the nonpartisan group Encounter. The trip raised hopes among some members on the WhatsApp chain that expressions of empathy toward Palestinians will become more common at Beth El, both from the bimah and in synagogue-wide communications. An e-mail that the rabbis sent to members after the outbreak of the Iran war began, "We prayed and continue to pray for the safety of our friends and family in Israel." But it went on to extend "prayers for peace and freedom, peace for the entire region, for Israel, for Palestinians, for Iran, and for all of Israel's neighbors."

Although a space for dialogue has opened, the distrust has hardly gone away. A reminder of this came in late January, after Israel announced that it had recovered the remains of Ran Gvili, the last remaining hostage in Gaza. A day later, Olitzky sent out a congregation-wide e-mail sharing the news, which, after eight hundred and forty-three days “full of anguish, uncertainty and heartache,” marked “the end of this period of mourning.”

Some Beth El members shared Olitzky’s sense of closure and relief. But others were in a different frame of mind. One member of the WhatsApp group wrote a pointed response to Olitzky. When Beth El’s leaders “speak as though the community is unified around a single moral framing (especially after years in which many felt unseen, unheard, or unsupported),” the member argued, “it risks becoming a form of gaslighting. It suggests consensus where there is none.” Molly Rodau, another Beth El member, wrote a poignant note to Olitzky. “How can we declare our mourning ‘concluded’ when the killing continues?” she asked. “What has brought us to a place where we can mark the end of one group’s suffering while another’s continues—as if our lives and theirs exist on separate moral planes?”

Olitzky’s e-mail did contain some seemingly welcome news for these Beth El members. Now that the hostages were home, he announced, the “We Stand with Israel” sign would be removed. A couple of days later, on a frigid morning, dozens of congregants gathered in the synagogue’s foyer, bundled in hats and scarves. They followed Olitzky outside, along a concrete path slick with ice. After several prayers were recited, Olitzky trudged through snow and took the sign down.

Beyer, who attended the ceremony, was struck by the balanced tone of the proceedings—which she credited both to the sombre occasion and to the letters that her WhatsApp peers had written. She was especially moved when Marder came forward to read “Prayer of the Mothers,” a poem co-written by Rabbi Tamar Elad-Appelbaum, who is Israeli, and Sheikha Ibtisam Mahameed, who is Palestinian. “May it be your will to hear the prayer of mothers,” it began. “For you did not create us to kill each other / Nor to live in fear, anger or hatred in your world.”

Felder, who was also there, had more mixed feelings. As he watched Olitzky pull down the sign, he felt relief. But he also felt frustrated about an upcoming change at Beth El. The synagogue's leaders had decided that a new emblem would replace the sign outside: an Israeli flag. ♦

An earlier version of this article mischaracterized Orthodox Jewish support for Zionism prior to the Yom Kippur War.

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Shouts & Murmurs

- **If I Made Novelty T-Shirts**
  By Jesse Eisenberg | Ever wondered why “I’m with Stupid”? Let me explain.

Shouts & Murmurs

If I Made Novelty T-Shirts

***By** Jesse Eisenberg*
March 30, 2026

Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

I Climbed Mt. Whitney and All I Got Was This Stupid T-Shirt
But I also had an amazing trip up the mountain. I was with my sister. We've been estranged for a while. And we were connecting as much as we were climbing. It's funny—putting yourself in a difficult physical situation (*continues on back of shirt*) can have a positive effect on your emotional well-being. I sometimes wonder if depression and convenience are more insidiously linked than we like to think.

I'm With Stupid
But I'm using the experience to try to learn from Stupid. Emerson said, "Every man I meet is my master in some point, and in that I learn of him." Although, to be frank, it's hard to think of Stupid as my master because he insists on repeating the same paranoid conspiracy theories. And I've tried (*continues on back of shirt*) to tell him that Finland is a real country, but Stupid keeps saying, "Show me a map! Show me a map!" And then, when I show Stupid the map with Finland on it, he just says, "But who made that

map?," and kind of raises his eyebrows like he's caught me in a trap. And so I tell him, "Rand McNally," and then Stupid's all, like, "Does anyone actually know this 'Rand McNally' guy?," and I want to answer him, but by this point it feels moot.

Don't Talk to Me Until I've Had My Coffee
And, even then, maybe don't talk to me. We're just sitting across from each other on the G train—why do we need to talk? And before you accuse me of perpetuating an individualist culture where we're all "buried in our phones" (*continues on back of shirt*) and can't muster any kind of real human connection, you should know that I have actually read Jonathan Haidt and impose strict phone curfews in my house. I just don't want to talk to you until I've had coffee because I know I wouldn't be my best self, and excuse me if I want to make a good impression.

New York Fuckin' City
is what my father says whenever we talk about his retirement. He spent the past twenty years living like a monk in Hoboken and saving his cash so that he can finally retire to a modest studio apartment in the city. But, as he was responsibly planning his future, New York City turned into what he calls "a cesspool of bankers and trust-fund kids and Russian oligarchs buying ghost (*continues on back of shirt*) apartments while the rest of us are pushed to the outer boroughs, schlepping in every day to make their lattes and pick up their snotty kids, who will one day grow up to be the bosses of our kids as New York gets dragged to the final circle of Hell."

Eat Sleep Spin Repeat
This is what my life has become. I am reduced to four activities, and the last one is just a demand to perform the first three again. What happened to my life? I used to be interested in (*continues on back of shirt*) culture. Julie and I used to go to St. Ann's Warehouse, in Brooklyn, and the Met. Now all I do is eat and sleep and spin. I don't even like the spinning. It hurts my calves, and the teacher always singles me out.

Rosé All Day
(*continues on back of shirt*) I have a drinking problem. ♦
Jesse Eisenberg won a 2025 BAFTA for best original screenplay for his film "A Real Pain."

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Fiction

- **“Enough for Now”**
  By Cassandra Neyenesch | She flipped through the diary, looking for her name. Was she hoping not to find herself, or did a perverse part of her want to?

Fiction

Enough for Now

By Cassandra Neyenesch

March 29, 2026

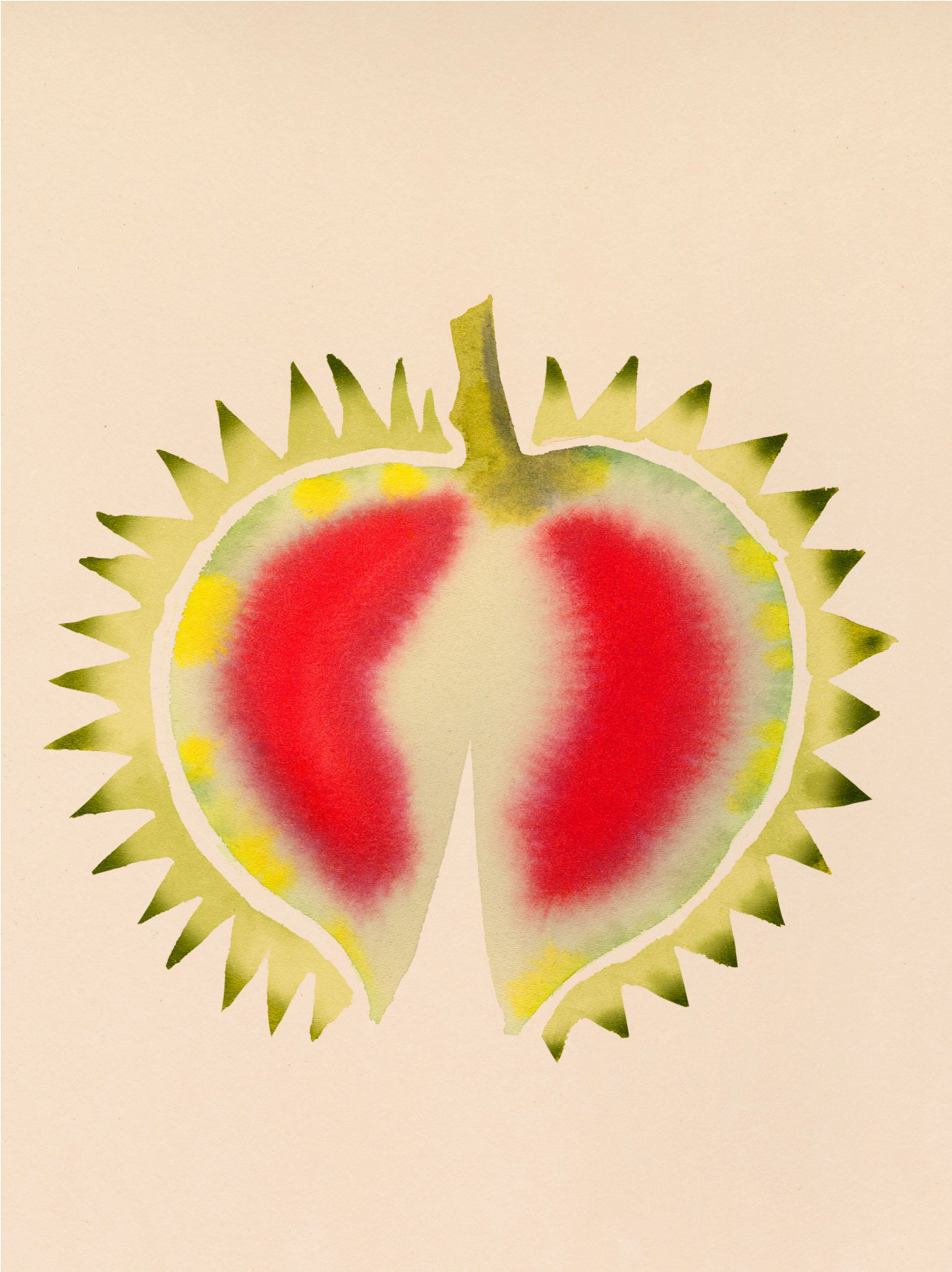


Illustration by Cecilia Carlstedt

Martha noticed the Dutch backpacker, of course. He was sitting next to her for eight hours, in the hard sleeper from Xi'an to Guilin. She could tell he was Dutch from his accent in Mandarin—like blurry German. He was engaged in a battle of courtesy with some policemen over a brand of cigarettes called Long Life.

"Long Life!" the police would say every hour or so, holding out the pack and shaking it at him.

"Long Life," the backpacker would reply with a chuckle, and wave a hand in front of his face to say, No, thank you.

Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.

Long Life cigarettes smelled like early death and bitter, frustrated dreams. At twenty-five cents a pack, they were considered a medium-status brand, still a splurge for most people in China. (The perfect cigarettes for bribing a low-level law-enforcement officer, for example.) Foreigners might have smoked them just to be cool and ironic, if they weren't so awful.

The backpacker's refusal seemed to hurt the policemen's feelings, and they would raise the stakes with each offer, nagging, scolding, and, by the fifth time, practically shouting, "Long Life! LONG LIFE!" The backpacker, not understanding that cigarettes were the main currency in an elaborate networking system, and that he was essentially rejecting their offer of friendship, looked more and more confused.

Martha watched all of this unfold from the flip-down seat by the window next to the Dutchman's lower bunk. (She had the top bunk.) She was enjoying the whole scene and, especially, the policemen's outfits. They looked like members of the Village People, with their giant aviator sunglasses and tight khaki uniforms tucked into high-heeled black boots. Between them sat a peasant with matted hair and a padded coat over his shoulders. From time to time, as the policemen were yelling "Long Life!" at the backpacker, one of them would stick a cigarette in the peasant's mouth and light it, as if to demonstrate what civilized men did.

When the train stopped for three hours outside Guiyang, the backpacker finally admitted defeat and accepted a cigarette. That seemed to break the ice.

Where were the foreigners headed? one of the policemen asked, crossing his booted legs and dragging on his cigarette. “Oh, Guilin! Wonderful city!”

The other policeman quoted a Tang Dynasty poem: *The river winds, a green silk ribbon . . .*

The first policeman, using the plural “you,” suggested that they try stuffed river snails, a famous Guilin delicacy.

The Dutch backpacker, possibly not knowing how to say that he and Martha were not together, gave her a sidelong look.

Martha clarified, “I’m also going to Guilin, but we don’t know each other.”

“You don’t know each other?” The police were astonished. What were the odds? Two foreigners in the same bunk! And they even looked alike.

Podcast: The Writer’s Voice
Listen to Cassandra Neyenesch read “Enough for Now.”

Martha and the Dutch boy glanced at each other again and blushed. Visually speaking, they were the same sort of white person, both sallow and long-nosed, with that ashy color of hair that is neither blond nor brown. He had a beardless, pretty, androgynous face that reminded Martha of a member of a New Wave band. But he wore a red bandanna around his head, like a Canadian Waldorf-school teacher.

Martha had already discounted the possibility of anything sexual happening between them, partly because of the bandanna. But who was she to judge? She was wearing an embroidered Uyghur men’s hat. Mostly she’d stopped believing in sex. Not that she didn’t want it, just that she no longer thought it could happen for her here.

The community of backpackers moving through the Chinese hostels had the values of a slutty, hippie utopia. They came from everywhere, mingling and flowing past one another like water molecules in a sea, swirling back at the uncrossable borders with Myanmar and Tibet, scattered by the slightest impulse. Certainly a person could get laid while adrift in this restless tide, but only in a “We’re all free spirits, no commitments here, hey, namaste, you look like you need a back rub” kind of way that really didn’t do it for Martha. As for Chinese men, they were either too shy or much too cocky, wanting to show off their high-school English with her.

After six months of backpacking, Martha was feeling very Taoist, very detached, just a big naked eyeball wandering around, absorbing all the astonishing things there were to see at the frayed edges of a defunct feudal empire. A person who was naturally solitary could become even more molded by solitude, to the point that she was afraid to let anyone take it away from her. She could not keep having interactions, real interactions involving sentences; she just wanted to eat a bowl of noodles and go on her way. She wasn’t interested in other foreigners, period, and she was definitely not here to speak English, which she already knew. If she felt that she was getting weird, she would attach herself to a group of backpackers at one of those cafés that catered to their longings for coffee, bread, and other exotic specialties. But foreigners were expensive; they kept playing cards and ordering smoothies and french fries and “pizza,” and she would feel her remaining money draining away as if it were her life force.

Cartoon by Roz Chast

She turned back to her book, “Gunnar’s Daughter,” a slender Norwegian novel about date rape in the Viking world. Every conversation ended in a stabbing. So far, Martha was cautiously intrigued, but it was impossible to concentrate. Long Life cigarette smoke was making her nauseated and hungry, and she had nothing to eat but some oily fried beans she couldn’t stand to look at anymore. “The East Is Red” and other patriotic songs played maddeningly in an endless loop on the scratchy sound system, and, just when she thought she would spontaneously combust, the train stopped in a town called Flower-something and idled there long enough for people on the platform to thrust Styrofoam lozenges of food through the windows at the passengers and for the passengers to thrust money back at them. In the transition that occurred—the shift in the quality of the silence between Martha and the Dutch boy as they inspected the contents of their lunch lozenges (chicken?) and rubbed their chopsticks together to remove the splinters—he asked, “What are you reading?”

With a game-show flourish, Martha indicated the legend beneath the author’s name, “Winner of the Nobel Prize for Literature.”

“Eh . . . must be pretty good then?”

Martha laughed. “Gunnar’s Daughter” was exactly the sort of harrowing, realist “good” novel that washed up on hostel bookshelves. She theorized that backpackers liked them because the miserable lives of the characters made the agony of a hard sleeper car seem relatively endurable. Being on the top bunk of three tended to make you ponder the deeper questions of existence—the patriotic songs wailing a foot from your ear, food and water and toilet so far away down a long ladder. And yet your sufferings would come to an end in a mere fifty-seven hours, or whenever the train disgorged you, while the sufferings of Gunnar’s daughter would probably end only with her death.

“I think it’s because the Chinese censors don’t allow Western novels into the country unless they’re depressing,” the Dutch boy said.

“Because they make our society look bad?” Martha said, devastated, knowing that he was probably right. Another theory deflated.

The Dutch boy’s name was Joost. As the train made the long approach to Guilin, he and Martha scooched closer and talked in lowered voices while the policemen rearranged the peasant’s jacket over his shoulders and gave him sips of tea from a jelly jar. Hours and hours of rolling green hills and rice paddies passed by the windows, the pale pools amid the shoots flashing bits of sky.

No one would talk to them about anything real, they agreed. They didn’t blame people for being cautious—they understood that it wasn’t safe. The Tiananmen Square massacre had been only five years before.

What Chinese people did like to talk about, a lot, was the price of goods and services in the U.S.A., which they called Beautiful Country. A ten-speed bicycle, for example, what did it cost in Beautiful Country? A car? A washing machine? It was a delicious shock for them to hear how expensive things were in Beautiful Country. It seemed to imply that people had the money to buy those wonderful things. They all wanted to immigrate to Beautiful Country, every single person Martha met. If she warned them about the inequality and racism in Beautiful Country, they would say, “Oh,

right, your social problems, uh-huh, we heard about those. What about a refrigerator? What does a refrigerator cost?”

Beautiful Country was definitely winning the twentieth century. That was clear to everyone at this point. “America! No. 1!” people would tell Martha, giving her a thumbs-up. Why, though? they seemed to be asking her. How had a callow upstart nation on the edge of nowhere become No. 1, the baby, the favorite child of history? What had Great China done to become so unloved by fate?

Joost said that he got it worse. Holland, mm-hmm, tulips, windmills. But have you been to Beautiful Country?

Stupid Beautiful Country.

The police were feeding anise-flavored watermelon seeds to the peasant, who cracked them expertly between his teeth and spat the shells onto the floor. Martha was transfixed by a realization: the peasant’s hands were cuffed behind his back. She hadn’t noticed before, with his coat draped over his shoulders. He was a prisoner the police were transporting, possibly a fugitive. So many impossible things happened in China every day that it hadn’t struck her as odd that the policemen were treating him like a big, scruffy baby.

Martha told Joost about a boy who had followed her from the youth hostel in Beijing, asking her the usual questions: Where you come from? How you like China? He was gaunt and brutally handsome, with a face like a cube someone had punched to make features, and had the general nerviness of a guy who had got up that morning planning to approach a Western girl. Martha, bored, had tried an experiment. When the boy had asked her how much she’d spent on her Nikes, she’d asked him if he thought there would ever be free speech in China. She wasn’t a total idiot—she’d waited until there was no one else around to overhear them as they had turned onto one of those endless Beijing streets that is just a series of compound gates. She imagined that, here, they would finally break through this barrier of silence between them and commune deeply about things that affected them as humans.

But the boy had become impatient and sullen, his hands shoved in the pockets of his jacket. “I don’t want to talk about history,” he’d said. “I’m tired of history. Nobody wants to talk about it.”

Martha had suddenly understood that she was being naïve, American, a huge asshole. She should have known this. She’d taken so much Chinese history in college she felt like she’d almost lived through the Cultural Revolution. Wars, famines, purges—why don’t we let the teen-agers kill all the professionals? That sounds like a good idea. And just when they’d started to have a bit of hope for something else, the tanks had come and mowed it all down again. If she didn’t understand that, she couldn’t understand him at all. Fuck history. The price of sneakers *was* his problem. “I WANT TO TALK ABOUT BEAUTIFUL COUNTRY!”

It was like a whole relationship that Martha didn’t want to have, in forty-five minutes. She felt terrible, but she needed to get away from him as fast as possible. She ran into the Forbidden City, where she knew he couldn’t afford the entry fee, and stared at dusty rooms behind smudged plexiglass for two hours.

And he *waited*.

As the train pulled into the precincts of Guilin, Martha and Joost gazed out the window at a series of pointy green hills poking up out of bright-orange soil.

“Would you like to split a double room at the hostel?” he said. “I have this durian. For once, I would like to eat the whole thing.”

He opened his pack and pulled out a durian the size of a dinosaur egg, covered in woody thorns. Then he pulled out a machete.

Wait, Martha thought. Is this a sex thing?

On the other hand, it made sense—wanting a private room in order to eat a durian. They were notoriously stinky fruits; you could never cut one open in a dorm situation.

Later, in their double at the hostel, Joost hacked at the durian over a copy of People's Daily. The flesh looked like a human brain and smelled like rotten hamburger meat wrapped in gym socks wrapped in butt. Martha sat on the other bed and thought about what a perverse species humans were—to insist on eating something that had tried so hard to be inedible.

That night, Joost wanted to dine at a real restaurant like rich foreigners. "Come on, it's so cheap!" he said. They shared an appetizer and two vegetable dishes, and he had a meat dish, plus beer. Joost spoke in a soft, amused tone, prefacing his sentences with, "Eh . . . yeah?," his head always cocked, in Martha's imagination, if not in reality. He was likable and easygoing—she kept thinking the word "amiable"—but there was something he was holding back. He was almost too polite.

They talked about the fugitive and the police on the train, wondering what the man had done, if he was a murderer, and feeling that the policemen in go-go boots had been very sweet with him, almost tender. It was as if the Chinese instinct for nurturing through creature comforts was stronger than whatever made the police the police.

After a few days of this—sleeping in the same room, eating all their meals together, not having sex—it felt as though they were practically married. Still, it was awkward between them, this unanswered question: Sex?

On the third night, Joost stopped being polite. Over dinner, he made fun of her for being a pescatarian, then ordered rabbit, snake, stuffed river snails—the cutest or most disgusting things on the menu—just to annoy her. She was annoyed and called him a dick. He seemed to take that as encouragement and got another round of Five Star beers.

On the way back to the hostel, Martha drunkenly confessed that she'd had a fantasy about the fugitive. The train had crashed and she and the fugitive had survived, and he had told her a super dramatic and horrible story about his life—he was a dissident on the run—and they had fallen in love. Then they'd had to steal food while evading the authorities, either escaping to Vietnam, or else coming to a tearful reckoning that they could never be together and parting ways.

“Keep your eyes on Mike—he’s said to be flirting with the concept of integrity.”
Cartoon by Mort Gerberg

She and Joost were walking along the Lijiang river watching a woman paddle a market raft. Fog wrapped the bottom of the cone-shaped hills and a wet breeze blew off the water. Martha was shivering. She’d never shared that particular dark corner of her mind with a boy before—the Harlequin Romance part.

“Here,” Joost said, unwinding his Cambodian scarf to give to her. It smelled of him, earthy in a surprisingly clean and herbal way, like chamomile tea. “So it’s true,” he said. “You really think life is a movie, you Americans?”

The playful way he said this made her laugh. “As if you don’t have fantasies.”

“Not silly ones like that.”

Back in the room, Joost initiated some tussling, some tickling, and was, as it turned out, extremely good at oral sex. Then he pretended that he was the fugitive and it was their first time. It was fun; Martha had not done sexual role-play since she was nine or ten, with other girls. Her last and only boyfriend, Tim, would have been too inhibited.

“I never liked cunnilingus before,” she said, all aglow with post-orgasmic triumph.

“Maybe that’s because you call it cunnilingus.”

“What do you call it?”

“Eh, yeah . . . we have a verb.”

He said a word she couldn’t pronounce right no matter how hard she tried. *Beffen*? The Dutch were apparently very particular about their unaspirated “B”s.

They spent the next week wandering Guilin and the outlying towns that backpackers liked, talking in a stream-of-consciousness way. Martha learned Joost’s entire history: his bipolar mother, his absent father, his battles with depression. He’d grown up in a commune, raised by three women with fairy-tale names—Agatha, Leneke, and Ineke—so the bandanna, she thought, was forgivable. Martha complained about her evil stepmother, who thought she was literally allergic to the planet and had made Martha’s father move to the Sonoran Desert to live in a geodesic dome. And Martha wasn’t even allowed to visit because of “contamination risk.”

It all emerged in this altered state; nothing had more weight than anything else. Sex bound them together as long as they were together, the swimming warmth of the double bed, skin and limbs and hair. It’s enough for now, Martha thought.

It was unlike her and made her feel a little distanced from herself—not in a bad way, maybe. She loved not having to sleep in a dorm, and she loved beffen, and Joost recited an existential Dutch poem to her:

> Why squirrel?
> Because in a tree he.

In Yangshuo, they fell in with some kids from Tel Aviv, who were sitting in a café playing whist (a card game that oddly existed only in Jane Austen novels and among groups of Israeli backpackers), and Martha wondered, Do they think we’re boyfriend-girlfriend?, and caught Joost’s eye. He didn’t seem to care. Maybe the pretense was comforting to him, too. The illusion of having a person who was your anchor to the world as it spun around you.

Sometimes Martha would look at Joost over dinner, her chopsticks poised in her hand, and think, After a week from now, I will never, ever see this person again, and then wait to see how she felt. A bit psychotic, actually.

“Shenme?” Joost would say in Mandarin. “What?”

She would reply, “This fish-flavored fish is pretty good to eat!” and give him a thumbs-up.

It was as if he were an experiment in not caring and, at the same time, in fucking. As if she were exploring the exact balance between having sex and giving a shit, like in an essay for one of her women’s-studies classes: *Explore the relationship/causality between being in love and achieving sexual satisfaction with someone. Are these necessarily direct values? Could it be argued that in some sense every sex act is a fleeting pantomime of love?*

From Yangshuo, they went to Guangzhou, where they both knew, although they didn’t talk about it much, that they would part ways. A backpacker never changed course for someone else. That was the only rule. On their first night in Guangzhou, while Joost was in the private shower attached to their room, Martha pulled her money pouch from the recesses of her pack and counted her traveller’s checks. She had four hundred dollars left, barely enough to get her to Taiwan. Joost planned to swing up the east coast to Shanghai, Hangzhou—places she’d seen already.

She didn’t want to go back to Beautiful Country. She wanted to keep being a giant eyeball. She’d decided to try Taipei, where, people said, you could easily earn twenty dollars an hour teaching English.

She sat for a while, not really thinking about that. Joost’s journal, bound in moss-green cloth, lay on the bedside table.

Something Martha admired about Joost, besides his unflappable amiability in the face of annoying situations, was the diligence with which he kept his journal, which he wrote in every morning as he drank his tea. She had a journal but wrote in it only sporadically, mostly to vent about her fights with street venders.

By now, at the end of their second week together, she'd begun to suspect that, one, Joost was secretly a romantic dude, and, two, he was some kind of aspiring writer, and, three, he unconsciously wanted her to read his journal.

He was almost dramatically evasive about the content of his entries—were they diaristic, observational, lyrical?—but he mentioned the journal often, making fun of himself for lugging around the six notebooks he'd already filled in, and saying that he wrote mostly in English because his favorite writers were Henry Miller and the Beat poets.

Also, he left it around.

The shower was still running—he was very clean. Martha picked up the journal and opened it to the first page.

In small, meticulous print, Joost described watching a girl in a miniskirt biking along the road, and how he was going to push her off her bike and pound her good with his big, hard cock and make her squeal like the whore pig she was. Martha turned the pages, finding more fantasies of Joost accosting girls in public places and humiliating them sexually, like Henry Miller but worse. It was at least, maybe, not racist, as some of the girls were white. She flipped through, looking for her name. Was she hoping not to find herself, or did a perverse part of her want to? Clashing forms of disgust made her feel something like motion sickness, and she dropped the book. She was shutting down, spiralling. She had to get out of the room—luckily, she hadn't unpacked yet. She grabbed her backpack and left the hostel.

She hurried to the main road, convinced that Joost was a serial killer and was following her. She ducked into the first side street, walking with no direction through an area of small apartment buildings, then through a street of restaurants with bright signs, alleys of tiny, ancient houses. She had an excellent internal map, and she loved to go nowhere, knowing that she was well enough oriented to find her way back. Usually, it soothed her, drifting quickly, absorbing the details of the world, the cat-sitting-in-a-window of it all, the way she could look and not belong. Now everything seemed fake, a setting made of cardboard.

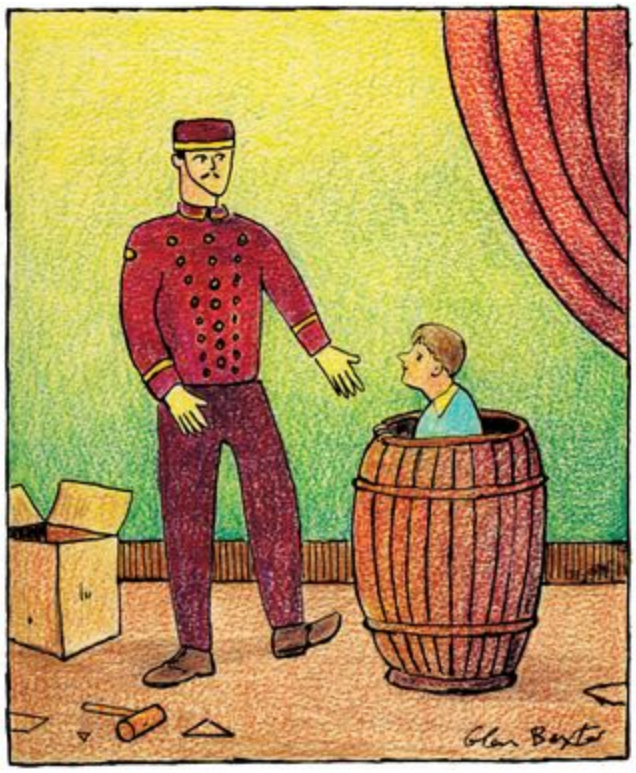
Were all men sexually gross? Why was everything so gross? Was that what it meant to be an adult, that you just accepted that everything was gross?

The thing is, another part of her brain chimed in, I didn't know that the last time we had sex was going to be the last time. And that's just kind of not fair.

Martha didn't want to be a prude. She and Joost were nothing to each other long-term. Did she really have to care that he had rapey fantasies? Couldn't she just sleep with him in a comfortable bed a few more times, eat, drink beer, and forget that she'd read that?

Night fell, and Martha came to a small black lake. From the shore, she could hear a brass band playing somewhere. The notes bounced over the lapping water, and people's voices came in fragments. It was one of those transient moments she lived for: something overwhelming about life seized her, and she experienced a kind of stunned bliss. But her back hurt from her lumpy pack, and she suddenly understood that there were people out there, groups of people who belonged together, families, friends, lovers, that she could hear but not see in this magical darkness by a lake. She was alone again. That was the trade-off for giving up her solitude—how she felt her aloneness when the other person was gone. If she walked into the lake and let her backpack drag her under and drown her, no one would care.

Here was the thing: Joost was good at sex, for someone who said he'd had only one girlfriend and few hookups—attentive, patient, persistent. With Tim, Martha hadn't often come during intercourse. She hadn't come much, really. She hadn't come at all. She had never once come while having intercourse with Tim. It hadn't seemed important. She'd felt like she might come. She was so in love; he smelled like a person and also like a freshly baked croissant. He was her total feminist dreamboat, a guy who, upon waking up to find all his clothes dirty, would be perfectly willing to wear some of her clothing to go to brunch. A boy who loved to dance, who let his curly hair grow wild, who never in his life called anyone bro, who was a music major with a minor in art history. More than this, or in spite of this, Tim was clever and silly. They had, as LL Cool J said, a lot of private jokes to share.



AFTER MANY HOURS OF TENSE NEGOTIATIONS, I WAS FINALLY ALLOWED AN UPGRADE.

Cartoon by Glen Baxter

And then, after four years together, Tim had dumped her, with the words "I'm sorry. I just really need to fuck someone else."

It happened at the Art Institute of Chicago. They were looking at collages by the artist Keiichi Tanaami in which some highly sexualized images of big-breasted women repeated horribly, like flashbacks. Martha was reading that Tanaami, a survivor of the Second World War, had been meditating on violence when he made these works. If repeated images of sexy women somehow equated to violence, she wondered aloud, what did that say about the male imagination? Were men traumatized by their own penises?

In a way, Tim replied, his sexual thoughts were as relentless as that. Like he didn't really control them; he wasn't driving the thing.

"Wow," Martha said, with a feeling of everything clicking into place. "You're describing P.T.S.D."

When she was nine, she had been in a car accident that had killed her mother. Splinters of memory still punctured reality when she was driving on the highway, and she would feel a compulsion to crash. That was how it sounded to her to be besieged by graphic sexual imagery at all times—so unrelenting, so unstoppable (because if you tried to repress it, it only got worse) that you might as well let the fantasies pass through you, the same way she occasionally noticed a racist thought in her mind and went, Well, that's not good, but now that I've noticed it I can let it go. Or something like that?

Tim said, "Yeah, pretty much." Then he looked serious. "Since you brought it up . . ."

Over the course of the next, endless day, Tim talked to her so candidly about his need to fuck other women and how he never thought about a single other thing that later, in the alone period after the dumping, Martha felt completely desexed. She was not a woman; she was barely human. She had transformed from being someone Tim wanted to fuck, and therefore lied to about his other desires, into an erotic nonentity to whom he could tell the truth.

She passed a lit-up restaurant, and there inside was Joost, drinking beer with some French backpackers they'd met before. With a rush of sick relief, she went in and sat down with them. She and Joost pretended that nothing had happened, drank Five Star beer, and laughed with the French people, but when they got back to the room, she said casually, "Do you hate women? I'm just wondering."

"You read my journal." Joost looked stricken but in a fake way, as if he'd thought about what his reaction should be. "You shouldn't have done that. It's a violation of my privacy."

Martha had guessed that he would say something like this and realized how completely she didn't care.

"We're about to go our separate ways, so if I'm an untrustworthy person, you don't have to worry about that ever again." Martha's father, a law professor, had trained her to be a rational, step-by-step arguer. Let the court

stipulate: I don’t care about invading your privacy and nothing you say will make me feel guilty about doing it. “But I am concerned that you write about raping people every day.”

Joost seemed to accept this. He was not an arguer at all. He sat down on the bed and said that he didn’t mean it, he just loved Henry Miller, so he pretended to be Henry Miller in his journal.

Martha sat down next to him. “But Henry Miller is terrible. He is, like, the worst writer.”

“I’ve always wished I could be a cool guy like him, though. Like a guy who has sex with lots of girls. But I never wrote that way about you.”

Now Martha was filled with a strange emotion she’d never experienced before, a tender, maternal pity. She felt such sorrow for the state of this man that she wanted to cradle him in her arms like Mary with the body of Jesus. She wanted to make a Pietà scene with Joost, emotionally, and hold him for a long time.

Another part of her knew that she absolutely did not want that. The whole reason she’d had sex with him in the first place was because it was temporary, and her stupid bimbo body couldn’t brainwash her into thinking that she loved him.

Martha and Joost said goodbye in the train station at the eastern end of Guangzhou, on the edge of China. He promised to write to her poste restante in Taipei, and Martha thought, Yeah, that’s not going to happen. They hugged for almost a minute, during which all she could feel was that this was the last time anyone was going to touch her for months, maybe years. She inhaled his chamomile musk and, horribly, tears sprang to her eyes. She really loved that existential poem about a squirrel.

She was the first to break away, turning and climbing onto the train without a word. From her seat, she watched him walk away, a hand on each strap of his technical European backpack, his feet splayed in well-worn Birkenstocks.

So that was that.

A woman with a teen-age daughter and glasses like a pair of headlights stared at Martha hungrily from the facing seat, as if she wanted to ask what a college education cost in America. As “The East Is Red” cranked up on the P.A. system, Martha bent over her pack and rummaged for “Gunnar’s Daughter,” the bloody Viking novel. Her torso had the strafed, torn-up feeling she usually got when she was fighting with a vender. She hoped that the ambitious-looking woman in the opposite seat would not try to speak English with her. ♦

Cassandra Neyenesch is the author of the novel “A Little Bit Bad” (May, 2026).

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The Critics

- **How to Measure the Good Life**
  By Becca Rothfeld | In a new book, the conservative pundit Arthur C. Brooks offers tips to “young strivers” on maximizing their daily meaning quotient.
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Books

How to Measure the Good Life

In a new book, the conservative pundit Arthur C. Brooks offers tips to “young strivers” on maximizing their daily meaning quotient.

By Becca Rothfeld

March 30, 2026

In “The Meaning of Your Life,” Brooks no longer trumpets free markets, extolls entrepreneurs, or praises work as “a blessing,” as he did in earlier books. Now he claims that the ambitious professionals he calls “young strivers” lead superficial and unfulfilling lives.Illustration by Pablo Amargo

The bromide has it that a liberal is a person who won’t take his own side in an argument. To this we might add a corollary: there is a certain kind of conservative pundit who has never really had a side to take. A creature of think tanks and business schools, galas and morning talk shows, he is assiduous about following the fashions of the right-wing establishment—at least, as long as they do not require him to relinquish his air of noncommittal politesse. In 2003, he opined on patriotism and national security, but never too rudely. In 2010, he railed against Obamacare, but never too peevishly. Now, in 2026, the peculiarities of the moment and the

spiritual extremities of Trumpism oblige him to discourse on the point of life and the nature of the good—a task for which he is remarkably ill-equipped.

No specimen of this endangered breed is more irritating or more exemplary than Arthur C. Brooks, whose new book, “The Meaning of Your Life: Finding Purpose in an Age of Emptiness” (Portfolio), strains to match the febrile mood of contemporary conservatism. On the face of it, Brooks looks like just the man for the job. In the course of a chameleonic career, he has proved himself a master of reinvention. At nineteen, he left college to play the French horn, eventually finding a position with the Barcelona Symphony Orchestra, and it was not until his late twenties that he earned a bachelor’s degree. During his studies, he “fell in love” with free-market economics and decided to pursue a Ph.D. in public-policy analysis at the *Rand* Corporation. Later, he would frame his unconventional origin story as proof positive of the capitalist concept. “I’m a living example of the happiness vocation can bring in a flexible labor market,” he wrote in the *Times*, in 2013.

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The flexible labor market has been good to him indeed. In 2009, after a stint in academia, he became president of the premier center-right think tank in the United States, the American Enterprise Institute. In this capacity, he demonstrated himself adept at flattering donors and chasing fleeting trends: initially, he championed a hard-line free-market agenda—but when Mitt Romney’s 2012 defeat kicked off the “reform conservatism” movement, he quickly fell in line. By 2015, Washington *Post* columnists were describing him as the “godfather of reform conservatism,” and in a best-selling book published that same year he promoted laissez-faire conservatism with a

compassionate face (and basic welfare protections). “I simply don’t buy the argument that Trumpism is characteristic of Tea Party supporters or conservatives in general,” he wrote in early 2016. “I look at the Republican governors. . . . Many are pragmatic, serious, non-populists. I could plausibly argue that this is the future of the movement.”

Rarely has a political prognostication proved so wrong. In 2016, Brooks could not even conceive of the spasms and breaches of etiquette that Trumpism would produce on an almost daily basis. How was he to navigate the brave new world that *MAGA* would build over the next decade? Some of his more spirited peers on the professional right, such as David Frum and Jonah Goldberg, declared themselves Never Trumpers; less honorable figures, such as Tucker Carlson, reimagined themselves as disgruntled men of the people and started dressing in plaid. Brooks, for his part, equivocated. He made some tentatively anti-*MAGA* gestures during the 2016 Presidential campaign, opposing Trump’s anti-immigrant rhetoric and interventionist economic orientation, but he quickly lost what little remained of his nerve. He walked back his critiques, hosted Vice-President Mike Pence at A.E.I., and eventually beat a retreat from politics altogether, installing himself at the Harvard Kennedy School and the Harvard Business School, in 2019.

A bout of frantic rebranding ensued. In 2020, Brooks began writing a popular column about happiness for *The Atlantic;* by 2022, he was commanding hefty speaking fees and churning out best-sellers. The business of happiness, he discovered, was booming. And make no mistake: it was a *business*. Brooks had been experimenting with an entrepreneurial approach to self-cultivation since at least 2015, when he confessed in a *Times* op-ed that he treated his courtship with his wife “as if it were a start-up.” Soon, he was urging his audience to think of themselves in similar terms. “The whole idea is that you are your own enterprise,” he told them. “You are the CEO of You, Inc.”

Brooks’s shift toward happiness was canny, and strategically timed: well-being, once the province of philosophers, had been thoroughly usurped by podcasters, data scientists, and influencers by the time he got his hands on it. Hellenistic thinkers, such as the Stoics, had once proposed, in the words

of the philosopher Martha Nussbaum, that “philosophy heals human diseases, diseases produced by false beliefs”—in other words, that by understanding and living in accordance with our nature we could achieve *eudaemonia*, which translates roughly to “flourishing.” Earlier thinkers, most famously Aristotle, had gone so far as to propose that *eudaemonia* was an inherently communal accomplishment, one that could only take root in the proper social and political context. But the social psychologists who catapulted to prominence in the early two-thousands were less interested in the richer concept of *eudaemonia* and more interested in a thinner, hollower, and vastly more individualistic enterprise of happiness, of simply feeling good. In 2006, two books by social psychologists—Daniel Gilbert’s “Stumbling on Happiness” and Jonathan Haidt’s “The Happiness Hypothesis”—set the latest wave of happiness studies in motion. But the written word was never the ideal medium for their particular message, and by 2026 innumerable podcasts had sprung up like mushrooms after a squall. There was “The Happiness Lab,” with Dr. Laurie Santos; there was “10% Happier,” with Dan Harris; and, inevitably, there was “Office Hours,” with Arthur Brooks.

These days, the C.E.O. of Brooks, Inc., appears to be thriving. He has acquired a jaunty wardrobe of loud suits and colorful pocket squares, and he exudes an avuncular charisma in videos he posts on YouTube. With the brisk, competent manner of a doctor prescribing medication, he assures his audience that his six-step morning “protocol” helps him manage “the negative side” of his “affect profile,” and expounds on “the science behind being good at leisure.” He has so thoroughly expunged his image of any unsavory political taint that he has co-authored a self-help book, “Build the Life You Want” (2023), with Oprah—and, as he never tires of informing his readers, paid a number of visits to the Dalai Lama. As of January, 2026, he had joined CBS News as a contributor and become a columnist at the anti-woke outlet *The Free Press*. His metamorphosis into social scientist-cum-sage appears to be complete.

In “The Meaning of Your Life,” he no longer trumpets free markets, extolls entrepreneurs, or praises work as “a blessing,” as he did in earlier books. Now he claims that the ambitious professionals he calls “young strivers”

lead superficial and unfulfilling lives. What they lack, in his view, is “the one thing that can never be simulated: *meaning*.”

“Seven and then door-close, door-close, door-close, door-close, door-close, door-close, door-close, door-close, and door-close.”
Cartoon by Paul Noth

There are any number of prospective material explanations for the young strivers’ predicament, and Brooks makes brief note of several, among them the punishing housing market and the imminent collapse of the social safety net. But calcified habits die hard, and rather than seriously entertain any of these explanations, or even clarify why he rejects them, he turns instinctively to what he knows best—dubious social science.

To make sense of the strivers’ malaise, Brooks relies on the work of Jonathan “Happiness Hypothesis” Haidt, whose 2024 best-seller, “The Anxious Generation,” argued that digital natives have been addled by excessive screen time. What he adds to Haidt’s account is a dash of questionable neuroscience: in his telling, “hemispheric lateralization,” the phenomenon whereby cognitive functions are localized in different halves of the brain, “explains the acute crisis of meaning today.” A nebulous alloy of smartphones, social media, and a lust for optimization has thrust society

into a “left-brained” orientation, forcing us to adopt a hyper-practical outlook. “The modern world of technology is literally changing the way people use their brains,” Brooks writes, “rendering them less and less capable of finding life’s coherence, purpose, and significance.”

Even though researchers have found no evidence that contemporary populations use one hemisphere of the brain any more than the other, every part of this picture is presented with slick confidence. Appeals to “the science” abound. Brooks is apt to fall back on that old assurance “studies show,” even when studies conflict—or, worse, when the very studies he cites do not show what he says they do. In his book “The Conservative Heart,” from 2015, for instance, he avers that monogamy yields happiness, then adds, “This isn’t my moral opinion; it’s what empirical evidence tells us.” The “empirical evidence” in question is a study showing that subjects with a single sexual partner have an average of 0.077 additional “happiness points.” But it also found that people who have sex four or more times a week, possibly with any number of partners, have 0.12, a fact that Brooks conveniently neglects to mention.

“The Meaning of Your Life” also contains its fair share of misrepresentations, as when Brooks muses that “the idea of opposites attracting might even be biological,” then cites a 1995 study that subsequent researchers have called into question. But no one reading the book will come away with the sense that studies are often contested, or that many of the findings of social psychology and economics remain unsettled, or that results can be interpreted in many ways. Like much popular social science, it makes no effort to prove or even to persuade. It simply asserts and instructs.

Its tone as it does so is distinctly infantilizing. Chapters are subdivided into digestible sections (“Get Bored the Right Way,” “Give More to Transcend Yourself”) and often end with homework, set aside in a little box, as in elementary-school textbooks. When Brooks is not offering “Questions for Reflection and Self-Assessment,” he is laying out “Three Big Things to Remember,” as if he were providing a study guide for the exam of a meaningful life. In his book “Love Your Enemies,” from 2019, he admiringly cites “The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People”—which he

describes, perhaps with a sense of defensive self-awareness, as a “masterpiece” that is not “just cheesy self-help.” Brooks, for his part, rarely imposes on readers by asking them to count as high as seven, perhaps assuming that “three major lessons from the science of morality” and “five simple facts” make more manageable mathematical demands.

Still, Brooks’s turn away from politics and toward a more therapeutic project has not been wholly unhelpful. His practical advice fares better than both his theories and his pallid attempts at profundity. In his columns, he recommends such commonsense remedies as a good night’s sleep and regular exercise. “The Meaning of Your Life,” in particular, contains several promising suggestions. Who would deny that we would all do better to turn off our phones, interact with other human beings, and maybe even go outside for a walk every once in a while? Brooks struggles, however, when he strays from the cozy precincts of self-help and into the rugged realm of philosophy.

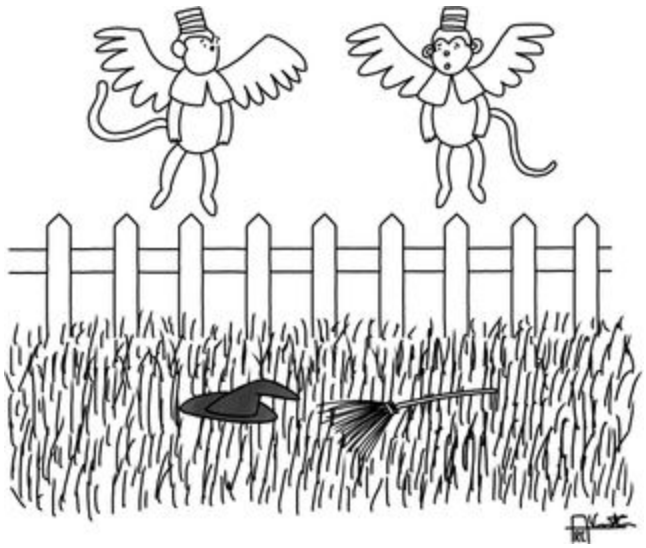
If his subject has shifted, his methods have lagged. Nothing in his background has outfitted him with the intellectual equipment to grapple with our “age of emptiness,” and at times he comes close to recognizing the inadequacy of his register and frame of reference. “In their technical excellence,” he concedes, “strivers trivialize their humanness by reducing life’s magnificent inscrutability to a series of complicated but solvable problems.” How do these remarks square with Brooks’s fondness for compressing expansive human goods into orderly formulas? In “The Conservative Heart,” Brooks wrote of “the happiness portfolio,” which consists of “faith, family, community, and meaningful work.” Now the portfolio has been supplanted by a less prescriptive and more schematic “happiness equation,” according to which “Happiness = Enjoyment + Satisfaction + Meaning.” (“Meaning” is further subdivided into “Coherence + Purpose + Significance.”) It is perhaps unsurprising that Brooks measures his body-fat percentage with calipers and keeps a dutiful record of his own happiness on a spreadsheet, assigning various elements of his life a number and then a force multiplier reflecting their importance. (How do his children feel knowing they command a mere eight out of ten importance points, but his faith and his marriage both rate a nine?)

Readers may resent being abstracted into algebra, but they are nonetheless invited to sort themselves into one of four categories on the basis of a short quiz. They might be Hopeful Wanderers, unsure of the meaning of their lives but in active search of it, or Happy Homebodies, so sure of the meaning of their lives that they have little need to search for it. Alternatively, they might be Relentless Seekers, who have some notion of the meaning of their lives but remain in search of it anyway, or, worst of all, Lost in Place, the sort that is neither sure of the meaning of life nor in any rush to find it.

It would be one thing if Brooks were reconciled to writing Enneagram tests, but “The Meaning of Your Life” is self-help that dreams it is philosophy. It makes a scattered show of its erudition in the form of drive-by efforts to project philosophical literacy. Only the aggressive carelessness that once enabled Brooks to write a column about how to “enhance your mood” with a playlist inspired by the unremitting pessimist Arthur Schopenhauer could have yielded his tortured misreadings of Ralph Waldo Emerson, Søren Kierkegaard, and Karl Marx. Friedrich Nietzsche once declared, “The discipline of suffering, of great suffering—do you not know that only this discipline has created all enhancements of man so far?” This doesn’t stop Brooks from summarizing Nietzsche’s position as follows: “There is no essence to life, so the secret is to have fun and not worry too much about it.”

But none of these ornamental flourishes can conceal his fundamental incuriosity. “Until recently,” Brooks writes hazily, of the meaning of life, “the definition probably wasn’t so important, because of the way people lived, just naturally going about life in ways that delivered meaning every day.” Which people? How recently? Readers of “The Meaning of Your Life” could be forgiven for thinking that despair was invented in 2007, the year the first iPhone was released. Brooks has no interest in the broader sweep of history and, indeed, no apparent knowledge of the philosophical accounts of encroaching meaninglessness which have been on offer for centuries—the 1785 letters in which the German philosopher Friedrich Heinrich Jacobi developed the idea of nihilism to describe the etiolation that accompanied the Enlightenment, for instance, or the fin-de-siècle

sociologist Max Weber's lament about how modernity shattered a formerly coherent world.



"Did you forget to turn off the automatic sprinklers?"
Cartoon by Amanda Chung and Vincent Coca

Nor is Brooks any more inquisitive about remedies for meaninglessness than he is about its origins. "The Meaning of Your Life" is the clearest possible demonstration of the extent to which the old think-tank mode, with its conspicuous show of reasonableness and its distaste for unseemly convulsions, is incongruous with the existential questions roiling contemporary conservatives (and not just conservatives) since Trump's election in 2016. How should we live? What is the nature of the beautiful, the good, and the true? What Brooks proffers is not the philosophy these queries require but a kind of pharmacology—a pill designed to alleviate every last pang.

It is striking that, in a book that is ostensibly about meaning, nothing approaching a positive picture of meaning ever emerges. Brooks ventures no substantive defense of the practices he recommends. Instead of exhorting readers to adopt any particular belief, he presses them to refrain from the rigors and responsibilities of commitment, urging them to "refuse to participate in ideologically polarized culture." Moral and political causes seem like precisely the sorts of things that might afford a person a sense of meaning—but they provoke some measure of dishevelment, so Brooks renounces them in favor of more soothing stratagems. The logic he prefers

is vulgarly instrumental. You should do things not because they are in fact valuable but because they generate meaning, which produces an enjoyable tingle. It is not because religious doctrine might be true that you ought to keep an open mind to what Brooks anemically calls “a metaphysical dimension to your life”; it is because “you will benefit.”

“You will benefit” (preferably in a chemically measurable way) is this book’s single promise and its overriding concern. Religion is good—because “recalling spiritual experiences lowers activity in the medial thalamus and caudate nucleus (brain regions controlling sensory and emotional processing).” Beauty is good—because psychological research outlines “well-being strategies using music or art.” Suffering is good—because “a belief that happiness requires an absence of suffering undermines happiness itself.” Romantic love (and, in some cases, marriage) is good—because it yields an influx of “the neurotransmitters norepinephrine and dopamine” and activates “the ventral tegmental area, nucleus accumbens, caudate nucleus, insula, dorsal anterior cingulate cortex, and dorsolateral prefrontal cortex,” all of which sound alarmingly contagious.

Philosophy, too, is pummelled into profitability. It is worthwhile because a foray into the “big questions . . . stimulates numinousness,” as if thinking were a hormone. What “Socrates meant when he said, ‘the unexamined life is not worth living,’ ” Brooks explains, is that “a life that is not deeply questioned is bereft of meaning.” But surely it is relevant that Socrates and Plato asked “big questions” not because they sought to increase their daily meaning quotient but because they cared about the answers. Might it be that pursuing love and religion primarily because they induce “pleasant feelings of warmth in the chest,” as one Brooks-approved psychologist puts it, prevents us from attaining them at all? If my husband told me he married me to get his ventral tegmental area thrumming, I would file for a divorce immediately.

Brooks’s discomfort with those pesky “big questions” is hardly surprising. After all, he came of age during a brief period when the liberal order seemed durable and secure. The watchword was “neutrality,” a doctrine according to which the state must remain ecumenical about differing

conceptions of the good life. Policies were justified not with reference to morality or metaphysics but with citations of white papers. Even those who advocated for conservative positions were compelled to make their case in language amenable to the liberal sensibility. But Trump's election proved that a sizable contingent of the population had no problem imposing their values on others—and even hoped that the government might do so for them. As the reactionary pundit Sohrab Ahmari wrote in a 2019 essay that has become one of the founding documents of the so-called post-liberal movement, the aim of the state is to produce "a public square re-ordered to the common good and ultimately the Highest Good."

The think-tank set was not prepared to tackle the common good, much less the Highest. Brooks has never even had the temerity to endorse what he is nominally endorsing: he eschews all convictions, save those about what makes people feel better according to "The Science" and its henchmen, "The Studies." How convenient, then, that the things that make us feel better are all conservative staples! Brooks, Inc., may have changed its advertising, but it has not quite abandoned its old politics. Brooks is still wont to assume that social crises are a function of our personal habits, not economic or political injustice, and his methodological tics are the same as ever. Free enterprise was a moral imperative in 2013 for the same reason that falling in love is advisable in 2026: because the "empirical evidence" shows that it tends to make us happier.

What's changed in the intervening years is certainly not the ubiquity of this style of argument. (Even the other Brooks in political media, David, helps himself to this mode of justification on occasion, encouraging Americans to wed because "married people are 30 points happier than the unmarried.") What's changed is the cultural environment in which these wan pleas ring out. The post-liberals are calling for the Highest Good, and even capitalizing it Germanically—and there goes the think-tank brigade, clinging to the forms that predominated during the liberal consensus, making a point of their neutrality and apologetically suggesting that the numbers forced them to come out in favor of Christianity. Their solution to Trumpism is to tackle the new problems, but always in the old tone.

Arthur Brooks, in particular, has made a career of elevating his noncommittal waffling into a warped kind of virtue. In “Love Your Enemies,” from 2019, a book that he completed as he was on the cusp of his supposed pivot away from politics, he dismisses moral argument as futile. “You aren’t going to change [anyone’s] mind through the force of argument any more than I will make my wife start liking cilantro by trying to force enough of it into her mouth,” he writes. Then he tells readers to “make your moral discussions with most people like the cilantro at our family dinner,” that is, treat ethical disagreements as trivial. As it happens, he has chosen the textbook example of what ethics are not like. Morality is not simply a matter of taste, of chocolate or vanilla. It transcends personal preference—and getting it right matters.

“I am not going to try to convert you to my religion,” Brooks writes in “The Meaning of Your Life,” before regaling us with neuroscientific findings about the health of religious brains. I almost wish he had. Reading Brooks, in all his fatal mildness, I could start to see how the ominous Highest Good might come to seem so appealing. A fanatical belief in *something*—and the irrepressible urge to proselytize that goes with it—is far more invigorating than the all-encompassing blandness of the therapeutic imperative. The post-liberals stand for cruelty and inanity, but Brooks can’t admit to standing for much of anything at all. ♦

Becca Rothfeld joined The New Yorker as a staff writer in February, 2026. Previously, she was the nonfiction book critic at the Washington Post.

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Books

The Ample Rewards of Ben Lerner’s Slender New Novel

In “Transcription,” a novel about memory and influence, an interview with an aging intellectual goes unrecorded. Or does it?

By Giles Harvey

March 30, 2026

A broken iPhone means no recording, but the novel, as Lerner shows, is a recording device more comprehensive than any machine.Photo illustration by Alex Merto

Several years ago, when I was profiling Ben Lerner for the *Times Magazine*, I spent an afternoon with him at the Whitney Museum. As we walked from room to room, Lerner spoke in freely flowing paragraphs about the paintings on the walls and the memories they stirred in him, much like the narrators of his form-breaking autofictions, who often find themselves looking at art. The parade of styles, of homage and revolt, from the chromatic frenzy of Pollock and de Kooning to the deadpan rigor of Ruscha and Johns, led to the question of Lerner’s formation. Because many of his major forebears were women (Rosmarie Waldrop, Eileen Myles,

Juliana Spahr, C. D. Wright), he believed he'd been spared the anxiety of influence, which, in Harold Bloom's telling, is largely patrilineal. The idea struck me as a little too neat. Of course, there was also John Ashbery, a presiding spirit in his body of work. Lerner, a prodigy, published three books of verse before, at the age of thirty-two, turning to fiction, the form in which he has made his reputation. Shifting to prose, he'd suggested earlier, was his way of creating distance from Ashbery, whose echo resounds in those earlier texts. If this wasn't anxious, it was hardly relaxed.

The following day, I uploaded the interview, recorded on my iPhone, to Otter.ai, a recently launched transcription service, hoping to save myself hours of work. Instead, as I skimmed the results it quickly spat out, I was seized by panic. The lucid discussion I remembered now read like a stream of dissociative drivel. Here was Lerner speaking of his interest in "generic hunting scenes, medical art, or occasional genitalia." Later, he mentioned a "Bolivian account" that was "very invested in a gong strong father," adding (no less puzzlingly), "He was asked to be an edible drama." Elsewhere, Lerner seemed afraid that a threatening figure named "Gaspar" was "going to kill me responding to my fiction." It was like something from one of his novels, which are filled with moments of semantic vertigo, when everyday language stops making sense and starts to resemble an Ashbery poem.

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As I soon came to grasp, with a shiver of relief, these glitches were caused by the A.I. "mishearing" what, to human ears, was perfectly intelligible. "Gaspar," I realized, playing back the audio, was Ashbery; the irony Lerner noted was that the poet "who counted to me" in such a significant way—not "who was going to kill me"—had responded with enthusiasm to his fiction, not his poetry. The "Bolivian account" that was "invested in a gong strong

father” was actually a “Bloomian account . . . invested in an agon of strong fathers.” For Bloom, Lerner had said skeptically, poetic influence always “has to be an Oedipal drama,” not an “edible” one. (“Occasional genitalia” was harder to explain.)

Oedipal dramas really are at the center of Lerner’s new novel, as are the bugs in recording technologies. “Transcription” (Farrar, Straus & Giroux), which presents a darker vision of influence than the one that Lerner shared with me, is the story of an interview and its unexpected fallout. The interviewer is an unnamed writer in early middle age, the usual Lerner proxy. He has travelled from New York to Providence, Rhode Island, to speak to an old mentor for a magazine. The mentor is Thomas, a world-renowned author, philosopher, and filmmaker who grew up in Nazi Germany and rubbed shoulders with twentieth-century giants such as Theodor Adorno. As a Brown undergraduate, the narrator took one of Thomas’s classes, which marked him indelibly. Now, more than twenty years later, the *COVID* pandemic has the world in its grip. Thomas, who is ninety, has recently survived a bout with the virus. It’s been decades since he sat for an interview, and this one, we sense, may well be his last. The stage seems set for a solemn farewell—the first in a series of sly indirections.

Like Lerner’s previous protagonists, the narrator is something of an intellectual klutz, at once Chekhov and Chaplin. Preparing for the interview in his hotel room, he knocks his iPhone into the bathroom sink, breaking it. He has no other means of recording the conversation, but instead of telling Thomas—the prospect is too humiliating—he hatches a face-saving proposal: this evening, they’ll just catch up off the record before conducting the interview proper the next day (once the narrator has bought a new phone). Thomas has no objections, but when the talk turns naturally to the subject of his childhood he wonders if they shouldn’t start recording: “Otherwise we repeat ourselves and it grows unnatural.” Helplessly, without explanation, the narrator suggests that they stick to the plan. “But here we are talking,” Thomas says, asserting authority, in his starched yet expressive Continental English, which Lerner renders faultlessly. “So we begin, OK?” Thus ensnared in a fiction of his making, the narrator takes his phone out and pretends to press Record.

In Lerner's work, which abounds with liars, fiction begets fiction. As the night wears on, and Thomas shares an archive's worth of memories and wisdom, we come to feel the narrator's giddy dread: all this precious speech is being lost, going unpreserved for future generations. Except here it all is, page after page of luminous table talk. "There is always music playing that we cannot hear," Thomas says in one of his impromptu arias about voices and vibrations:

> We did not know that elephants spoke until someone accidentally sped up a field recording—at least we Westerners had no idea. But none of us truly knows what's in the air; that is one of few universals. A negative universal. The air is alive with messages. Messengers, angels.

And so the irony of Lerner's title comes brightly into focus: since there was no recording, there can be no transcription. What we are reading, instead, is the narrator's reconstruction, a volatile compound of the fictive and the real. Much like the Socrates of Plato's dialogues (which the novel frequently alludes to), Thomas, in a sense, is the narrator's invention.

But it isn't just the narrator making free with his sources. Thomas bears a resemblance to, among others, Alexander Kluge, the acclaimed author, philosopher, and filmmaker, who was also born in Nazi Germany and knew Adorno. Kluge's intentional muddling of fiction and reality, his alertness to the humor of intellectual chatter, and the way he uses photos in his texts are all features that Lerner has adopted. In 2017, when Lerner interviewed him for *The Paris Review*, Kluge was full of metaphysical drolleries ("It would be arbitrary to say that we cannot know anything about angels just because they very rarely come into laboratories"), which now sound, paradoxically, like Thomasisms. A transcript, which appears to be authentic, is reproduced in "The Snows of Venice" (2018), a hybrid work of fiction, poetry, and roving dialogues co-authored by Lerner and his precursor.

"Transcription," you could say, is the inauthentic transcript of Lerner's dialogues with Kluge. The book reworks him—a new specialty here, a change of address there—in a way that resembles what its narrator does with Thomas. (Kluge, for instance, has never taught at Brown, Lerner's alma mater.) In "The Snows of Venice," fiction, poetry, and interviews are labelled as such; in "Transcription," you're never sure what's what. As with

all of Lerner's novels, the book is formally unstable, "a work that, like a poem, is neither fiction nor nonfiction, but a flickering between them," as he wrote in "10:04." Lerner rightly insists that "the correspondence between text and world" matters less than the "intensities" of the text itself. Yet, as with a leaf insect or a fata morgana, those intensities arise, time and again, from our never quite knowing what, exactly, we are looking at.

"Penne, Rigatoni, and another one that I don't recognize."
Cartoon by Edward Steed

There are further instabilities at play in the text. When the narrator asks Thomas about his Hitlerite parents, a subject he's previously been keen to avoid, he replies, "I am happy to speak of my family. And they speak through me." The same thing goes for the writers of the past, who speak through their inheritors. The narrator, we notice, can sound a lot like his mentor. How much our voices are really our own is a question the novel obsessively circles. If Thomas, so to speak, is his mentee's invention, the reverse may be true as well. Kluge, too, can take credit for Lerner. For it was Kluge, along with Ashbery and the others, who showed Lerner his potential fully realized and embodied. "The young man reveres men of

genius, because, to speak truly, they are more himself than he is," as Emerson wrote in his essay "The Poet."

According to Harold Bloom, however, reverence is not an attitude that leads to great art: it leads to counterfeits and knockoffs, to Coldplays and De Palmas. "Weaker talents idealize; figures of capable imagination appropriate for themselves," he writes in "The Anxiety of Influence." Or, to put it another way (and putting it another way, for Bloom as for Lerner, is the essence of innovation): weaker writers transcribe; stronger ones, having broken their iPhones, creatively recast. It's a process that involves a necessary betrayal. Thomas is at once an intellectual hero and a kind of surrogate father to the narrator. Still, in the way of many great men, he is "not uncomplicated." Haughty and irascible, he uses refinement as a screen for aggression, a habit his protégé disloyally records. When the narrator asks if the radio was really "always" on in the house where he grew up, as Thomas has claimed, he loftily retorts, "It is maybe silly to be so literal now? It is late for the literal, no? We practice literature, not law."

One person who does practice law is Thomas's actual son, Max, with whom, we gather, he is not on good terms. "He became very angry at me recently for my forgetfulness," Thomas cryptically explains. "He angers easily. That is from his mother." As we soon learn, Max's mother was bipolar and killed herself when he was still a young child. The wound of this loss appears to have reopened following Thomas's experience with *Covid*. Scattered and unsteady, he begins to come unmoored. "You accuse me, it seems," he tells the narrator, apparently mistaking his student for his son. (The two were friends at Brown.) "That I could not bring down your mother—" The narrator tries to correct him, but Thomas's fugue keeps gathering momentum. "That she has to put stones in the pockets, that she exchanged the medium of air for water. And yes, that I was distant in my research." Nothing makes his distance more tangible than the pompous euphemism "air for water."

Words, Lerner shows, lead double lives, including the one he has taken for his title. To transcribe is not simply to make a written copy (whether faithful or not); it is also to convert a text or a piece of music into a different form. Thomas, like Kluge, is steeped in Kafka, whose fiction the novel repeatedly

invokes. Yet, as becomes clear during Thomas's meltdown, what Lerner is doing goes beyond mere allusion: he is performing a kind of free-jazz cover of Kafka's "The Judgment." In that brief, hallucinatory story, a young man suggests to his ailing father that it's time to retire. Enraged by this perceived usurpation, the old man disowns him, claiming that one of his son's best friends was the child he'd truly wanted. Then, in a startling turn, he sentences him to death—an order the son obediently follows.

In "Transcription," too, we have a fearsome patriarch, a struggle for authority, a son by blood and a son by spirit. The difference between Kafka and his heir—between canonical source and hectic transcription—is more than a matter of Lerner's reshufflings; it is a matter of his view toward difference itself. In Kafka, change is unthinkable. "So you were lying in wait for me," the son says in "The Judgment," grasping that he was doomed from the start. In Lerner, there is always a margin of hope.

Resisting despair, both private and social, has long been central to Lerner's mission. "Leaving the Atocha Station" (2011), his début novel, channels a mood of cultural stagnation. Adam Gordon, its poet narrator, lies about everything except his own fraudulence ("that I *was* a fraud had never been in question—who wasn't?"), but what saves the book from being merely symptomatic is his closeted idealism. This idealism gets a wider berth in "10:04" (2014), whose narrator, another shifty poet, is forever catching glimpses of how things might be. As a tropical storm bears down on New York and subway riders show sudden camaraderie, "what normally felt like the only possible world," he says, "became one among many, its meaning everywhere up for grabs." That sense of possibility was forced back underground in "The Topeka School" (2019), which confronts the disaster of Trump's first election. Set mainly in nineteen-nineties Kansas, during Adam Gordon's childhood, the novel suggests that the so-called end of history, complacently proclaimed by the era's centrist pundits, was actually the seedbed of our crypto-fascist present.

"Transcription" represents a tactical retreat. The novel, Lerner's shortest to date, is a chamber piece, more compressed and crystallized than any of its predecessors. As it was during the pandemic, the wider social world is mostly just a rumor. What we see of it comes filtered through screens—or

reflected in the lives of the people it's unravelled. Later in the book, after Thomas has died, the narrator visits Max at his home in California, where another hypnotic two-hander unfolds. In a subtle reworking of Kafka's "A Hunger Artist," Max recounts how, before the pandemic, his young daughter, Emmie, was afflicted by *arfid*, an eating disorder. Emmie's condition is an interpretative riddle for both her parents and the reader. How does it connect to the rest of the novel? Is she starving herself, Max desperately wonders, "because she is registering a sense of futurelessness, catastrophe—fires, floods, fascism?" In fact, it may be more about the past.

A third sense of "transcription"—what occurs during gene expression, when the information in a strand of DNA gets converted into protein—is now deftly drawn out. The process involves the selective activation of what's been handed down, which is one way to think about Emmie's condition. Lerner, who has two young daughters, has spoken of the parallels between writing and parenting. Both involve reshaping old patterns inherited from forebears (literary, familial) in an effort to form new ones. Thomas, it seems, was an imperfect father. We recall his words from the novel's first section, intended for Max but delivered to the narrator: "I sound angry but I think it is yours, the anger, reflected in me." It is hard to imagine a more infuriating statement, especially from one's father. Whatever its source, the anger has clearly echoed down the years, from one voice to another. Thanks to Lerner's mastery of the novel—the most capacious recording technology invented so far—we come to understand Emmie's disorder as the latest variation on an age-old theme. Once this pattern has been recognized, new ones can begin to be formed.

But if anger has a long half-life in this book, then so does love. At the start of the pandemic, Thomas is hospitalized with *COVID*, placed on a ventilator, and seems certain to die. "Emmie will carry you with her, she loves you so much, the love goes on forever in both ways," Max tells him by phone, that last phrase borrowed, whether wittingly or not, from a video his daughter has been watching for school. (In the original, it is geometric lines that "go on forever.") Thomas is unable to speak, but a nurse reports that he'd seemed to understand. Delivered of his message, Max feels at peace—only to hear later that his father has pulled through. When he visits him, it's unclear what, if anything, Thomas remembers, and Max feels

unable to repeat what he'd said. They argue, as usual; and so the "good" ending, when the words had come out right, is replaced by this bad one.

Except nothing in this exquisite, shape-shifting novel is quite what it seems—words least of all. For Lerner, language is both a symbol and the medium of human reciprocity, a long collective poem we each assume is ours alone. Max's argument with his father, it slowly grows clear, is what Thomas had been stewing on when the narrator went to see him. As we begin to reread, dissociative drivel is jolted into meaning. "To forgive each other we must acknowledge that these forces are too great," Thomas says to the man he's mistaken for his son. "That *die Familie*, it is a tiny station in a grid. Economic and electric. Or a dish, receiving from space. The love, it must go on forever in both ways." ♦

Giles Harvey, a contributing writer at the Times Magazine, began writing for The New Yorker in 2011.

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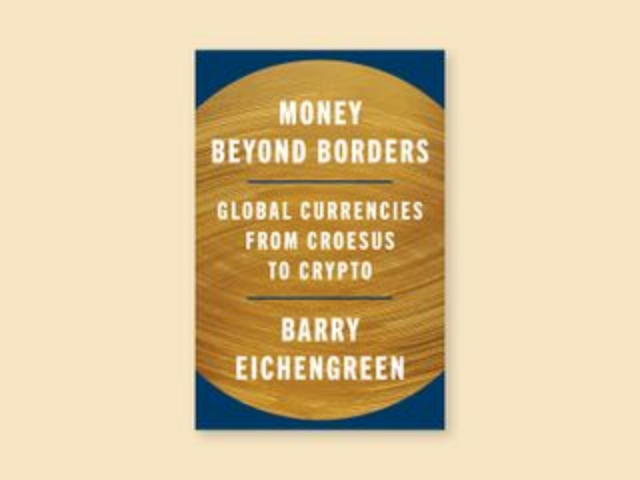
Books

Briefly Noted

“Kids, Wait Till You Hear This!,” “Money Beyond Borders,” “A Beautiful Loan,” and “Spoiled Milk.”

March 30, 2026

Kids, Wait Till You Hear This!, *by Liza Minnelli, as told to Michael Feinstein (Grand Central)*. Early in this unvarnished memoir, Minnelli—the daughter of the director Vincente Minnelli and the tormented entertainer Judy Garland—muses, “Was life perfect with my parents? With Papa, yes. With Mama? Stay tuned.” Here, Minnelli, whose cultural footprint extends from television to pop music, chronicles her efforts to establish a career on her own terms, avoid the drug dependencies that afflicted her mother, and reckon with the “intense highs and anxious lows” that have defined her life as a performer. Even dark memories are recounted with an upbeat touch: “I was a Chrysler, honey! Just order up some new parts for me, and you’ll get me back on the road.”



Money Beyond Borders, *by Barry Eichengreen (Princeton)*. The international economy relies on the U.S. dollar, a fact that rewards American banks, businesses, policymakers, and people. As this sweeping history points out, however, the greenback is only the latest in a centuries-long series of global currencies, including the Dutch guilder and the British pound sterling, whose statures have risen and fallen with the fortunes of their issuers. For now, Eichengreen argues, none of the dollar's would-be challengers, from the renminbi to digital alternatives such as stablecoins, have what it takes to supplant it. But, as America's debts pile up and its relative wealth and power decline, the dollar's appeal may fade.

What We're Reading

Illustration by Henri Campeã

Discover notable new fiction, nonfiction, and poetry.

A Beautiful Loan, *by Mary Costello (Norton)*. “I have been trying to account for certain events in my life,” Anna, this novel’s forty-five-year-old narrator, tells us by way of introduction. The events in question revolve around her relationships with two men: Peter, an older, aloof Irishman whom she met at nineteen and soon married; and Karim, a warm, devout Muslim from Algeria whom she dates after her marriage falls apart. The two couldn’t be more different, but Anna sees both as a means to freedom from “all the outer chaos.” Peter’s penchant for solitude and Karim’s commitment to Islamic rules each seem to offer Anna the buffer and order she desires, but not without a price. This psychologically raw record of one woman’s life explores the consequences of orienting oneself in relation to another.

Spoiled Milk, *Avery Curran (Doubleday)*. The backdrop of this chilling début novel is the Briarley School for Girls, a regimented institution housed

in an imposing English estate. “The bells governed our lives,” Emily, the teen-aged narrator, explains, as do the mistresses, who strictly impose propriety. The tragic death of a prized student, however, sets loose something wicked—food begins to rot, people start to disappear, and those who remain become unrecognizable. In search of answers, Emily and her friends find themselves consulting paranormal expertise, in the form of “mediums, and crystal balls.” Brimming with spiritualism and sensuality, this neo-gothic story navigates the terrain between life and death, and between childhood and adulthood.

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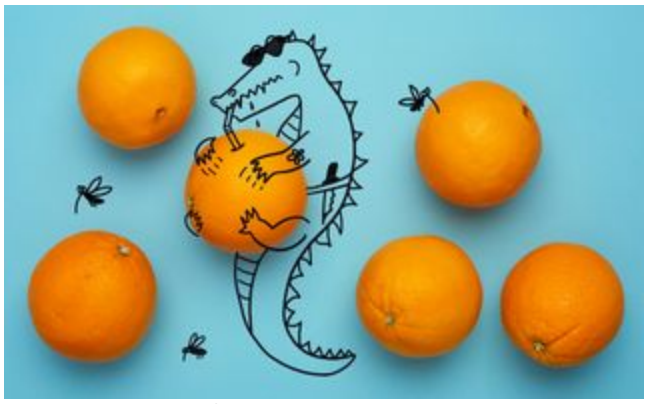
On and Off the Menu

Kia Damon’s Audacious Florida Cooking

A young Black chef from Orlando conjures a distinctive image of her home state, beyond the loud luxury of Miami and the kitsch of the Keys.

***By** Hannah Goldfield*

March 30, 2026



Kia Damon’s cooking conjures a vision of Florida that’s steeped in Black history.Photo illustration by Jason Fulford and Tamara Shopsin

Around lunchtime one recent Friday, the chef Kia Damon stood in front of a produce display at a Publix grocery store in St. Cloud, Florida, bobbing her head like a d.j. “Yeah! Yeah! Take a shower!” she said, holding a finger in the air as a sprinkler system released fine sprays of mist onto neat rows of cabbage and kale. “Me next!” Damon, who wore loose denim overalls with a baggy T-shirt and a vintage Orlando Magic hat, was eager to cool off: we’d just spent several hours on an airboat tour of the marshes of Lake Tohopekaliga, scanning the waters for gators and herons under the high glare of the sun.

Like Wawa, in Pennsylvania, and H-E-B, in Texas, Publix—founded in 1930 by a former Piggly Wiggly manager in Winter Haven, Florida—is a regional chain that commands an almost religious devotion. “There was a

summer that I spent living with my mom when my mind was really clouded, my heart was really clouded," Damon, who is thirty-two and grew up in Orlando, told me. "My brain was, like, Just need to go to Publix." After perusing some locally made products—including Falling Iguana hot sauce, named for the stunned reptiles that drop from trees during cold snaps in South Florida—we got in line for Pub Subs, as the chain's beloved sandwiches are known. For the past few years, Damon's order has been jerk turkey with spinach and creamy Havarti on a multigrain hoagie roll; for a first-timer, she recommended a sub with chicken tenders, which get chopped up to insure optimal distribution. "I don't trust other people's delis," Damon said, watching an employee behind the counter wrestle butcher paper around a heaping foot-long sub. "I trust what's happening here."

Publix is one of the many Florida fixtures that Damon takes very seriously. In her early twenties, after a few years of cooking in Tallahassee, she moved to New York, where she was briefly the executive chef at a California-inspired, Mexican-ish restaurant called Lalito, and then the culinary director of the women-in-food magazine *Cherry Bombe*. Almost immediately, she determined that being a Floridian was a liability: "They're, like, 'Oh, so is it true that y'all eat gator? Is it true that everyone over there is a redneck?' " She dreaded being stereotyped as "trashy" and "backwards," but she also resented the assumption that she looked down on where she'd come from. " 'You're just running away to the North from Florida because you hate it,' " she recalled people saying.

Her initial instinct was to clam up about the place she still considered home. Over time, she began to see the potential in doing exactly the opposite. As a descendant of Africans who were enslaved on Florida plantations, she felt that the state was underappreciated as part of the American South's Black history, including its Black culinary history. Like many Southerners, Damon grew up eating barbecue, gumbo, and hush puppies; she also adored foods more specific to Florida, such as stone crab and datil peppers—a fruity, spicy variety cultivated in St. Augustine, where a free settlement for escaped slaves was established in the eighteenth century, and where Damon's mother and grandmother were born. In 2022, she organized the Florida Water Tour, a series of dinners at restaurants in New York and other

cities, featuring dishes that evoked classic Southern cooking and Florida's sticky, tropical climate: root-beer-braised turkey necks, green beans cooked in coconut milk, roast chicken bronzed with earthy, bright-orange achiote, also known as annatto.

Online, Damon has cheekily adopted the label of Florida Woman—an epithet more likely to evoke antics of the "Tiger King" variety than those of an earnest Black millennial—and sells nineties-style "Floridacore" T-shirts in homage to such institutions as Publix and Waffle House. The recipes that she develops for her social-media accounts and for the *Times* and *Southern Living* magazine deftly combine her worldly palate and her reverence for tradition. In the caption for an Instagram post about fermenting boiled peanuts into miso, she joked, "I'm living George Washington Carver's wildest dreams."

The marsh tour and the Pub Subs were part of a meticulously planned itinerary that Damon had deemed a Big Florida Weekend—a primer for the uninitiated, and also a research trip for her forthcoming début cookbook, "Cooking with Florida Water: Recipes, Stories, & History of the Unsung South." Currently, she lives in Savannah, Georgia, where she works as the culinary-operations manager for Grey Spaces, the restaurant group co-founded by the chef Mashama Bailey. On her days off, Damon steeps herself in Floridiana, studying vintage cookbooks like "Florida Fixin's," from 1992, and "The Gasparilla Cookbook," a pirate-themed volume, published in 1961 by the Junior League of Tampa, that includes recipes for Cuban shrimp creole and grapefruit-aspic salad.

As an aspiring "stewardess of Floridian history," Damon is as enthusiastic about the state's most polarizing dishes as she is about its obvious crowd-pleasers, aiming to conjure an image of Florida beyond the loud luxury of Miami and the kitsch of the Keys. Her book will include an adaptation of the Orange Crunch Cake served at the Bubble Room, a campy restaurant on Captiva Island, and a recipe for crab chilau, the unofficial dish of Tampa, a spicy Sicilian-Afro-Cuban seafood stew. But there will also be a fried-gator po'boy and backwoods deep cuts like raccoon with sweet potatoes. "I had to make a decision. I was, like, Either it's possum, it's raccoon, or it's squirrel," Damon told me. "I don't think I could fit all three in there."

From Publix, we drove to Crystal River, in Citrus County, where, after an appropriately chaotic central-Florida afternoon—I briefly lost my rental-car keys in a wildlife refuge, stranding us until Damon persuaded an indifferent park ranger to help rescue them—we ended our day on the patio of a waterfront restaurant called the Crab Plant. As the sun set, and no-see-ums and mosquitoes began to feast on our bare skin, we split half a pound of steamed stone-crab claws, forking the slippery, tender meat from their shells; a pile of plump, cornmeal-crusted fried frog legs, which tasted like chicken with the texture of a firm-fleshed white fish; and a slick, snappy sausage made from gator cut with pork. Damon was especially interested in a creamy smoked-mullet dip, which was served in a small deli container with a side of crackers. Despite its reputation as a bait or "trash" fish (in the sixties, Florida's conservation board tried to rebrand it as "Lisa"), the oily, strong-tasting mullet is so central to the state's cuisine that Damon is considering having one tattooed around her left kneecap.

Damon knows that few of her readers are likely to try her recipes for mullet or raccoon or gator, even if she includes tips on where to order each frozen online. For her, that's no reason not to publish them. She showed me an unedited headnote from the book, a defense of chitlins, or stewed pig intestines, a dish that she studiously avoided every New Year's Eve for the first twenty years of her life. "There's a joke amongst Black southerners that goes 'We don't gotta eat chitlins anymore because we're free,' " she writes. "Why eat slave food? . . . But there's more to it than that. At least to me. The value in chitlins is how enduring the recipe is. We're talking centuries of true farm to table, whole animal eating."

The next morning, we stopped at a gas station near Damon's mom's house for breakfast: fried chicken gizzards, fried fish, and cheesy grits pooled in butter, served in Styrofoam containers. We were on our way to the Florida Strawberry Festival, an annual event in a place called Plant City, the sort of extremely on-the-nose name that is common in Florida. (Damon was beside herself to learn, during one of our drives, that Orlando is situated in what was once known as Mosquito County.) It was at her first strawberry festival, Damon told me, that she became conscious of her state pride. "We're driving into Plant City, and, the closer you get, you start to see all the strawberries everywhere, and the place looks like Candy Land," she

said, describing a uniquely Floridian mix of agricultural splendor and theme-park excess. As we made our way through an exhaustive list of everything she wanted to eat, including a buttermilk corn dog and a strawberry-crunch funnel cake that she'd seen on TikTok, a man about her age stopped her and asked how he knew her. It turned out that they'd worked together, in high school, in concessions at Universal Studios—a rite of passage for Orlando teens—serving Butterbeer at a Harry Potter-themed pub.

The last and most important item on Damon's list was the strawberry shortcake from St. Clement Catholic Church, which runs a make-your-own station every year. (A sign advertised the parish as "Trinity Centered, Discipleship Driven. . . . . & Shortcake Emphatic!") Women wearing green aprons, with white doilies pinned to their heads, presided over comically huge metal mixing bowls of freshly whipped cream and locally grown berries, which we spooned onto small rounds of cake. "Over time, folks have been, like, 'Oh, I don't really care for the St. Clement shortcake, it's just O.K.,' " Damon said. "But for whatever reason it's always a ten out of ten to me. It's never not delicious."

To some, the Plant City fairground, pungent with the scent of livestock and swarming with people in strawberry-themed clothing, might have verged on nightmarish. It was hard to find shade; each car on an enormous Ferris wheel was emblazoned with the face of a different U.S. President. When the heat began to break, late in the afternoon, a welcome breeze turned sinister as it kicked up dirt, covering our sunscreened arms and faces in a thin layer of grime. But Damon was in her element, bounding around in a "Dirty South" jersey, a cowboy hat fitted atop the bandanna she had tied around her head. "This is it," she had told me the day before, as we got into the car with our Pub Subs. "This is Florida. You're hot. You're overstimulated. The A.C. isn't going on fast enough." Still, she said, "I wouldn't bother being from anywhere else." ♦

Hannah Goldfield, a staff writer covering restaurants and food culture, received a 2024 James Beard Award for her Profile of the chef Kwame Onwuachi.

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On Television

“Jury Duty Presents: Company Retreat” and Age of the Prestige Prank Show

The series, returning for a second season, is the latest example of a new breed—one that relies on elaborate, full-immersion experiments rather than on one-off stunts.

By **Inkoo Kang**

March 27, 2026

“Jury Duty” refers to its unsuspecting main character as the “Hero.”Illustration by Andrea Chronopoulos

Three years ago, the quasi-scripted comedy “Jury Duty,” an unassuming offering on the now defunct streaming service Freevee, became a social-media sensation through its particular brand of gentle brazenness. Its creators, Lee Eisenberg and Gene Stupnitsky, Frankensteined the series by stitching together two moribund TV genres—the mockumentary sitcom and the prank show—to construct something new, if still lumbering. Cameras followed a handful of actors serving as the jurors in a fake trial alongside one unwitting civilian, a thirty-year-old solar contractor named Ronald Gladden, who believed that he was taking part in a straightforward documentary about the workings of the justice system. Surrounded by weirdos, losers, and a preening movie star (James Marsden, playing a fame-monster version of himself), Ronald spent three eventful weeks on his very own “Truman Show.” At one point, he came perilously close to the truth, declaring, “This literally feels like reality TV.”

Since the days of “Candid Camera,” a practical-joke program that began on the radio in 1947 and jumped to television the following year, prank shows have been critiqued for their exploitative dynamics. “Jury Duty” strives to reassure the audience by portraying its production as a fair trade: though the show deceives its main character, it also presents him in a favorable light, takes pains to minimize his distress, and insures that jokes are never at his expense. (Gladden also received a hundred thousand dollars and an over-all deal at Amazon for his trouble.) The series’ carefully curated feel-good vibes seemed to exceed even the novel premise as the primary source of its appeal: one review praised its “life-affirming joy.” But that very quality renders the follow-up, the awkwardly titled “Jury Duty Presents: Company Retreat,” unnecessary. Like so many sitcoms before it, it withers under the force of its own unrelenting sunniness.

The sophomore season, now streaming on Prime Video, features a whole new cast, who play the tight-knit employees of a Los Angeles-based hot-sauce company called Rockin’ Grandma’s. Ronald’s successor at the center of the story is Anthony Norman, another young man with an open face and an inviting disposition. Early on, Anthony is told by the company’s H.R. chief, Kevin (Ryan Perez), that he’s been hired as a temp to help out at the annual staff retreat—the last such event for the firm’s founder, Doug (Jerry Hauck), who plans to retire. Poised to take over is his thirtysomething son,

Dougie (Alex Bonifer), a failed ska-E.D.M. musician with a mop of bleached hair to match, who intends to implement some changes to the family business.

Season 2's grander ambitions are evident from the start. While the original "Jury Duty" largely took place in a courtroom and in a hotel where the jurors were sequestered, leaving the cast drably entrapped, "Company Retreat" feels less cloistered. The employees of Rockin' Grandma's roam the grounds of the retreat site, which boasts multiple structures, and are visited by a series of guest speakers whose lectures range from the merely dull to the truly Dada. After Dougie bombs a presentation and gets dressed down by his father, he flees into the nearby hills to lick his wounds. The actors' hours-long commitment to the bit continues through meticulously choreographed stunts and persists even when they leave Anthony's sight line.

These hyper-dedicated cast members are "Company Retreat" 's greatest asset. Rockin' Grandma's is compared, without irony, to a family, and its "employees" feel more distinctive than the stock types who populated the first season. The most memorable include a warehouse manager named Jimmy (Jim Woods), who's intent on reforming his boorish ways but still can't help blurting out faux pas, as when he calls Martin Luther King, Jr., "the Tom Brady of civil rights." A receptionist and aspiring snack-fluencer, PJ (Marc-Sully Saint-Fleur), who offers Anthony some octopus-wasabi chips on his first day, could be the most popular guy in any workplace. Even Dougie, an inveterate screwup, isn't without hidden depths—and Anthony, a natural hype man for whoever's around, takes his plea for emotional support seriously, quickly becoming invested in a twisty succession crisis.

Eisenberg and Stupnitsky cut their teeth in the writers' room of "The Office," and "Company Retreat" occasionally evokes the misadventures of a young Jim Halpert, who tries to politely stifle his laughter while the people around him engage in delusional or over-the-top behavior. Anthony's tolerance for nonsense is clear on Day One, when he high-fives Kevin for planning to propose to a co-worker in front of the entire staff. It soon emerges that the pair hadn't even been on a single date, and the public

proposal goes accordingly. But the incident doesn't seem to affect Anthony's regard for the head of H.R., or his esteem for the company as a whole. Too often, the season asks the audience to see this as evidence of Anthony's unstinting optimism, rather than the quality they must have cast him for: an apparent inability to recognize red flags.

"Jury Duty" 's blend of comedy and reality has garnered comparisons to "The Rehearsal," in which Nathan Fielder mounts elaborate run-throughs of difficult situations. Both series, building on the work of Sacha Baron Cohen, could be thought of as a new breed: the prestige prank show, which utilizes practical jokes to get at higher truths. Baron Cohen is best known for the "Borat" movies, in which he plays a disarming lout whose antics expose the prejudices and injustices that his targets are willing to accept or partake in. Where he stitches together one-off encounters, Fielder, Eisenberg, and Stupnitsky devise sustained, full-immersion experiments with the potential to change the lives of their subjects. In the first season of "The Rehearsal," participants use their practice sessions to allay anxieties or to optimize strategies. In the second, Fielder takes this to a systems-level extreme, suggesting that playacting among pilots could break down the hierarchical cockpit dynamics that he believes correlate with plane crashes.

Though Fielder's methods and hypotheses are frequently absurd, he captures something real about human nature. The regular people featured in "The Rehearsal" don't always come off looking good: many are stiff, strange, or downright dickish. "Jury Duty," whose scripts refer to the unsuspecting main character as the "Hero," is hamstrung by its insistence on protecting its protagonist. When the show received a Peabody Award, in 2024, it was commended for illustrating that reality television can "bring out the best in all of us." But this, too, is a consequence of casting—and of producers and editors working overtime to hide the seams that someone like Fielder might prefer to flaunt. Anthony's decency is a foregone conclusion; in fact, he never exhibits anything less. To stack the deck further, and to spur their champion into action, the writers throw in a sinister trio of private-equity investors who might as well arrive twirling their mustaches. If Dougie can't hack it as Rockin' Grandma's next C.E.O., the vultures are more than ready to swoop in.

It isn’t hard to buy that Anthony’s a good guy, and he’s so charismatic that you can forget, for long stretches of the season, how little else there is to define him. But even as the rest of the ensemble’s subplots become increasingly complex—and their high jinks increasingly overwrought—he remains a blank slate. Eventually, it becomes impossible not to wonder how he came to Rockin’ Grandma’s in the first place, and where he hopes to go from here. He’s a young dad, a transplant from Tennessee who’s been working odd jobs for years. Are the lengths to which he’ll go to ignore the weirdness of his new gig and make a positive impression all about being “good,” or is this a desperate audition for full-time employment that will never come? The show, with its interest in corporate buffoonery, doesn’t quite manage to hand-wave away the queasy implications. The harder it pushes for a black-and-white vision of morality, the more shades of gray appear. ♦

Inkoo Kang, a staff writer, has been a television critic for The New Yorker since 2022.

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A Critic at Large

The Unseen Work of One of Iran's Greatest Filmmakers

For the director Mani Haghighi, his country's rich cinematic tradition is a family affair.

***By** Richard Brody*

March 27, 2026

"Because of Kiarostami, everyone expected simplicity from Iranian cinema," Haghighi has said. "Because of Panahi, a critical and social approach. And the same for Farhadi: a social cinema, a linear narrative." His own work is different.Illustration by Adams Carvalho

Since 2012, only one country has won the Oscar for Best International Feature twice: Iran. The achievement is all the more remarkable for the stringent censorship that filmmakers in the Islamic Republic face and also because, in this category, the Academy (unlike, say, the Golden Globes or the National Society of Film Critics) considers only official submissions from national film boards, one per country. This means that filmmakers out of favor with autocratic regimes—including, in Iran, some of the nation's greatest artists—don't stand a chance, and some of the most notable recent Iranian films have been submitted by other countries. One of this year's nominees, "It Was Just an Accident," by the dissident Iranian director Jafar Panahi, was the entrant for France, where several of its co-producers are based; Panahi, who has been imprisoned for his activism and was banned

from filmmaking in 2010, has since shot his films clandestinely. In 2024, another director, Mohammad Rasoulof, fled to Germany after being sentenced to a flogging and eight years in prison; the final film he made before leaving, “The Seed of the Sacred Fig,” received an Oscar nomination last year, having been submitted by Germany.

Yet, like the Academy, the movie business at large has its blind spots; some of Iran’s best films remain unrecognized in the United States. At New York’s Iranian Film Festival, which was held three times between 2019 and 2025, I saw two films by the director Mani Haghighi—“Pig” (2018) and “Subtraction” (2022)—and reviewed both enthusiastically. Few critics have had the chance to agree: “Pig” had only a nominal U.S. release, and “Subtraction” is still unreleased here. Yet both movies are worthy of mention alongside anything released during that time, and I wouldn’t hesitate to call Haghighi’s 2016 feature “A Dragon Arrives!” one of the greatest films of the twenty-first century. It played in a handful of American film festivals in 2016 and 2017 but has never been in theatrical release or available on streaming here. For those in the U.S., appreciating Haghighi’s œuvre currently involves trawling the web for bootlegs, but the more of his work I’ve watched, the more convinced I am that he is one of the world’s most interesting and most woefully underrated filmmakers.

Iranian movies have been among the treasures of world cinema long before the Oscars deigned to take notice, of course, and also before the Islamic Revolution installed the current regime, in 1979. Haghighi’s films, like those of his distinguished peers, emerge from a grand tradition that goes back more than sixty years, to the days of the Shah, who, in 1953, consolidated his despotic rule over the country in a coup backed by the U.S. and Britain. The Shah’s Western orientation extended to culture, and a wide range of artistically important international films could be seen in Tehran, in time including those of the French New Wave. During the political and artistic ferment of the nineteen-sixties, Iran was one of many countries that developed a homegrown New Wave. Iranian cinema came to international attention with a short documentary about a leper colony, “The House Is Black” (1962), directed by one of Iran’s most revered modern poets, Forugh Farrokhzad, which won a prize at West Germany’s Oberhausen festival; Ebrahim Golestan’s 1965 feature, “Brick and Mirror,” which was acclaimed

in *Cahiers du Cinéma*, the crucible and house organ of the French New Wave; and Dariush Mehrjui's "The Cow," from 1969, which won a major award at the Venice Film Festival and is often cited as the first film of the Iranian New Wave.

In 1969, a local event proved even more cinematically consequential than international recognition: an organization called Kanoon, dedicated to children's culture, appointed a young graphic artist named Abbas Kiarostami to launch a film division. He made playfully inventive educational shorts, soon expanding his scope to features exploring the lives of both children and adults, often with an ambiguous blend of documentary and fiction. Such films as "Close-Up" (1990) and "And Life Goes On" (1992)—the first Iranian film to be shown at the New York Film Festival—established his worldwide reputation as one of the cinematic masters of symbolism, metaphor, allegory, and irony. In 1997, his film "Taste of Cherry" was a co-winner of the Palme d'Or at Cannes. Kiarostami's work, and the prominence it brought to Iranian cinema, energized younger directors and gave them a platform. Panahi, who began his career as Kiarostami's assistant, made his first feature in 1995, and the first years of the twenty-first century saw the débuts of Rasoulof and of Asghar Farhadi, whose later films "A Separation" (2011) and "The Salesman" (2016) brought Iran its two Best International Feature Oscars.

Haghighi, born in 1969, is a contemporary of Rasoulof and Farhadi and, like Panahi, worked with Kiarostami early in his career. But the great heritage of Iranian cinema is, for Haghighi, more than an influence: it's a family affair. Haghighi's father, Nemat, was a cinematographer, and his mother, the gallerist and translator Lili Golestan, is the daughter of the New Wave trailblazer Ebrahim Golestan. Haghighi went to university in Canada, studying philosophy, before returning to Tehran to begin his film career, making documentaries and commercials; his first two features, "Abadan" (2003) and "Men at Work" (2006), were shot cheaply, in small-format digital video. The latter, a wry comedy of futile endeavor, was based on a story by Kiarostami, but Haghighi soon sought to shake off Kiarostami's influence—and, even more, a prevailing caricature of Iranian cinema that Kiarostami's style had given rise to. Kiarostami had made films mostly with nonprofessional actors, often about rural people of modest means. As early

as 2003, Haghighi said, “There has been a pressure to emulate that Kiarostami touch, which, of course, is impossible.” When “Pig” was released, he was quoted as saying, “I still love many of these films, but I feel a little crushed by the weight of their heritage on the Iranian cinema.”

After his first feature, Haghighi suggested to Farhadi that they team up and break with this tradition, working with professional actors in stories about their own milieu—the urban middle class. Their first collaboration, “Fireworks Wednesday” (2006), which they co-wrote and which Farhadi directed, was a success. Another, “About Elly” (2009), won international acclaim; again, Farhadi directed, and this time Haghighi co-starred, also pitching in on the script, uncredited. (Rachel Aviv has detailed, in this magazine, the pair’s stressful partnership.)

Steeped in international cinema, Haghighi has since taken familiar tropes, forms, and genres and bent them in new directions. His two most recent films, “Pig” and “Subtraction”—the first of his that I saw—are so different that I doubt whether a viewer who didn’t know would guess they were by the same director. “Subtraction” is a descendant of the films of Alfred Hitchcock, a taut thriller about a Tehran couple who find that another couple in the city are their doppelgängers and who, in attempting to unravel the mystery, get entangled in the other family’s life. “Pig” is a playfully anarchic yet gory comedy about a Tehran-based filmmaker named Hasan who has been banned from making films. While he’s earning a living directing commercials, directors who are still making features are being targeted in murderous attacks in which their foreheads are carved with the Persian word for “pig.” Hasan frets that his reputation is insufficient to make him a target; instead, he becomes a suspect, after a rival director is killed.

Haghighi’s “Canaan” (2008), a bourgeois melodrama based on an Alice Munro story, was another collaboration with Farhadi, who was a co-writer. Here, after his ultra-low-budget earlier films, Haghighi discovered the emotional power of the precision that he could achieve with professional resources at his disposal. The film also showed an important difference between his approach and Farhadi’s. Where Farhadi concentrates on the script and the actors via images that are largely transparent and neutral,

Haghighi truly thinks with the camera. The movie teems with closeups, from which he derives an extraordinary variety of moods and compositions; actors' frozen gazes, seen in fixed framings, suggest the inner life in action.

His next film, "Modest Reception" (2012), was another exercise in bending genre, albeit a genre of recent vintage—that of Kiarostami's many road movies. Its personal significance is trumpeted by the fact that Haghighi plays one of the two lead roles, a man named Kaveh who is being driven by a woman, Leila (Taraneh Alidoosti), to a remote, wintry mountain region. The film begins with the pair in their car, a squabble already in progress as they reach a police checkpoint, where the dispute becomes so heated that they risk arrest. They find an odd way out of the jam—opening the trunk, grabbing plastic bags filled with cash, and throwing them at the officer, who overcomes his bewilderment to gather the loot as the pair drive off. It turns out that the duo have undertaken their rustic journey with the aim of divesting themselves of two hundred bags of cash—to distribute huge, life-changing jackpots to individuals throughout the area, and to record the handovers in photos and videos. The random recipients are naturally suspicious: How can these weird benefactors be on the level?

Leila and Kaveh improvise their way through each encounter. In effect, they're an itinerant theatre troupe of two, concocting ever more eccentric, reckless scenarios to coax or fool or frighten their audience into taking the money. Sometimes they present themselves as a couple, sometimes as siblings, and their schemes involve manipulation, cruelty, and destruction; they set brother against brother, tear down a peddler's stall, and disrupt a burial. Haghighi's robust and outgoing manner usually makes him an appealing onscreen presence, but here his glib bonhomie is diabolical. The pair are chaos agents who, in conferring the benefit of sudden wealth, lure the recipients into corruption. (The story also winks at Golestan's last film, "Secrets of the Treasure of the Jinn Valley," from 1974, in which a farmer's discovery of buried treasure corrupts him and his neighbors.) Chronicling an obsession that leads to calamity, "Modest Reception" leaps out of its realistic style and into the realm of the irrational and the symbolic, pointing the way toward the dizzying layering of the masterpiece of Haghighi's career so far, "A Dragon Arrives!"

“A Dragon Arrives!” expands a simple premise—the investigation into the death of a political prisoner under the Shah’s regime—into a pan-historical jamboree, a breathtakingly imaginative abundance of narrative strands, a thrilling, revelatory complex of adventures and ideas that is also a compendium of Haghighi’s themes, styles, and ideals. The story is principally set early in 1965, on the stark desert island of Qeshm, in the Strait of Hormuz. A youthful plainclothes detective named Babak (Amir Jadidi) arrives to investigate the death of a man who’d been living there in internal exile, in the shored-up hull of a beached seventeenth-century ship. The death looks like suicide, but Babak suspects murder.

“No way—I also want five hundred children.”
Cartoon by Jason Adam Katzenstein

After Babak has the victim buried, a superstitious local warns him that this will bring disaster and he must leave. He stays anyway, and a mysterious earthquake strikes the grave. Babak recruits two men from Tehran to help investigate: a geologist and a hippieish sound recordist for movies. Another officer stationed on the island—terse, formal, and frighteningly chilly—does his best to impede the investigation, but the three sleuths make an interesting discovery: the victim, despite his hermetic existence, was involved with a local woman, and, while they are there, she dies in childbirth. A member of the Shah’s terrifying secret police, the *savak*, turns up and interrogates the trio; though they risk arrest or worse, they’re loath to abandon the newborn.

“A Dragon Arrives!” leaps among time frames with a deft assertiveness that’s both clear and suspenseful. Recordings of the three men being

interrogated provide the basis for flashbacks, and scenes set in Tehran's artistic beau monde of the late sixties show the aftermath of their adventures. (The film delights in the period styles of fashion, equipment, cars; an orange Chevy Impala is practically a character.) Haghighi also launches the story back beyond the Shah's regime into earlier eras of Persian culture and into the history of Qeshm itself, where the English explorer William Baffin was killed in 1622. Inspired in part by Roberto Bolaño's novel "The Savage Detectives," these strands are explored through a polyphony of voices; the present day is brought to life by way of documentary-style interviews with real-life people telling ostensibly true stories. As playful as the movie is, its central tale of persecution and resistance plays not like an allegory but like a communion, a linking of the times—the inspiration of conscience by the revelation of past heroism, political and artistic.

The film's fanatical attention to detail, whether in the rugged and remote island's metaphysical conundrums or the labyrinthine logic of the investigation, is more than a matter of style; it's at the core of the movie's political morality. The plot pivots on tiny gestures involving matters of life and death. It would be cruel to divulge the details, but, after a scene of climactic violence, Haghighi delivers one of the most exalted point-of-view shots I've ever seen, of a sunrise, discerned beyond the banal edge of a car door, that's one of the cinema's most serene and glorious affirmations of being alive.

Haghighi's tale of three men and a newborn hints at John Ford's "3 Godfathers," but its true cinematic forebear is his grandfather Golestan's "Brick and Mirror," which is about a Tehran taxi-driver named Hashem who is left with a baby after a passenger abandons it in his back seat. The connection between the films goes far beyond the presence of a foundling. The sound-recordist character in "A Dragon Arrives!" has supposedly worked on Golestan's movie, and in some of the documentary-style scenes Haghighi discusses "Brick and Mirror," illustrating his points with clips from it. He even claims that his own film originated in a chance exploration of Golestan's archives and elaborates this fanciful tale with more faux interviews, including one with his (actual) mother. Even Haghighi's daring sense of form—his cornucopia of tones, styles, and genres—reflects his

grandfather's masterwork and suggests an expansion of Golestan's audacious and original aesthetic.

Before Golestan directed films, he was a writer, translator, and photographer, and his wide-ranging artistic experience is evident in "Brick and Mirror" in a multiplicity of tones, moods, and subjects—a variousness that frees this straightforwardly realistic tale from dramatic convention. He subtly anatomizes the Iranian society of his day with a nightmarish vision of poverty in the area where the baby is abandoned; loose talk at a night club where Hashem seeks guidance from his friends but receives conflicting advice; bureaucratic intransigence at a police station and a maternity ward; and a bravura half-hour sequence, in Hashem's apartment, of romance and negotiation with his girlfriend, Taji. Above all, there is a remarkable scene in which Taji, who wants him to adopt the child and raise it with her, visits an orphanage.

This documentary-like episode, which would be a noteworthy short film in itself, is also a point of contact with that other harbinger of the Iranian New Wave, Forugh Farrokhzad's leper-colony documentary, "The House Is Black." In 1958, Golestan, having just opened his own studio, hired Farrokhzad, who was already well known for boldly candid love poetry, as an assistant. They soon became lovers, and their relationship—he was married, she was divorced—was the talk of literary Iran. When Farrokhzad decided to make her documentary, Golestan produced it. The finished film features voice-overs by both of them—Golestan's informational, Farrokhzad's lyrical. The couple stayed together until Farrokhzad's untimely death, in a car crash, in 1967.

The directness with which the camera meets the eyes of the film's subjects suggests compassion for their disfigurement and isolation (indeed, Farrokhzad adopted a boy from the colony), but there are no interviews. Farrokhzad's context is less social than cosmic. This is a kind of existential documentary, in which psychology is elided in favor of a confrontation with concealed, unbearable truths and with a form of cruel beauty that defies social norms. Farrokhzad's camera is unsparing and tender as it surveys the faces and limbs of the afflicted and reportorially curious in its view of the colony's medical, educational, and recreational activities. Numinous plein-

air compositions, showing the patients around the institution's grounds, assert the irresistible force of nature. That sense of freedom—of the gaze, of emotion, and of expression—is part of what made Farrokhzad the Iranian New Wave's confrontational exemplar. She was a prime source of inspiration for Kiarostami, whose 1999 masterwork, "The Wind Will Carry Us," borrowing its title from a poem of hers, is a tale of the natural powers of sex and death that are stronger than religious and political strictures.

Haghighi, in setting "A Dragon Arrives!" in the mid-sixties, soon after Farrokhzad's and Golestan's classic films were made, historicizes his portrayal of a brutal police state. But his harking back to the early years of the film tradition in which he and his contemporaries still work has other resonances, too, revealing contemporary Iran's indelible connections to the culture of the pre-Revolutionary era. For Haghighi, the ongoing effort to explore long-sealed mysteries and reveal hidden byways of history—the quest for truth in the face of a regime that suppresses it—is, for all its dangers and difficulties, a joyful act of liberation.

When "A Dragon Arrives!" was released in France, in 2017, Haghighi was asked how he hoped it would be received. He spoke of the "very particular expectations from everyone in France or Europe" for films from his country: "Because of Kiarostami, everyone expected simplicity from Iranian cinema. Because of Panahi, a critical and social approach. And the same for Farhadi: a social cinema, a linear narrative." He sought to show "a more complex aspect," even as he rightly deemed his film "completely political." He achieved his goal artistically, but his movies have yet to be widely recognized as a distinctive cinematic universe; perhaps their variety of genres and tones has been an impediment for critics, programmers, and other gatekeepers. His themes intersect with those of Kiarostami—an anti-authoritarianism that, though no less radical, is an ironic, self-deprecating one.

Haghighi has taken a stand against censorship and repression not only in his movies but also by personal example. In 2022, he was among the signers of an open letter denouncing police violence against protesters, which was posted on social media by Rasoulof and another Iranian director, Mostafa al-Ahmad. After the pair were arrested, Haghighi also co-signed a letter of

protest—as did Panahi, who, in turn, was arrested and imprisoned. The international film community—including the Cannes, Berlin, and Venice festivals and the American Cinematheque—spoke out against these persecutions. On September 13, 2022, in Tehran, a young woman named Mahsa Amini was arrested on the ground that her hijab was too loose; after a beating by police, she went into a coma, and, on September 16th, she died. Protests arose throughout Iran; Haghighi recorded a video in support of the protesters. In mid-October, Haghighi was at the Tehran airport and about to travel to the London Film Festival to present "Subtraction," but he was prevented from boarding his flight and his passport was confiscated.

Interviewed soon thereafter, Haghighi continued to criticize Iran's government—but he also felt that cinematic allies worldwide, with their statements of support, were exerting their energies in the wrong direction: "The only thing they accomplish is to give the international film community the false sense that they 'played a small role' in helping us." Haghighi's perspective was institutional and involved practical, decisive official action from the mainstream of world cinema: "Real support takes place when the Oscar Academy stops asking government bodies to nominate films for the best foreign-film category." He added, "Gestures are useless." ♦

Richard Brody, a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of "Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard."

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Poems

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Poems

The Great-Grandmothers

***By** Sandra Lim*

March 30, 2026

One paid the rent with a row of her teeth.
The other hacked off her Bible-black hair

for a glass ring, then just as quickly
shattered it in a fit of temper. She was always

on the side of men. They both know so much
about the world, being out of it now.

One says, God can always see you
with his unfeeling precision. A hiss under all speech.

The other says that the sky is black,
then blue, and always empty. Or as clear as a window,

if you prefer. You can do anything you like.

This is drawn from "The Givens."

Sandra Lim is the author of the poetry collection "The Curious Thing," among other works.

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Poems

Following Bashō's Narrow Walk Into the Interior

***By** Bob Holman*
March 30, 2026

Take a moment to
Remember the poet who
Passed here long ago

Much was made of it
So much that it disappeared
This is all that's left

Not saying goodbye
An ineluctable truth
Not moving moves me

No one can stop it
The world eases out a cloud
Now everyone believes me

I follow ant muse
As it moves across the page
Into this poem

Can it now be told?
Perfect day. Wind dividing
Summer from autumn

Memory made real
Embracing last rays of sun

Something you once said

Sun opens its eye
Day radiates elongates
This is all I know

Unripe persimmons
Wafting in the cooling breeze
I sit and I watch

Persimmons falling
My old body follows the
Good old daily grind

Sweat drops on journal
It’s a long trek this fall day
No time to read or write

Up among mountains
Fall fog dampens, colors fade
The road never ends

Zen garden selfie
My eyes can’t bear to focus
Brown leaf on gray stone

There is Emptiness
& then there is Emptiness
Surrounding itself

White water-filled spheres
Floating in a rock garden
Ah! Whose dream is this?

Painting turns into
River turns into clouds that
Turn into painting

Backward just in time
Forward into the unknown
Chrysanthemum leaf

Look quickly before
Someone comes by and says stop
Then write it all down

Bob Holman is the founder of the Bowery Poetry Club. His solo poetry show, with Mivos Quartet, is "Life Poem."

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Puzzles & Games

- **The Crossword: Monday, March 30, 2026**
  By Anna Shechtman | A challenging puzzle.

Crossword

The Crossword: Monday, March 30, 2026

A challenging puzzle.

***By** Anna Shechtman*

March 30, 2026

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Anna Shechtman is an assistant professor of literature at Cornell, an editor-at-large at the Los Angeles Review of Books, and the author of "The Riddles of the Sphinx: Inheriting the Feminist History of the Crossword Puzzle."

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